The Editorial Page: On H1-B visa issue, read between the lines of US put-down and Indian riposte 10

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CROWD GATHERS IN CONNAUGHT PLACE IN RESPONSE TO CJP CALL FOR TRICOLOUR MARCH

Over 100 detained after protests against CEC, Opp demands release of Dipke, Bora

Heavy police bandobast in heart of Capital, CJP founder detained ahead of march

Pragynesh, Drishti Jain, Sophiya Mathew, Alok Singh & Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, October 16

POLICE DETAINED more than 100 people, including Cockroach Janta Party founder Abhijeet Dipke and All India Students' Association president Neha Bora, as protesters gathered in and around Connaught Place in the heart of the Capital Friday evening, responding to the CJP call for a 'Lehra Do Tiranga' march to demand the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

An estimated 2,000 people, many of them carrying the Tricolour, showed up amid heavy police bandobast around Central Park, the site chosen by the CJP for the protest.

Dipke was detained from Karol Bagh ahead of the march and Bora shortly after she tried to march from Mandi House. With the CJP and AISA expressing concern on their whereabouts late at night, the Opposition — from DMK to SP, TMC to Congress — demanded their immediate release and criticised the government and the police action.

A flash protest was also »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



'Lehra Do Tiranga' march at Connaught Place in New Delhi, Friday. GAJENDRA YADAV

Cong, allies want regime change on lines of Bangladesh: Rajnath

That is Opp's job, part of democratic process, says Cong

Lalmani Verma & Jatin Anand
Lucknow, New Delhi, Oct 16



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh in Lucknow, Friday. VISHAL SRIVASTAV

THE BJP Friday targeted the Congress and its allies over protests in Delhi, accusing them of seeking a "regime change" like in Bangladesh and using the energy of the youth to spread "anarchy". Countering the ruling party, the Congress said former President Pranab Mukherjee used to say that the Opposition's job in a democracy is to "oppose, expose, and depose".

At a press conference at the BJP headquarters in Lucknow, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh criticised the protests by the Congress and its allies seeking the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and a halt to »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Month after July protest, Centre set up panel for sites away from Jantar Mantar

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, October 16

THE DENOTIFICATION of Jantar Mantar as a designated protest site, a challenge against which will be heard by the Supreme Court in the coming days, did not happen overnight.

The denotification followed recommendations by a committee formed by the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) on August 20 — exactly a month after the Cockroach Janta Party's march from Jantar Mantar towards Parliament on July 20 — to examine alternative venues for protests in the Capital.

On October 12, Delhi Police denotified Jantar Mantar as a designated protest site and identified three alternative venues — Ramlila Ground, Burari Ground and CBD Ground — for protest gatherings in the Capital. Police attributed the change to recommendations made by the committee.

The panel, headed by New Delhi Municipal Council chairperson Manoj Kumar Dwivedi, had senior officials of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, Delhi government, Delhi Police and the MHA as its members. »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

'HAVE BEEN DENIED MARKET ACCESS FOR A DECADE'

China's trade barriers a big hurdle: FM; let's work on it, says Beijing

Imbalance growing exponentially, but we believe in talks, not punitive action, says Sitharaman

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, October 16

AMID RISING global trade pressure on China, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said Friday that India's trade imbalance with the world's second-largest economy is "growing exponentially" and requests for market access have been denied for a decade.

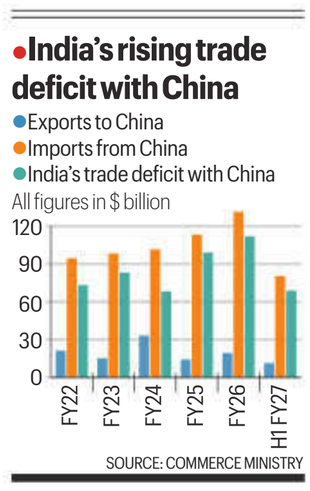
She said that while tariffs and other punitive actions have been the global approach to trade imbalances, India does not believe in them and prefers to "sit and talk". »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman in Bangkok. ANI

EXPLAINED

The widening gap

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said China uses non-tariff barriers unhesitatingly. India's trade deficit with China in first 6 months of 2026-27 was $69 billion, 27% more than in the corresponding period of 2025-26.



Business as Usual
By EP UNNY



INSIDE PAGE 9



JAISHANKAR TO HOST UAE DY PM, RUBIO IN MUMBAI NEXT WEEK

NILEKANI-LED PANEL MULLS QUESTION VAULT

Happening today

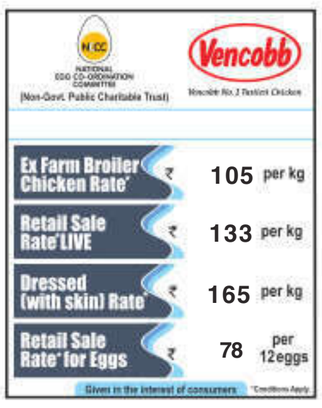
- **PACER BHUVNESHWAR** Kumar has been added to the Indian squad for the fifth and final series-deciding T20I match against the West Indies.
- **US SECRETARY** of State Marco Rubio will begin his five-day trip to Uzbekistan and India.

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2020 Delhi riots accused Narwal can go to UK, must not seek asylum: HC

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, October 16

THE DELHI High Court Friday allowed student activist Natasha Narwal, an accused in the larger conspiracy case relating to the 2020 Delhi riots, to travel to the United Kingdom for academic requirements as she pursues her PhD from the University of Warwick. »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



EXPRESS special

A real-time dashboard to watch local spikes in air pollution: Inside the country's biggest monitoring centre

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, October 16



At the Integrated Command and Control Centre at Shastri Park in Northeast Delhi. SOPHIYA MATHEW

AROUND 5.30 PM this past Wednesday, several red lights flashed on the dashboard at the Delhi Pollution Control Committee's (DPCC's) new AI-enabled Integrated Command and Control Centre (ICCC) at Shastri Park in Northeast Delhi. In Wazirpur, the Air Quality Index (AQI) had spiked 60 points in just an hour; in Narela, a monitoring station had gone offline; and a camera at a construction site had not transmitted for six hours.

Looking at a massive floor-to-ceiling monitor in front of him, a senior DPCC scientist said: "PM10 levels above the permissible limit at 44 [air quality] monitoring stations. PM2.5 exceeded the limit at 43 out of the 56 stations."

The monitor showed a map of Delhi, with blipping wind vectors pointing downward, and automated warnings flashing across the screen. "Poor dispersion. Emissions inside Delhi will stay local," said a warning.

The ICCC monitors pollution sources across Delhi in real time, the scientist said. It is the country's largest pollution control war room, and is monitored round the clock by teams that work a general shift from 10 am to 6 pm, plus three additional shifts from 7 am to 3 pm, 3 pm to 11 pm, and 11 pm to 7 am. »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

• SPECIALISED 'SHE' UNIT PERSONNEL ON DUTY TO DETER MISCREANTS, REASSURE WOMEN

'We feel like Mr India': Policewomen in Gujarat go undercover on garba nights

Brendan Dabhi & Aditi Raja
Ahmedabad, Vadodara, October 16

EVERY EVENING this Navratri, Inspector Chandrika Aasundra has been dressing up in a chaniya choli and reaching a garba venue. The 38-year-old policewoman joins the revellers and grooves to the music — but her eyes are always alert, closely watching every corner.

Inspector Aasundra heads the Vadodara city police's Anti Human Trafficking Unit. She is also part of SHE, a specialised unit of the Gujarat Police focused on the safety of women, children, and senior citizens.

Aasundra has been on undercover duty at garba venues for the past two years, along with several other women police officers. "We feel like we are Mr India. We are around, but we cannot be seen," she said, referring to the 1987 Bollywood film in which the titular character, played by Anil Kapoor, could become invisible.

"When you are in uniform, people tend to behave well. But when they cannot recognise us (police), we can see them for who they are," Aasundra said.

The largest deployment of personnel by Gujarat Police happens during Navratri. Thousands are put on duty, monitoring control centres and patrolling the streets. Gujarat Police has had 33 per cent reservation for women since 2014, so, a large chunk of these personnel is made up of women.

Sub-Inspector Hetal Jadeja has been on duty at garbas since 2022. She said that rotational undercover duty has an advantage. "Everyone gets the chance to do a bit of teen-taali while on the job, since policewomen rarely get leave during Navratri," Jadeja said.

Asked why police officers need to go undercover, Sub-Inspector Jadeja said: "Appearing at garba venues in uniform may be a deterrent (against crime) for a short time, but there are so »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

PAGE 1 anchor



A videograb of Inspector Nidhi Kalsaria on duty at a garba event in Ahmedabad.

epaper.indianexpress.com



A vehicle parked outside the YSRCP party office set on fire following a clash with the TDP workers, in Annamayya on Friday. ANI

TDP, YSRCP workers clash ahead of local body polls; MP claims convoy under attack

Sreenivas Janyala
Hyderabad, October 16

TENSIONS OVER nomination filings led to clashes between workers of the ruling Telugu Desam Party and the YSR Congress Party in Punganur town in Andhra Pradesh's Annamayya district ahead of local body polls, with stone pelting and vandalism reported.

YSRCP Lok Sabha Floor Leader and Rajampet MP P V Midhun Reddy claimed his convoy came under attack from TDP workers armed with sticks, iron rods and stones. The MP, who was injured in the attack, was accompanying YSRCP candidates to file nominations for the local body elections.

One senior police officer claimed that there was a standoff when supporters of both parties reached the office where nominations were being filed at the same time and that attacks began.

Meanwhile, the YSRCP alleged that TDP leaders and workers blocked the convoy and tried to stop candidates from reaching the nomination centre. Vehicles belonging to YSRCP leaders were vandalised, the party said, adding that police personnel present at the scene "failed to stop the attackers or protect the candidates".

YSRCP General Secretary Gadikota Sreekanth Reddy said: "It was an attempt to murder."

Police, however, claimed that supporters of TDP and YSRCP candidates came face to face and attacked each other, and that the police quickly moved in to restore order.

The YSRCP accused the TDP government of allowing its workers to use violence to silence opposition candidates and disrupt the election process.

The party has demanded that the State Election Commission intervene immediately, direct the police to register criminal cases and arrest those responsible, and take action against officers who failed to prevent the attack. It also sought protection for candidates and their proposers, and arrangements for all affected candidates to file their nominations safely and without obstruction.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Sitharaman

Speaking on the sidelines of the International Monetary Fund-World Bank annual meeting in Bangkok, Sitharaman also said she hopes the trade deal with the US is concluded "at the earliest" in the interest of global trade and trade between the two countries.

"The trade imbalance is something which we have been talking with China now for several years. We are denied market access even for those goods for which there are immense market opportunities in China," she said, adding that there is "huge potential" for India to export generic drugs, bovine meat, vegetables and other perishables to China. According to a PTI report from Beijing, Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning, responding to a question on Sitharaman's remarks, told a media briefing: "What I can tell you is that China never aims for trade surplus. We stand ready to work with India to address each other's economic and trade concerns in a balanced way and promote the steady development of bilateral relations."

Sitharaman's remarks came two days after Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal said India is "working to develop the relationship with China once again, but the last word has not yet been scripted on this journey". External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar also flagged concerns over economic issues with China, underlining the "one-sided" and "tilted" trade balance. India's trade deficit with China in the first six months of 2026-27 was $69 billion, 27% higher than in the corresponding period of 2025-26.

Sitharaman said, "I would think a decade has gone, consistently putting up a case for market access for Indian products. But non-tariff barriers have been very strong and China uses non-tariff barriers unhesitatingly, whether it is in the name of phytosanitary measures or any other for which due investigations can happen, both sides sitting and talking can happen. But no progress has been made. So, non-tariff barriers are the biggest hurdle in the trade between India and China."

The European Union and China have struck a preliminary deal that caps Chinese hybrid vehicle sales in Europe to 350,000 a year with goods from the Asian major flooding Europe – its daily trade deficit in 2025 was 1 billion euros. On Thursday, there were reports that the 27-nation bloc was looking at ways to "completely shut off" China's access to the single market.

Earlier this month, the US Trade Representative said trade ministers from 15 G20 countries, including the US, EU and India, had signed an agreement that called for the elimination of structural excess manufacturing capacity. China was among the countries not to have agreed to the statement.

The Chinese Commerce Ministry, according to state news agency Xinhua, said it would "respond as necessary if relevant economies adopt measures that harm Chinese interests".

Without naming the EU or US in her remarks, Sitharaman said the global approach to trade imbalances has been tariffs and other punitive action. This, she said, is a route India has never taken or believed in.

"We sit and talk. Sometimes it's very tiresome, but we do go through that approach rather than put CVD (countervailing duties) or some non-tariff barriers to counter the non-tariff barriers on the other side. So, these are ways in which we find it difficult in correcting the imbalance which prevails between China and us," she said.

According to Swiss think-tank Global Trade Alert, India opened 18 anti-dumping and anti-subsidy investigations in the July-September quarter, more than any other country. The single largest target was China. Sitharaman also defended the BRICS grouping, saying its objective is to better the lives of its people and it should not be seen from a negative perspective that "it is countering some other".

At the BRICS summit in New Delhi last month, the grouping's leaders said they will look to boost trade within themselves by using "mutually reinforcing policy levers" and explore solutions to efficient cross-border payments, interoperability of payment and messaging channels, and promoting trade settlements and investments using BRICS local currencies.

On Friday, Sitharaman batted in favour of rupee and local currency trade, saying it's a "method we have understood and we are working on it". In the first four months of 2026-27, India paid for 7.9% of its imports in rupees, or Rs 2.09 lakh crore. In all of 2025-26, imports worth only Rs 1.73 lakh crore were settled in rupees. The jump in rupee settlement of imports this year has primarily been on the account of oil purchased from Russia.

Delhi riots accused

Justice Amit Bansal, however, said Narwal has to furnish an undertaking that she will not seek asylum while in the UK. The Delhi Police had expressed apprehension that she may apply for asylum once in the UK, claiming "political persecution".

Released on bail in 2021 after spending 14 months in custody, Narwal sought to travel to the UK from November 2 to December 1. Additional Solicitor General (ASG) S V Raju, appearing for the Delhi Police, opposed her request. He said the UK's "extradition laws are strict", which will make it "difficult" to extradite her if she chooses not to return once abroad.

Earlier, a trial court had declined Narwal's request for permission to travel to the UK. She then moved the High Court.

Represented by advocate Adit Pujari, Narwal said she had to go to the UK to present a paper on 'Gendered Carceral Labour as Social Reproduction' at the School of Oriental and African Studies (SOAS) in London from November 5 to November 8.

She said she would then visit her PhD supervisor at the University of Warwick to update her on the work progress and access archival and library material. Narwal enrolled for the programme in 2023. Since then, she has been attending it via virtual mode. ASG Raju told the High Court that the paper presentation and her PhD course requirements could be done virtually and did not require her physical presence.

Special Public Prosecutor Madhukar Pandey said, "Tomorrow, she will say I am being politically persecuted and seek asylum (in the UK)."

Justice Bansal said, "We will put a condition that she won't seek asylum. You can always take steps, you are the government... The trial may take 20 years, this is purely an academic pursuit, and it's not an unknown university, it's a renowned university."

Pujari said Narwal is on a scholarship and has been living on a stipend, that she does not have the financial wherewithal to violate the court's order or stay in the UK, and that her passport is valid only for a year.

Justice Bansal permitted her to stay in the UK for a month, subject to her furnishing a personal bond of Rs 1 lakh, with her brother standing as surety.

Both she and her brother must also submit undertakings that she will return to India on December 2.

Protests

called at Firozeshah Road around 6 pm by the SFI and other Left student organisations. This group, which was joined by CPI(M) MP John Brittas, marched to Connaught Place.

By 7 pm, the protesters were dispersed by police and CAPF personnel deployed in Central Delhi. A senior police officer said more than 100 people had been detained for violating prohibitory orders.

Dipke, who was staying in the Karol Bagh house of NCP (Sharad Pawar) spokesperson Anish Gawande, was served a notice by a Delhi Police team, prohibiting him from holding the march "without seeking lawful permission" while underlining that the police action was in furtherance of court directions.

Citing the livelihood of traders and public movement in the area, the notice stated that Connaught Place was not a notified protest site and that other designated venues could be used "subject to lawful permission being sought and granted".

When Dipke stepped out of the Karol Bagh house at 4.50 pm, he was detained by police. "I am alone. Why are you stopping me?" he asked. He unfurled a Tricolour before police personnel put him in a police van and took him away.

Police sources said Dipke was taken to Jaffarpur Kalan police station in South West Delhi, where he could be placed under preventive detention for 24 hours.

Before Dipke's detention, a crowd began gathering near Central Park. There, the protesters were not only met by police and CAPF personnel, but also by local traders of Palika Bazar who raised slogans against them, saying their business was being disrupted.

More than 25,000 police and paramilitary personnel were deployed in the New Delhi district and nearby areas. Citing "administrative reasons," the NDMC had ordered the Central Park shut to the public on Friday and Saturday.

Neha Bora called for a flash protest at Mandi House around 5 pm. She began marching with her supporters around 5.20 pm but was detained soon after. She was taken to a location near the RK Puram police station in South West Delhi, and a police officer said that her lawyers had been informed.

Following the detention of Dipke and Bora, both CJP and AISA expressed concern over their whereabouts, saying there had been no communication with them.

DMK chief M K Stalin, in a post on X, said the government must release Dipke and Bora immediately and "stop suppressing peaceful protests".

Demanding to know the whereabouts of Dipke and Bora, Stalin said, "Detaining them without disclosing their whereabouts is blatantly illegal and deeply inhumane. The Union government must release them immediately and stop suppressing peaceful protests. Every attempt to crush the movement will only make it stronger."

Former West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee also criticised Dipke's detention. "What is Delhi Police up to? Abhijeet Dipke has been detained for holding the Indian National Flag. In independent India, our youth are being detained for peacefully asserting their democratic rights," she said on X. "This is nothing short of an undeclared Emergency. A government that fears dissent is now trying to intimidate an entire generation into silence. This is the conduct of a fascist regime that cannot tolerate a voice it cannot control... Abhijeet, Ashutosh, Saurav, you represent the courage, conscience and aspirations of India's youth... Your Didi stands firmly with you."

Congress MP Pawan Khera said, "Neha Bora and her companions have been kept in custody until such a late hour and even clear information on their whereabouts has not been provided." SP chief Akhilesh Yadav said, "Where was a woman taken after being detained at night? The police must disclose this. The National Commission for Women must immediately take cognizance. Neha Bora must be released immediately." CPI(M)'s Brittas too demanded an explanation from the police on Bora's whereabouts.

Rajnath

the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls. "Regime change is being pursued on the lines of Bangladesh ... They openly said at a press conference that they took inspiration from Bangladesh for regime change. Another speaks of bringing down the government. This makes it clear that their sole agenda is to destroy democratic institutions and create unrest in the country," Singh said.

"It appears that the Congress and its political allies, directly and through their supporting organisations, are trying to use the energy of the youth to fuel political confrontation and spread anarchy instead of channelling it towards constructive work and nation-building. The youth of the country are being made pawns in the politics of anarchy," Singh said.

Targeting Rahul Gandhi, he said the LoP and his allies need to understand that democracy is not "a licence to spread anarchy, damage the credibility of Constitutional institutions, and create barriers in development of the nation". The LoP carries a copy of the Constitution in his pocket while "trying to spread anarchy", Singh said.

In a post on X, BJP chief Nitin Nabin said the call for "regime change" had exposed the "true agenda of the Opposition". This was a "nefarious attempt to destabilise India in collusion with foreign powers", which is the agenda of "Urban Naxals", he alleged. "The Opposition's fight is not for electoral reforms, the SIR, or the future of the country's youth, but rather to spread anarchy in the country and seize power at any cost. In democracy, the path to power passes through the mandate of the people, not through chaos. India's patriotic public and the BJP will never allow any attempt to weaken the country's democratic system to succeed."

The BJP's pushback came a day after lawyer-activist Prashant Bhushan said at a press conference in Delhi, "Yes, we want regime change ... What is wrong with this? I am saying today that yes, it is a battle for regime change, and we will get it done anyhow."

A day earlier, in a video message to the Socialist Students' Front in Bangladesh, Left student leader Neha Bora said, "We know that the Gen Z movement that we are seeing everywhere in this country first started in Bangladesh and congratulations to you for showing us the way ... for extending solidarity to young people of this country. We know that the movement that began in Bangladesh was for democratic and voter rights." Bora added, "We take inspiration from you, lessons from the movements that you lead and we hope that together, you in Bangladesh and we in India, can fight together for a better South Asia, for a better world."

In his remarks to the media, Singh also said that in 2009, then CEC N Gopalaswami had written a letter to the President seeking the removal of EC Navin Chawla, accusing him of sharing sensitive information of the EC with Congress leaders. "The Congress then not only protected Navin Chawla, but also appointed him CEC because he was close to the Nehru-Gandhi family," he said.

His Cabinet colleagues Piyush Goyal and Manohar Lal also targeted the LoP and the INDIA bloc, accusing them of nursing a "dream of forcing regime change through street chaos".

Responding to Singh, Congress's communications incharge Jairam Ramesh said, "The Defence Minister needs to be reminded of what the former President Pranab Mukherjee, who was awarded the Bharat Ratna in 2019, would often say: the job of the Opposition in a democracy is to oppose, expose, and depose."

Congress's media head Pawan Khera also cited Mukherjee's words to emphasise that seeking "regime change" was part of the democratic process.

"Rajnath ji is surprised that the Opposition seeks a regime change. But that's what oppositions all over the world seek. That's what the BJP sought to do before 2014. It is the obvious part of the democratic process. The job of the Opposition, in the words of Shri Pranab Mukherjee, is to expose, oppose and, if possible, depose. Did Rajnath ji expect the Opposition to start a Bhakti Movement for Modi?" Khera said.

Panel

"On August 28, after the committee was formed, all the members decided to visit Jantar Mantar. After visiting the protest site, they decided to inspect three other venues, Ramlila Ground in Central Delhi, Burari in North Delhi and CBD Ground in East Delhi," a source said.

During inspections, officials assessed the traffic situation, the possible impact of gatherings on local markets and the security arrangements required at each venue. "Around 5.30 pm, all officials returned to their offices after visiting the sites, and Dwivedi was asked to prepare a report for the MHA," the source said. The Ministry received the report in September. In the meantime, the committee discussed the matter with legal experts. "After discussions and legal opinion, it was decided that Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar was empowered to issue such a notification," the source said. On October 11, after the CJP called for a protest on October 10, the Police Commissioner issued a fresh standing order.

Undercover

many venues, and the belief that an undercover officer may be present among the revellers can provide sustained deterrence."

Garbas are organised everywhere in Gujarat. In Ahmedabad alone, there are 84 commercial garba venues and 1,300 sheri (community) garbas in the streets and societies this year.

Across the city, about 14,000 police personnel and Home Guards are on duty. This includes 49 SHE Teams with 300 personnel in all.

"The number of garba venues is increasing every year. At Mandli garbas (where folk instruments are used), the speakers shut down at midnight, but the garba can go on until 5 in the morning. So police teams have to remain in the field for longer," Jadeja said.

ACP Himala Joshi, who heads the Mahila Crime Unit in Ahmedabad city, told *The Indian Express:* "Ahmedabad has people from various states, young people who come to study, as well as migrant workers. When they call for help, police must be able to communicate in languages other than Gujarati, including English and Hindi. We are trying to reach out to Gen Z so that they do not hesitate to ask for help."

In Vadodara, DCP, Zone 2, Manjita Vanzara, who has been leading SHE teams, said: "We are on the (garba) grounds, outside the venues, and on deserted stretches along the way."

Women officers undergo training for a month that prepares them for duty in crowded places, DCP Vanzara said. A technical team provides backroom support, and organisers maintain records of those attending garba. "During Navratri, most people are up until dawn, so calls to police are fewer during the day. But the bandobast at night is akin to VIP duty," Inspector Aasundra said. But there is an advantage too: "Night duty is usually boring, but garba nights give us a chance to dress up and dance. It does not feel like a burden," she said.

Given the rising incidence of cybercrime such as morphing and doxxing, women officers at garba venues are trained to keep an eye out for people secretly recording women, officers said. Such miscreants are pulled aside, forced to delete pictures taken without consent, and given a warning. Constables Jagruti Chavda and Sujata Parmar of the SHE Team at Rajkot's Bhaktinagar police station have been going undercover during Navratri since 2022. But their job does not end at garba, they said.

"We ensure that no woman faces problems on their way home from the venue. If we find any such woman, we make sure she reaches home," Constable Chavda said. "We may not get to enjoy Navratri with our families, but we make sure that others do so without worries," she said.

Videos of Inspector Nidhi Kalsaria dressed in traditional attire at a garba venue in Ahmedabad went viral after police posted them on social media earlier this week. This prompted many to wonder whether sharing videos of the policewomen defeated the purpose of their going undercover. Inspector Kalsaria said the idea is deterrence and reassurance. "We put up photos and videos of undercover staff at garba venues to send the message that police are everywhere. We also need to reassure the women that we are there, dancing with them and patrolling the streets," she said.

Karnataka CID seeks nod to prosecute suspended IAS officer Gangwar

Express News Service
Bengaluru, October 16

THE CRIMINAL Investigation Department (CID) of the Karnataka Police has approached the state government for official sanction to prosecute an IAS officer who was arrested for his alleged involvement in leaking questions of a Karnataka Public Service Commission (KSPC) recruitment exam.

An officer from the 2016 batch of the Karnataka cadre, Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar was the Controller of Exams at the KPSC between January 2024 and March 2026. Investigations revealed that Gangwar leaked the questions of the KPSC recruitment exam for veterinary doctors held in January this year to 10 candidates who eventually figured in the top 20 rank list. He was arrested on August 29.

The CID acted after the SC indicated on October 13 that chargesheets could be filed against those arrested by the agency, even though the court had also allowed a Special Investigation Team (SIT) to be formed.

Section 218 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita mandates a sanction when state officers are directly involved in crimes, CID police sources said. Incidentally, under BNSS, a prosecution sanction is deemed granted if not given in 120 days.

Basvaraj Kannale, a middleman who operated with Gangwar and helped find aspirants willing to pay bribes in the range of Rs 20 lakh to Rs 40 lakh to receive questions in advance, was also arrested – on August 30.

CORRECTION & CLARIFICATION PAGE 3, 14.10.2026

● The report 'Metro Line 7A height hurdle nears resolution' wrongly stated that MMRDA identified the height-clearance issue on the elevated section of Metro 7A in 2025, and that MMRDA Metropolitan Commissioner Sanjay Mukherjee had met Gautam Adani over the issue. MMRDA had first formally raised the height-clearance concern in August 2023, and no meeting took place between Mukherjee and Adani. The error is regretted.

Air pollution

Observations by the general shift form the basis for key daytime action-taken reports and operations. The centre integrates multiple data points to assess pollution in real time using multiple sources of information, officials said.

Monitoring stations across the city record the concentration of pollutants at specific locations and times. Meteorological data help explain or predict whether atmospheric conditions favour the dispersion of pollutants or allow them to accumulate.

Historical readings help identify trends and unusual changes, while information about construction sites, industrial activity, road-sweeping operations and field inspections can help examine possible local sources, the senior DPCC scientist who is in charge of the station explained.

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta inaugurated the centre on October 1. On Wednesday, when *The Indian Express* visited the control room, the AQI in the city was 148. The major takeaways from the working of the integrated monitoring centre are likely to become apparent in the coming weeks, as the winter sets in and Delhi enters its air pollution season.

At the ICCC, the senior scientist at the control room turned to look at a large white workstation underlit in neon blue. "Wind speed is less than 4 km per hour. There is poor dispersion. Wind speed has to be more than 10 kmph for good dispersion," he said.

A younger operator sitting at the workstation confirmed that some stations were reporting a near-negligible wind speed of 1.9 kmph. As the system flagged the stagnant regional wind flow, the remarks on the dashboard said data from the India Meteorological Department (IMD) and Global Forecast System (GFS), a model run by the United States National Weather Service, would be needed to assess the transport of pollutants from Punjab and Haryana.

Almost on cue, the screens flashed red with a "critical" Priority-1 alert. AQI at Burari crossing in North Delhi had breached the emergency threshold. "Generate the alert," a supervisor instructed.

Wednesday was the first day of full-fledged operations at the control centre, and the alerts had piled up. In the 'Ambient Air' dashboard, a breach flagged: "PM10 jumps by more than 50 µg/m³ (micrograms per cubic metre) between two hourly readings" at the Wazirpur monitoring station. It was marked as a Priority 2 (P2) incident in the 'Severity' column.

The system had logged the AQI surge from 149 to 210 between 4 pm and 5 pm, and routed the report to the instrumentation cell at the Wazirpur Continuous Ambient Air Quality Monitoring Station (CAAQMS) so the source could be tracked down.

The queue flagged other issues — the Narela and Chhawla CAAQMSes had failed to transmit valid readings for three consecutive hours, and automated offline alerts had been generated and assigned to nodal officers.

The escalation queue also flickered with severe P1 triggers requiring immediate ground intervention. A "Camera Alert Missing 6 hour" had popped up because a mandatory construction-site camera had gone dark, a "PM Sensor Alert 6 hour" was flashing because a particulate-matter sensor had stopped transmitting data, and a P1 Audit Alert signalled that a builder's mandatory self-audit was overdue.

With median acknowledgment time lagging at 57 minutes against a 30-minute target, and with 10 major alerts having escalated past Level 1, operators in the control room raced to triage the situation before dusk fell – when lower temperatures could be expected to trap polluted air closer to the surface in an atmospheric phenomenon known as temperature-inversion effect.

Among the technicians and data analysts at the consoles was technical trainee Shalu Yadav, a Master's in Environmental Management from Guru Gobind Singh Indraprastha University.

"Alerts are divided into Priority 1 and Priority 2," Yadav said. "If PM10 and PM2.5 values go above 50 µg/m³, an alert is generated. If the AQI at a monitoring station goes above 200 and stays continuously in that range, an alert goes to that station, and the cause is checked. If readings go too high somewhere, alerts go to the on-ground enforcement teams, and we tell them, 'Please go to this station and see what the issue is.'," she said.

The E-Datalens Air Quality Analytics platform at the control centre was developed for DPCC by an Indian company called Datalens Technologies Pvt Ltd, along with global tech infrastructure partners such as Delta Americas, Hewlett Packard, Cisco, and NetApp, officials said.

The platform has integrated APIs from the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB), Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology (IITM), IMD, Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), and the Indian Agricultural Research Institute (IARI), which monitors farm fires, the project in-charge said.

The centre's biggest challenge is "AI-layering", the centre in-charge, who preferred not to be identified, said.

This refers to human operators having to review video feeds from construction sites and manually draw bounding boxes over specific frames to classify issues. They tag the feeds daily with labels such as "Dust High", "Smoke Low", "Dust + Smoke", and "Clear".

Every manual selection feeds the algorithm to train the AI. A senior official said roughly 10,000 frames of inputs mapped with trained tags will be required before the LLM is trained fully.

Six modules have been developed so far — they include an hourly AQI forecast for the next 72 hours, a colour-coded record of daily air-quality categories over 30 days, and a 20-day mean AQI.

Operators can also examine individual monitoring stations and compare readings with those from nearby stations. An official said that integrating Automatic Number Plate Recognition (ANPR) cameras and monitoring of traffic congestion hotspots is planned to be added. For construction sites, AI-enabled cameras and particulate matter sensors can flag potential dust-control problems and identify interruptions in surveillance.

The centre will also track the operations of the Mechanical Road Sweeper Machines, including their location and movement, to help officials monitor their deployment and identify stretches that may require further attention.

On Wednesday, when *The Indian Express* visited the control centre, the Road Dust Control interface had logged that 75 out of the 79 available sweepers were running, having covered a cumulative distance of 1,774.1 km. A total 210 vehicle stoppages were recorded.

The system has a complete operational dossier for each sweeper, including the name of the driver, the machine's sweeping speed, and its adherence to its designated route. GPS-enabled vehicles track 78 field squad teams working in two shifts, and a complaint-handling system — which includes personnel manning social media and call centre — routes grievances to relevant authorities and monitors follow-up actions.

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Less than 50 turn up for CJP protest

Low turnout at Azad Maidan rally despite the group securing police nod

Apoorva Agashe & Ishika Gupta
Mumbai, October 16

THE COCKROACH Janta Party's (CJP) 'Lehrao Tiranga' rally at Mumbai's Azad Maidan turned rather uneventful as fewer than 50 protesters gathered at the protest site despite the group securing permission for the much-awaited demonstration.

As per the police permission, the CJP's Tiranga rally was officially meant to start at 10 am and continue until 5 pm. For the first four hours, volunteers from Bhavan Singh Jan Adhikar Yatra and All India Students' Federation (AISF) and CJP were present on the ground.

The protesters only started to gather around 3 pm, but their numbers never surpassed that of the volunteers.

In fact, CJP's Mumbai coordinator Pranav Ahire was also absent from the protest site. After 5 pm, the crowds thinned and completely cleared out.





(From left) CJP supporters protest at Azad Maidan on Friday, calling for Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's resignation; lawyers protest outside Bombay High Court against the arrests of Supreme Court lawyers as well as the SIR issue. ANURAG AHIRE

Protesters question leaders' absence, lack of information

For many, the poor turnout at Mumbai's Azad Maidan was due to a lack of official information from the CJP. Protesters argued that the announcement regarding the protest was given very late, with no clarity on the issue or the movement ahead.

The protestors have said that the CJP must also come up with a plan, while questioning the absence of any major leader at the Mumbai protest. Others pointed to fear as the main deterrent to attending the gathering.

"Perhaps the thinner crowds are owing to fear of receiving similar treatment and detention, as the Delhi police is initiating against the crowd," said Mumbai resident Aayush Nagrecha. However, the strength of the crowd did not deter those who had gathered.

"Democracy will always stand the test of time," Aayush Nagrecha said.

A similar sentiment of solidarity was also echoed by others. "We're here in solidarity with our brothers and sisters who have been brutally detained and mishandled by the authorities in Delhi," said students Raisa and Pramodita.

Ahead of the protests, the authorities had deployed 500 police personnel to maintain law and order around Azad Maidan and the Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Metro.

The protestors said that they were unaware of the protest as the CJP's official handle had allegedly not posted anything about it.

"I am here by myself, and there is no awareness about the protest by the CJP; even their official Instagram handle had no information about the protest despite having proper permission. There is no coordination, due to which people are not present. We are protesting here so that our right to protest does not come under threat," advocate Anandini Fernandes said.

A student said there was no coordination among the CJP members, "as people are afraid of the mass detention that the Mumbai police had been doing more awareness about the protest which has permission, the party did not give any prior information about the protest," Pramodita said.

"People who reached here did not know how to reach the ground. The protest should be more organised," she said.

Leaders like Samya Kore, Aamir Kazi and social activists like Anjali Damania gave short speeches, demanding the resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar and accountability for the brutality by the Delhi Police.

According to the police, the protest was peaceful. "There was adequate security deployed at the Azad Maidan, no law and order situation was created, and the CJP-led left-wing student organisation protest ended at 5 pm after singing the national anthem," the police said.

SPECIAL INTENSIVE REVISION

CM urges voters to check names in poll rolls, enroll by Oct 26

Express News Service
Mumbai, October 16



CM Devendra Fadnavis. FILE

CHIEF MINISTER Devendra Fadnavis on Friday urged citizens to check their names in the electoral rolls and ensure that all eligible voters are registered, ahead of a statewide special enrolment drive on October 17, 18, 24 and 25.

The Chief Minister's Office posted appeals on social media urging people to come forward and ensure their enrolment in the electoral rolls.

The drive, being conducted by the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), Maharashtra, in coordination with the Election Commission of India (ECI), aims to enrol newly eligible voters and include names inadvertently left out of the draft electoral roll.

In a press note issued on Thursday, the General Administration Department reiterated the Election Commission's objective: "No eligible voter to be left out of the Electoral Roll."

The campaign will cover all Assembly constituencies in the state.

The administration has deployed 36 District Election Officers, 288 Electoral Registration Officers, 7,100 Assistant Electoral Registration Officers and 1,00,253 Booth Level Officers (BLOs) to assist voters.

Special camps will be held at polling stations on October 17 and 18, and again on October 24 and 25.

BLOs will help citizens verify their details, apply for enrollment and seek corrections.

The CEO's office has asked citizens to submit claims, applications and objections by October 26 as part of the ongoing revision process.

For assistance, voters can call the toll-free Voter Helpline at 1950. Helpdesks are also available at District Election Officer offices and Electoral Registration Officer offices at the Assembly constituency level.

147 FAKE LOANS IN THREE DAYS

Rs 4.03 crore siphoned off from Piramal Finance

Manish Kumar Pathak
Mumbai, October 16

FRAUDSTERS ALLEGEDLY siphoned off Rs 4.03 crore from Piramal Finance Limited by securing 147 loans in three days using forged documents and repeated PAN and Aadhaar details under different names, Ghatkopar police said.

The case was registered on Wednesday following a complaint by an assistant vice-president in the company's legal department.

The alleged fraud took place between February 18 and 20 this year.

According to the FIR, the company's automated digital lending system verifies applicants' PAN and Aadhaar details, bank statements, e-KYC and live selfies before disbursing loans.

The company's Fraud Control Unit flagged a spike in applications on February 20, following which an internal inquiry found repeated personal details and bank account information.

Of the 147 loans, 25 were processed on February 18, 78 on February 19 and 44 on February 20. The accused allegedly siphoned off Rs 4,03,29,880 by transferring the money to various bank accounts.

The company subsequently approached the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal and the Ghatkopar police.

Investigators are examining loan applications, beneficiary accounts, IP addresses and call records to identify the accused and trace the funds. A police officer said the fraud appeared to involve an organised gang.

Two Palghar men held for taking Rs 30 lakh bribe

Express News Service
Mumbai, October 16

THE MUMBAI Crime Branch on Friday arrested two Palghar-based men while they were allegedly accepting Rs 30 lakh from a senior citizen as "protection money".

According to police, the complainant wanted to set up a stone-crushing unit in Palghar, for which the accused had initially demanded Rs 80 lakh.

One of the accused is also the deputy sarpanch of a village in Palghar and allegedly used his influence to threaten people, officers said.

The accused, identified as Machindra Paste and Vaibhav Harad, allegedly demanded "protection money" from people seeking to set up new factories in Palghar, police said.

Sources said the police received several calls from Palghar after the arrests, with callers raising similar complaints against the accused.

The duo was produced before a court and remanded to police custody.

State govt online services to remain shut till October 20

Express News Service
Mumbai, October 16

ONLINE SERVICES across Maharashtra government departments will remain unavailable from Friday to October 20 due to data centre migration and system upgrades, Maharashtra Information Technology Corporation Limited (MahaIT) has said in a notice.

The work is intended to improve the performance, stability and security of government websites, portals, applications and citizen services hosted at the State Data Centre.

During the scheduled outage, the affected websites, portals, applications and citizen and Village Level Entrepreneur (VLE) services will be unavailable. Users will not be able to submit online applications or documents, or complete pending transactions through these services.

MahaIT said it would make efforts to complete the work by Monday, October 19.

Services are expected to be restored on Tuesday, October 20, after the technical work and system checks are completed.

ADVERTORIAL

UTTAR PRADESH'S
EDUCATION TRANSFORMATION



BETTER EDUCATION,
EVERY CHILD,
EQUAL OPPORTUNITIES







Uttar Pradesh is transforming government education through a comprehensive approach focused on infrastructure, foundational learning, digital education and inclusion. Since 2017-18, Operation Kayakalp has upgraded 1.32 lakh schools across 19 key parameters, while school saturation has risen from 36% to 96.30%. Better classrooms, 3.42 lakh desks and benches, smart classrooms, ICT labs, libraries, safe water, sanitation and accessible facilities are creating improved learning environments. Alongside this, 75 CM Abhyudaya Composite Schools and 150 CM Model Composite Schools across 75 districts are being developed. SHARDA, NIPUN Bharat and Samarth further strengthen enrolment, foundational learning and support for Children with Special Needs-ensuring every child learns, participates and progresses.







OPERATION KAYAKALP: 19 PARAMETERS, ONE GOAL

Uttar Pradesh is transforming government schools through Operation Kayakalp, creating cleaner, safer, more accessible and modern learning spaces. The initiative focuses on 19 key parameters, covering infrastructure, hygiene, accessibility, digital education, sports and student amenities.

Better Infrastructure | Better Learning Environment | Digital Education | Accessibility | Hygiene | Safety | Holistic Development

19 PARAMETERS OF OPERATION KAYAKALP

- **Safe Drinking Water:** Functional handpumps, water filters, RO systems and clean water facilities.
- **Running Water Supply:** Piped water connections for toilets and handwashing facilities.
- **Separate Boys' & Girls' Toilets:** Clean, functional and gender-segregated toilet facilities.
- **Tiled Toilets & Urinals:** Hygienic, easy-to-clean tiled floors & walls.
- **CWSN-Friendly Toilets:** Accessible toilets with ramps, railings and appropriate facilities.
- **Handwashing Facilities:** Multi-tap handwashing stations for better hygiene practices.
- **Tiled Classroom Floors:** Durable, clean and well-maintained flooring in classrooms.
- **Electricity Connection:** Reliable grid-connected power supply for the school.
- **Quality Blackboards:** Clear, smooth and functional blackboards in every classroom.
- **Classroom Furniture:** Adequate desks, tables and chairs for comfortable learning.



- **Kitchen Sheds:** Hygienic and dedicated facilities for preparation of PM POSHAN meals.
- **Ramps & Railings:** Accessible pathways for children with physical disabilities.
- **Safe Electrical Wiring:** Secure wiring with functional lights, fans and switches.
- **Boundary Walls & Gates:** Secure school premises with proper boundary walls and gates.
- **Library & Reading Corner:** Dedicated spaces with books to promote reading habits.
- **Playground Facilities** Safe, levelled spaces for sports and physical activities.
- **Painting & Learning Walls:** Clean, vibrant campuses with educational and child-friendly murals.
- **Smart Classrooms & ICT Labs :** Digital tools, computers, projectors and smart boards for modern learning.
- **Green & Clean Campus:** Tree plantation, gardens, cleanliness and eco-friendly school surroundings.

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IIT-B suicide: Police recover victim's WhatsApp chats from his laptop

Wakode's iPhone remains locked, and the forensic lab has not been able to access it yet

Mohamed Thaver
Mumbai, October 16

THE MUMBAI Police Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing the suicide of Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Bombay student Sahil Wakode has accessed his WhatsApp chats through his laptop, on which he had synced the messaging application.

Wakode's iPhone 17 remains locked, and the forensic laboratory has not been able to access it yet. The police have also sent the mobile phone of professor Suryanarayan Doolla to the forensic laboratory for examination.

"We have finally got access to the deceased's WhatsApp chats as he had synced his laptop to WhatsApp. So far, his mobile phone could not be accessed. This should help in our probe," a source said.

The official said the police had also sent Doolla's phone for forensic examination. Such tests can help recover data that may have been deleted from a device.

The police have received cloned copies of the laptop and tablet used by Wakode. They have also sent specific queries to forensic officials about the data and are awaiting answers in the final report, the official said.

The police have also sent digital video recorders (DVRs) containing CCTV footage from IIT Bombay to the forensic laboratory for verification.

So far, the police have recorded statements from more than 50 people in the case, including the IIT Bombay director, Doolla, fellow students who were in the examination hall and Wakode's parents.

Wakode's parents, who have been protesting for the past few weeks, also met the joint commissioner of the Crime Branch to raise their grievances regarding the investigation.

Wakode, a second-year IIT Bombay student, was found dead in his hostel room hours after he was asked to leave an examination hall for allegedly using a cellphone during a mid-semester examination.

Doolla, who was the invigilator, was booked by Powai police on charges of abetment to suicide and under provisions of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.

Wakode's family has alleged that Doolla had been harassing him for months and making casteist remarks. No arrests have been made in the case so far.

Wakodes plan homage for son outside Powai campus

Ishika Gupta
Mumbai, October 16

NEARLY A month after IIT Bombay student Sahil Wakode died by suicide, his parents have announced a march and homage ceremony outside the institute on October 18, as they continue their indefinite hunger strike at Azad Maidan, demanding action in the case.

The announcement was made on Friday, the 15th day of the hunger strike. Sahil's father, Ravindra Wakode, said the family also hoped to meet Dr K Radhakrishnan, chairperson of IIT Bombay's Board of Governors, to raise concerns over the circumstances surrounding their son's death and the subsequent investigation.

"Since it has been a month since Sahil's death, we will honour his soul outside the IIT Bombay campus on October 18. We also hope to meet Dr K Radhakrishnan to discuss our concerns," Ravindra Wakode said.

The announcement comes amid restrictions on demonstrations at Azad Maidan over the weekend, when gatherings and protests are prohibited.

Wakode said that while politicians and ministers had met him and his wife during their protest, the family was yet to receive a substantive update on the investigation. They have been demanding accountability over what they allege was mistreatment and caste-based discrimination against their son.



Ravindra and Sonali Wakode, parents of Sahil Wakode, on hunger strike at Azad Maidan on Friday. AMIT CHAKRAVARTY

The family has also questioned why Professor Suryanarayana Doolla, against whom it has levelled allegations, has not been arrested and thoroughly investigated.

"Our primary demand is that Doolla be arrested," Wakode said. He added that the family had met Joint Commissioner of Police (Crime) Anil Kumbhare, who assured them that the matter was under investigation.

Meanwhile, student leaders and activists at Azad Maidan raised concerns over alleged caste-based discrimination and the treatment of students from marginalised communities at IIT Bombay. They cited figures claiming that 14 students at the institute had died by suicide over the past two decades.

On Thursday, activists from six organisations were detained outside IIT Bombay's main gate after gathering in support of Sahil's parents. The activists were on their way to meet the institute's director to demand a fair investigation by its internal committee and accountability in the case.

EXPRESS special

To plug underground water leaks, BMC turns to SONAR tech

Civic body plans to increase annual replacement of pipelines five-fold

Pratip Acharya
Mumbai, October 16

WITH MUMBAI facing a 10 per cent water cut following deficient rainfall, the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) plans to step up efforts to plug leakages in its ageing water supply network by using SONAR technology to pinpoint underground leaks and increasing the pace of pipeline replacement up to five-fold.

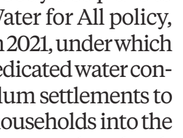
The civic body estimates that nearly 34 per cent of the water it supplies, or around 1,394 million litres per day (MLD), is lost to leakages and water theft. With a network stretching nearly 6,000 km, much of it decades old, the BMC plans to replace 250-300 km of pipelines annually, against the current 60-70 km.

One of the key interventions under consideration is the use of Sound Navigation and Ranging (SONAR) technology to identify underground leakages. The technology uses sound waves to detect objects and identify changes beneath the surface.

"Whenever there is leakage, water starts gushing out from underneath the ground onto the streets or roads above. Often, after digging the surface, we discover that the source of leakage is not at the spot from where the water comes out. Following this, we need to do our own calculations, narrow down a few suspected points and continue to dig the roads until the leakages are located," Abhijit Bangar, Additional Municipal Commissioner (Projects), told The Indian Express.

• MUMBAI'S WATER LOSS: THE NUMBERS

4,600 MLD — DAILY WATER DEMAND
4,100 MLD — DAILY WATER SUPPLY
(34%) 1,394 MLD — Estimated water lost to leakages and theft



WHAT THE BMC PLANS
- Use SONAR technology to pinpoint underground leaks
- Increase annual pipeline replacement from **60-70 km** to **250-300 km**
- Expand the Water for All policy to provide formal water connections in slum settlements

LENGTH OF EXISTING PIPELINE NETWORK: 6,000 KM

He said repeated digging damages roads, while the actual source of a leak can remain undetected for some time. SONAR technology is expected to help pinpoint leaks and reduce the need for exploratory digging.

The BMC is also looking to accelerate the replacement of its ageing pipeline network. Civic officials said the current pace of replacing 60-70 km of pipelines annually accounts for barely one per cent of the network. The target is to raise this to 250-300 km a year, replacing around 5-6 per cent of the network annually.

"If we see from a metric point, the BMC is now able to replace only 1 per cent of the existing pipeline network. Going forward, we aim to replace 5-6 per cent of the existing old pipelines annually with new ones, scaling up the progress to 25-30 per cent in the next four years, resulting in fewer losses of water," Bangar said.

The civic body also plans to expand its Water for All policy, introduced in 2021, under which it provides dedicated water connections to slum settlements to bring more households into the formal supply network and curb water theft.

According to BMC data, the civic body has received 35,697 applications under the policy and granted 29,110 water connections so far.

Bangar said the BMC is in the process of appointing a consultant to assess the feasibility of the proposed interventions and prepare a detailed report within six months. The civic body plans to begin implementing the measures around the middle of 2027.

The move comes a week after Mumbai Mayor Ritu Tawde asked the civic administration to submit a report to the civic house on measures to prevent water loss.

Why it matters

Mumbai depends on seven lakes, Tulsi, Vihar, Bhatsa, Tansa, Modak Sagar, Upper Vaitarna and Middle Vaitarna, located across the city's suburbs and neighbouring districts, for its water supply. The lakes are replenished by monsoon rainfall, and the stored water is transported to households and establishments through the pipeline network.

The city's daily water demand stands at around 4,600 MLD, while the BMC supplies approximately 4,100 MLD. Of this, an estimated 1,394 MLD is lost to leakages and theft.

With deficient rainfall this year and higher temperatures accelerating evaporation, the BMC has imposed a 10 per cent water cut to ensure available stocks last until September next year.

FDA suspends licences of 25 food joints, Domino's pizza among them

Press Trust of India
Mumbai, October 16

THE MAHARASHTRA Food and Drug Administration (FDA) has suspended the licences of 25 food establishments and four edible oil and spice manufacturing units as part of a statewide crackdown, officials said on Friday.

Six outlets of Domino's Pizza were among the establishments whose licences were suspended in Pune division. The action also covered outlets in Jalna and Parbhani in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar division, the FDA said.

The FDA also seized approximately 81,330 kg of suspected substandard, adulterated or wrongly-labelled food products worth Rs 1.73 crore from 37 establishments across six divisions.

In a press release, it said the seized stock included edible oil, chilli, turmeric powder, areca nut, dry fruits, sabudana, rajgira, tea powder and sweets.

• Ready for 2027 launch, Juhu's new flyover to cut travel time to 20 min - Will commute get faster?

CHANGING city

The new flyover over Mumbai's Juhu-Vile Parle Development Scheme (JVPD) circle is likely to be commissioned for vehicular use by December 2027. The new flyover in Juhu will allow commuters traversing from the western suburbs to bypass at least five congested traffic junctions, including the JVPD circle, cutting travel time down from 45 minutes to just 20.


The flyover will commence from the end of the CD Barfiwala flyover up to the Juhu Versova Link Road. EXPRESS



THE PROJECT
- The flyover will commence from the end of the CD Barfiwala flyover up to the Juhu Versova Link Road. While linking the two busy routes, the flyover will bypass five traffic junctions.
- Additionally, the project seeks to connect an arm to the upcoming Versova Bandra Sea Link, offering direct connectivity to the coastal road.

CHALLENGES
- Installation of girders under the metro station using special technology
- Construction of 72 m-long-bridge at 90-feet junction
- Relocation of 600 mm and 900 mm diameter drains by 400 metres
- Relocation of a 1200 mm diameter drain through microtunneling

Current deadline - **December 31, 2027,** Previous deadline - **March 31, 2028**

Total length: **1.75 km** | Width **15.10 metres** | Total cost **₹460 crore**

"At present, it takes about 45 minutes to travel on this route during peak hours. After the completion of the flyover, the travel time is expected to be reduced to about 20 minutes. The completion of the JVPD flyover will provide a major relief to the road traffic in Juhu, Vile Parle West, Andheri West and Versova and will help in making the transport system in the western suburbs more efficient."
ABHIJIT BANGAR,
ADDITIONAL MUNICIPAL COMMISSIONER (PROJECTS) AT BMC.

COMPILED BY: NAYONIKA BOSE

Two minors detained over murder of teen

Thane: Two minors were detained for allegedly murdering a 17-year-old boy in Thane to steal his gold chain to raise funds to throw a birthday party and buy a motorcycle, a police official said on Friday.

The two stabbed their friend with a knife and bludgeoned him with a heavy stone. To eliminate evidence, they returned the following day, poured petrol on the body, and set it on fire, police said.

The body was recovered and a murder case was filed. PTI

BMC eyes Rs 10,000 cr in green bonds amid Rs 2.34L cr liabilities


The Mumbai civic body had also recorded a Rs 3,544 crore loss in its financial reserves this year.

Express News Service
Mumbai, October 16

WITH LIABILITIES of Rs 2.34 crore, the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) has floated an expression of interest (EoI) to appoint a debenture trustee to oversee the civic body's proposed green municipal bonds issue, aimed at raising funds.

A debenture trustee is an independent financial intermediary appointed by a company issuing debentures or bonds to protect and represent the interests of the investors. Municipal bonds are debt securities issued by municipal corporations to raise capital for funding key public infrastructure projects.

The civic body's move comes at a time when it is reeling under a liability of Rs 2.34 lakh core owing to the large scale infrastructure projects it took up.

The size of the infrastructure projects is two and half times more than BMC's annual 2026-27 budget.

The Mumbai civic body had also recorded a Rs 3,544 crore loss in its financial reserves this year.

"We have finalised an agency for studying our credit rating and banks through which bonds will be issued have also been finalised. This new agency will manage the entire process of bindi issuance as well as managing the investors money and providing liquidity security for a period of 15 years," an odficial said.

According to the civic authorities, the BMC intends to generate revenue between Rs 5000-Rs 10,000 crore through green bonds.

Some other projects that will be funded through these bonds include BMC's upcoming wastewater treatment facilities at Dharavi, Versova, Bhandup, Ghatkopar, Bandra and Malad, as well as the upcoming desalination plants, alongside two water tunnel project, and the proposed Gargai dam project.

During the Union Budget 2026-27, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman had announced a Rs 100 crore incentive for a single municipal bond issuance of Rs 1000 crore.

In April, the BMC had appointed a Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI)-registered agency for analysing BMC's credit rating – an important step towards initiating the process of future borrowing of money through markets.

'Impossible to package every item': Order by FDA banning sale of loose spices divides Lalbaug traders

Purnima Sah
Mumbai, October 16

AT MUMBAI'S century-old Lalbaug spice market, customers have long bought masalas in small quantities, relying on shopkeepers whose families have served generations of buyers. A Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) order banning the sale of loose, unpackaged spice powders has divided traders, with some backing the move to curb adulteration while others fear higher costs and disruption to their traditional businesses.

Ajit Gaikwad, president of the New Lalbaug Markets Merchants Association, said traders supported the objective but needed clarity on implementation.

"People have been asking for such measures for 10-15 years. If the government wants to eliminate adulteration, this is a good system. But there are practical issues that need to be addressed, including how to handle customers who need only 10 grams when packaged products may be available in quantities of 50 grams or more," he said.

Packaging would add costs through cleaning, processing and sealing, Gaikwad said, but could also bring greater transparency and encourage established companies to enter the market. The association has around 150 registered spice merchants in Lalbaug, apart from an estimated 100 unregistered traders. It has begun discussing implementation concerns with the local food inspector.

Other traders, however, fear the requirements could push up prices and weaken the appeal of traditional shops.

Naresh Rathod of H B Rathod Masala said packaging each product and providing the required details on every packet would increase costs for consumers. He added that freshly ground spices could last about a year when stored in airtight conditions.

Rathod also questioned whether packaged products were necessarily safer, arguing that regulators should examine concerns about contaminants in branded spices as well.



The Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration has banned the sale of loose and unpackaged spice powders and mixed masalas. GANESH SHIRSEKAR

Yusuf Kapasi, 80, owner of Gulab Traders, said packaging every item was "practically impossible" for his business. He argued that enforcement should focus on sellers using harmful chemicals and colours to adulterate spices, including some roadside vendors, rather than treating all traditional traders alike.

Customers travelled from across Maharashtra to buy from his shop, Kapasi said. One customer from Pune, who had come to stock up for his family, said the relationship with the store went back generations.

"It is about quality and trust. My mother used to buy from them, and now my wife also urges me to buy from them whenever I come to Mumbai," he said. At Vivek Stores, a shop with a history of around 100 years, Chandrakant Jadhav said loose spices were ground and stored in airtight jars under hygienic conditions.

"If we package everything, customers will be forced to buy packets. Once spices are packaged, people cannot assess the quality for themselves in the same way," he said.

Smaller manufacturers are also concerned about the additional expenditure. Sachin Shinde of Shindraj Masala, a business operating since 1962, said packaging would require additional staff and spending on labelling. The business currently grinds spices and sells them in quantities chosen by customers.

"We will see what happens at the association meeting with the FDA officials," he said. For small vendors, the financial burden could be harder to absorb. "We are daily wagers, this is our only way of income. If we cannot do this, then we don't know how else to survive in this city," said a pushcart vendor selling powdered spices in Dadar.

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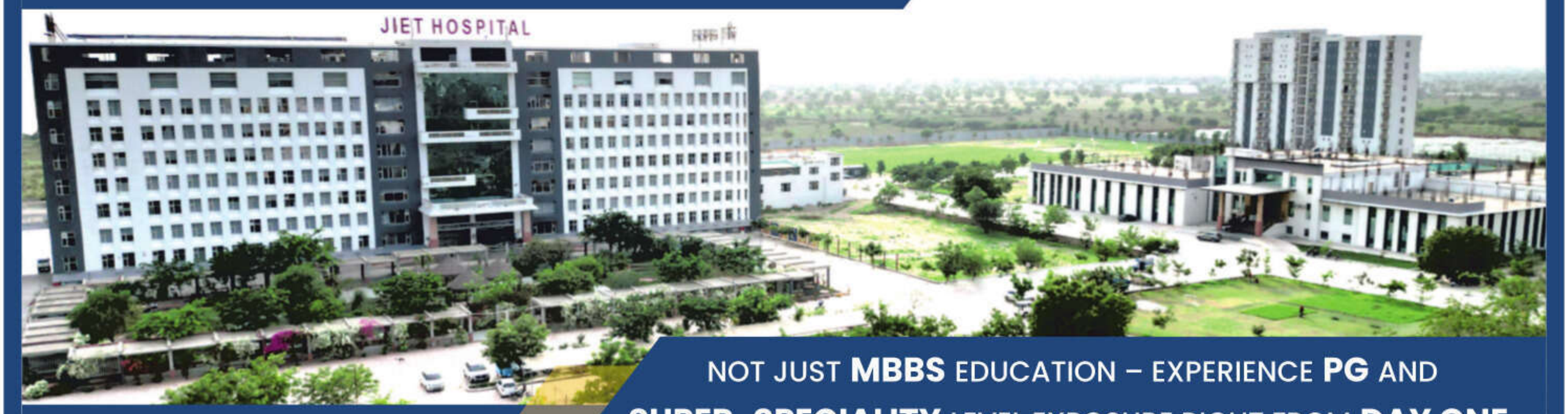
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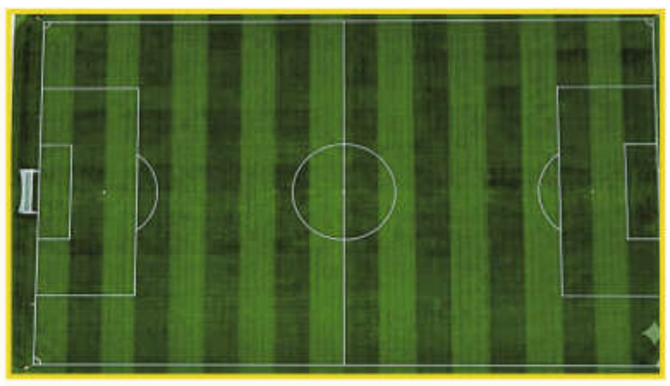
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State govt makes display of hospital rates in Marathi, English mandatory

Express News Service
Mumbai, October 16

PRIVATE HOSPITALS and clinics across Maharashtra will have to prominently display rates for medical services and treatment packages in Marathi and English. The state government has directed authorities to take administrative and legal action against establishments that fail to comply. A government resolution (GR) issued by the Public Health Department on Friday said rates specified under Schedule III of the Maharashtra Nursing Homes Registration Rules, 2021, must be displayed at clearly visible and accessible locations within hospital premises.

The directive also requires hospitals to inform patients and their relatives about applicable charges and treatment packages. Staff at registration desks, enquiry counters and billing sections must guide visitors to the rate lists to prevent confusion and complaints over bills.

Hospitals treating foreign patients arriving on medical or Ayush visas must separately display the package rates applicable to international patients, the GR said. The government said the requirement to display rates was already part of the existing rules. The latest directive follows instructions issued by the Union Ministry of Health and Family Welfare on October 12 and aims to bring greater transparency to healthcare costs, allowing patients to plan expenses and make informed decisions.

MILLERS FLAG DROUGHT LOSSES

Raju Shetti steps up stir to halt sugarcane crushing

Shubham Kurale
Pune, October 16



Shetti (centre) has asked factories to suspend cane crushing. EXPRESS

SWABHIMANI SHETKARI Sanghatana president Raju Shetti has stepped up his agitation for higher sugar and ethanol prices, asking cooperative sugar factories to suspend cane crushing until the Centre decides on farmers' key demands.

Shetti, a former MP, and his organisation have spent the past few days on the roads of western Maharashtra, stopping cane transport to the mills. On Tuesday, he led a blockade of the Pune-Bengaluru national highway that lasted 32 hours. He has since been visiting cooperative mills in Karnataka, Satara, Sangli and neighbouring areas, urging management to hold back operations.

On Thursday, party activists occupied weighbridges at several prominent factories in Sangli and Satara districts in a 'Kaata Band' (weighbridge shutdown) agitation. Shetti said the chimneys would not be lit until the Centre raises the minimum selling price (MSP) of sugar. Although the crushing season has officially begun, most mills have yet to start.

Shetti wants the MSP of sugar raised from the present Rs 31 per kg (Rs 3,100 per quintal) to Rs 50 per kg (Rs 5,000 per quintal). He also wants the price of ethanol made from C-heavy molasses increased to Rs 70 per litre. Paying farmers better would be feasible only with a higher sugar MSP and ethanol procurement prices, he said. The MSP, the floor price at which mills can legally sell sugar in the wholesale market, has stayed at Rs 31 per kg since February 2019, even as cane procurement costs have risen. On Wednesday, the Centre set up a committee headed by professor Ramesh Chand, a former NITI Aayog member, to examine the demand for higher payments to cane growers and a revision of the sugar MSP. The panel will look at cultivation costs and the financial health of mills.

Shetti said mills had started crushing under government pressure, even though they knew that processing immature cane hurts both farmers and factories. He criticised them for staying silent while the MSP remained frozen. "This year, farmers are in a decisive battle on the streets against the Centre's unjust policies," he told the Indian Express. A higher MSP, he argued, would benefit mill owners even more than farmers, so they should openly back the movement and resist political and official pressure. Any mill that chooses to operate, he warned, would bear the full responsibility for the losses that follow. Shivaji Mane, founder of the Jai Shivray Kisan Sanghatana, said, "The input costs had climbed because of costlier fertilisers, linked to the West Asia conflict, along with higher labour costs and erratic weather. So we seek a sugar MSP of Rs 55 per kg."

Mane also questioned the fair and remunerative price (FRP) for the 2026-27 season, fixed at Rs 3,650 per tonne for a basic recovery rate of 10.25 per cent, and said the recovery rate had been inflated and should revert to 8.5 per cent in the interest of farmers. Millers support the price demands but not necessarily the shutdown.

Speaking to the Indian Express, Bhairavnath Thombare, chairperson of the Western India Sugar Mills Association (WISMA), said, "We support Shetti's call for an MSP hike and appreciate his efforts to take the issue to the Centre. With the sugar MSP at Rs 31 per kg and the sugarcane FRP at Rs 3,650 per tonne, mills cannot survive or pay farmers adequately without an increase in both sugar and ethanol prices."

But Thombare cautioned that a delay in crushing would hurt farmers as well. He said, "Maharashtra's sugar output could fall by nearly 20 per cent, as drought has hit the majority of regions of the state except some parts in Satara, Sangli and Kolhapur. In Marathwada, 40-50 per cent of the cane is drying up and losing weight, and some mills elsewhere have begun harvesting such cane on priority. I urge farmer organisations to let mills start while continuing to press their other demands."

A Kolhapur-based miller said mills there also supported higher MSP and ethanol rates, adding that rising power tariffs too needed review. His mill had not yet begun crushing but planned to start within a week, he said, and he felt that mills should start now, since water shortages are expected in the coming months and early harvesting would help.

Bombay HC reserves order on appeal against Sachin Waze bail

NIA claims threat to Ambani family affects India's economic security

Express News Service
Mumbai, October 16

THE BOMBAY High Court on Friday concluded the hearing on an appeal by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) against bail granted to dismissed police officer Sachin Waze in the 2021 Antilia bomb scare and Mansukh Hiran murder cases, and reserved its order. The bench continued the stay on the bail order until the pronouncement of the order.

Waze was arrested by the NIA for playing a crucial role in the 2021 cases, involving an explosives-laden SUV found near the Mumbai residence of industrialist Mukesh Ambani, and the subsequent murder of businessman Mansukh Hiran.

Justifying the invocation of Section 15 of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), related to the conduct of a terrorist act, against Waze, Additional Solicitor General Anil Singh, in his rejoinder for the NIA, claimed that if anything happened to a prominent industrialist in India, it would be a loss to the economic security of the nation. Waze's lawyer had claimed that Section 15 required an intent to threaten the sovereignty of India or strike terror in the general public.

"The terror has to be felt by the victim and it cannot be decided by the accused. Merely because the accused feels nobody was terrorised...Even the special judge (who granted bail) accepts in his finding that if something happens to the richest industrialist in the country, there would be an issue of economic security," ASG Singh argued.

He added that the definition of a terrorist act under the UAPA was "wide" and every act of the accused, including the placing of an explosive substance, was required to be looked into by a special court. The NIA also referred to the "threat note" to the industrialist's family along with the gelatin, and another note on Telegram, which a "terrorist gang" called "Jaish-ul-Hind' later denied to have issued, "also gave a communal angle".

"Therefore, consequences may be considered as it was not some private issue taking place and it was not a simple threat note," the NIA lawyer argued, adding that he could not seek bail on grounds of parity with other accused. Rejecting the Special Court's observation that the NIA failed to record statements proving that the Ambani family was terrorised, ASG Singh stated that statements of three persons from the family's security team, including its in-charge, who was also from the police department, were recorded, which the special judge did not consider; therefore, the bail order was required to be set aside.

MPSC member Satish Waghole given additional charge as chairman

Express News Service
Mumbai, October 16

THE MAHARASHTRA government on Friday assigned the additional charge of Maharashtra Public Service Commission (MPSC) chairman to commission member Satish Waghole.

The post fell vacant after MPSC chairman Vivek Bhimanwar went on leave following the announcement of a committee headed by retired justice Dilip Bhosle to investigate the alleged MPSC examination paper leak. The committee has been given two months to complete its inquiry. The notification constituting the inquiry committee will be issued after the Governor's approval, following which it will begin its work. Bhimanwar had proceeded to go on leave, stating that he had always prioritised ethics throughout his life.

On Wednesday, the state government also assigned the additional charge of MPSC secretary to Mumbai Suburban Collector Saurabh Katiyar. The post fell vacant after the transfer of former secretary Mahendra Harpalkar amid student protests over alleged paper leaks in MPSC recruitment examinations.

SC issues notice to Sanjay Raut, journalist over remarks on CJI

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 16



Sanjay Raut allegedly made remarks critical of the CJI for not meeting Rahul Gandhi. FILE

THE SUPREME Court on Friday issued notice on a petition seeking contempt of court proceedings against Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut and journalist Nikhil Wagle for remarks against Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant.

A bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi issued notice on the petition filed by the Supreme Court Bar Association (SCBA). Appearing for the petitioner association, its president, senior advocate Pradeep Rai, said, "We are pained to initiate this. One is a responsible journalist, one a member of Parliament. Ultimately, we had thought that if we ignore this now, there are so many others who are instigated by this and they are doing something utterly inappropriate."

Rai said such actions bring disrepute to the institution. After the bench issued notice, Rai urged the court to seek their personal presence.

"People don't understand they are being trapped," the CJI said. Backing the SCBA plea, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta said, "Many of them understand. They do it deliberately. They misunderstand that it will not bring pressure on court. They believe it will bring pressure. Attempt is that, may be a futile one."

The CJI said at least one of the two alleged contemnors has been coming to the court in matters of personal liberty, etc. in the past also and "courts have never lagged behind in protecting those rights. If you still keep on condemning, inciting, taking left and right, it's very unfortunate, very very unfortunate".

The bench said it is exempting them from personal appearance for the first hearing. "We are giving a show cause... as of now we are granting exemption for personal appearance. Let us see," the CJI said.

On Thursday too, the Supreme Court, while taking up the petition by Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi and other INDIA bloc leaders challenging the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls and the functioning of the Election Commission, had asked Raut, who is one of the petitioners, to explain his conduct. The court said in its order that "...the petition on behalf of Petitioner No. 6 is entertained on a provisional basis, subject to his explaining his conduct".

Raut allegedly made remarks critical of the CJI for not meeting Rahul Gandhi, who had sought an appointment to raise issues related to Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and the SIR. Wagle too allegedly used certain abusive words for the CJI but later deleted them.

Sanjay Raut's 'save democracy' reminder comes with 'apology'

Express News Service
Mumbai, October 16

A DAY after the Supreme Court asked Shiv Sena (UBT) MP Sanjay Raut to explain his remarks on Chief Justice Surya Kant, the Shiv Sena MP said that he was ready to apologise but emphasised that the "responsibility to save democracy" rests with the top court.

Speaking to the media, Sanjay Raut said he had been seeking justice for four years over the Shiv Sena's party symbol and that the resulting anger may have led him to use an inappropriate word. He said that he was ready to apologise "10 times" for it. "If a wrong word has come out of my mouth, I will tell the Supreme Court that I apologise 10 times. But the responsibility to save democracy in this country is yours," Sanjay Raut said. His remarks come a day after the Supreme Court asked him to explain his conduct over comments critical of CJI Surya Kant.

Sanjay Raut further said that the Supreme Court was the "last ray of hope" for those seeking justice and said he would continue to approach it. His comments followed the controversy after the Chief Justice refused to meet a delegation of Opposition leaders to submit a memorandum on alleged irregularities in the Election Commission's Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of voter lists.



NARENDRA VASKAR

The season of devotion

At the Vashi cultural association Durga Puja in Navi Mumbai; (below) Shruti Shekhar of Thane arranges the Golu dolls for Navratri. The tradition has been followed by her family for over 100 years.



DEEPAK JOSHI

Over 1 lakh investors hit by stock crash after WhatsApp tips, ED raids 29 premises

Groups operated from Gujarat; SIM cards obtained from Haryana as well as Mumbai

Express News Service
Mumbai, October 16

ENFORCEMENT DIRECTORATE (ED), Mumbai Office Friday conducted search operations at 29 premises across Mumbai, Nashik, Ahmedabad, Gandhinagar, Surat and Bhavnagar after over one lakh suffered heavy losses from investing in 'multibagger' stocks following tips on WhatsApp.

The ED raids, conducted under the provisions of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, later revealed manipulation of the shares of listed companies including M/s R M Drip and Sprinklers Systems Ltd and M/s R&B Denims Ltd. The premises searched include the offices of the two companies, the residences of their promoters, of persons to whom shares were allotted at low prices, offices of stock-broking and finance firms, and premises of persons suspected to have operated the promotional WhatsApp groups, an official said.

The investigation carried out under the provisions of PMLA, 2002 revealed that between April 2023 and March 2024, the two companies issued over 3.5 crore shares and convertible warrants, to selected persons and entities.

A large part of the money paid for these shares came from a small circle of connected persons, firms and lenders, the agency said.

Over the following months, the share prices were steadily pushed up, while the shares had largely continued to stay in the same hands.

The investigation also revealed that from the end of December 2025 to February 2026, WhatsApp communities with names such as "Multibagger Stocks" sent daily "buy" tips on these shares to gullible retail investors.

These groups were run on SIM cards obtained in the names of other persons in Haryana and Mumbai, but operated from Bhavnagar, Gujarat.

Lured by the tips, the number of buyers in the two shares rose from about 3,400 to over 1 lakh, an official said.

On February 25 this year, the WhatsApp groups were suddenly deleted, triggering a major fall into the price of the shares, losing about 70 per cent of their value within days.

The drop left more than one lakh small investors with heavy losses and shares that could not be sold. During the search operations, various incriminating documents, digital devices, records of share transactions and property documents have been found and seized.

Nagpur Rural Police bust Rs 9.88 crore cyber fraud

Express News Service
Nagpur, October 16

NAGPUR RURAL Police have busted an alleged inter-state cyber fraud involving Rs 9.88 crore and arrested six accused, including an advocate practising before the Bombay and Delhi High Courts. Police have recovered Rs 4.21 crore of the defrauded amount.

According to police, a victim under the jurisdiction of Wadoda police station lost Rs 9,88,83,999 through RTGS transactions between July 4 and 6, 2026, without clicking any link or sharing an OTP. Investigators are probing the possibility of SIM swapping.

The six accused, arrested from Uttar Pradesh, Jharkhand, Delhi and Mumbai, have been identified as Hanuman Kumar Khakhanu Ram (26), Ravikumar Ramvriksha Yadav (24), Azim Rafique Mithani (26), Mukeshkumar Shamshankar Mishra (41), Rakesh Sailesh Singh (44) and Ankur Ashokkumar Goswami (30).

Gadchiroli farmers' road blockade called off after written assurance

Ankita Deshkar
Nagpur, October 16

FARMERS PROTESTING land acquisition for a proposed steel project by the Maharashtra Industrial Development Corporation (MIDC) in Gadchiroli's Chamorshi tehsil called off their agitation late Friday evening after police and administration officials gave them a written assurance that Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis would meet a selected group of protesting farmers. They warned that they would resume the protest on November 2 if their concerns were not addressed.

Hundreds of farmers from Bhendala, Yenapur and Jairampur had begun the chakka jam (road blockade) at Chamorshi's main square around 12.30 pm on Thursday, disrupting traffic on the Mul-Ashti road and the national highway. The agitation had intensified following fresh land acquisition notices, despite an earlier assurance that the process would be kept on hold.

Satish Pimpalshende, a 35-year-old farmer from Kishtapur, said he had received a notice concerning his three-acre farm and had submitted his objections. "There are 11 members in my family. How can we simply give away our farmland?" Pimpalshende said.

The MIDC proposes to acquire around 3,000 to 3,500 hectares across 14 villages for the integrated steel plant planned by the JSW Group. The conglomerate plans to develop the project with an investment of around Rs 1 lakh crore.

Year after surrender, former Maoist couple welcomes baby

Ankita Deshkar
Nagpur, October 16



Kamlesh and his wife, Manjula

ON FRIDAY, phones of surrendered Maoist cadres and officials in Gadchiroli buzzed with a photograph of a baby boy. The newborn is the child of a couple who surrendered along with former Maoist leader Mallojula Venugopal on October 15 last year.

For Kamlesh alias Nanda Nuppo and his wife, Manjula alias Rame Kunjam, October 7 marked the beginning of a new chapter. The couple welcomed their first child, a baby boy, months after Kamlesh underwent surgery to reverse his vasectomy following their surrender in Gadchiroli.

"Abhi toh bahut khushi hui hai. Aage uski padhai par dhyaan denge (I am very happy right now. We will focus on the child's education)," Kamlesh told The Indian Express.

Both the mother and baby are doing well, he said. Manjula delivered the baby at a government hospital in Sukma, Chhattisgarh.

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PLEA ON FIR CHALLENGE

ED summons Pinarayi after SC declines urgent hearing

Express News Service
Thiruvananthapuram, New Delhi, October 16



Pinarayi Vijayan

HOURS AFTER the Supreme Court declined an urgent hearing on former Kerala chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan's plea challenging a Kerala High Court order directing the registration of an FIR against him in the alleged Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd (CMRL)-Exalogic bribery case, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) summoned him to appear at its Kochi zonal office on October 23.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi said it would consider constituting a bench during the Dussehra vacations or take up the matter when the court reopens on October 26. Appearing for Vijayan, senior advocate Siddharth Luthra urged the bench to take up the plea that day, citing the risk of arrest.

"The threat is because now the FIR is registered. All I am saying is, let him be protected, because that is my concern. Otherwise, an 82-year-old gentleman will be put in custody," Luthra told the bench.

He contended that the single bench that passed the order in a writ petition in the nature of a public interest litigation (PIL) did not have the roster for PILs.

The senior counsel added that the High Court issued the direction without hearing the accused and had also refused to grant leave to appeal.

Besides Vijayan, his daughter and co-accused Veena T and son-in-law Muhammed Riyas have also approached the Supreme Court.

The developments come a day after a division bench of the Kerala High Court dismissed Vijayan's appeals challenging a single-bench order directing the state's Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB) to register an FIR in the case without further delay.

The VACB had registered an FIR against Vijayan and others on Monday. A day later, the ED registered two Enforcement Case Information Reports — its equivalent of an FIR — against Vijayan and his family members under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act.

In May, the ED raided several premises linked to Vijayan and allegedly recovered documents indicating a money trail.

The VACB had booked Vijayan, his daughter Veena T, son-in-law Muhammed Riyas and others under the Prevention of Corruption Act days earlier, alleging that Cochin Minerals and Rutile Limited (CMRL) paid a bribe of Rs 3.28 crore to Veena's IT firm, Exalogic Solutions, "disguised" as consultation charges.

Sudhakar Dalela is next envoy to Nepal

Divya A
New Delhi, October 16

SUDHAKAR DALELA, presently Secretary in the Ministry of External Affairs and who led the negotiations for the BRICS declaration, has been appointed as India's next envoy to Nepal.

He will succeed Naveen Srivastava, who recently completed his three-year term and retired. A day earlier, Nepal had cleared the name of Nischal Nath Pandey as Nepal's ambassador to India.

The appointments come in the wake of New Delhi and Kathmandu engaging to work out the first bilateral visit of Prime Minister Balen Shah to India next month.



Sudhakar Dalela will succeed Naveen Srivastava

The appointment of a secretary-level officer to Kathmandu is also a step up from previous practice, where India dispatched Additional Secretary-rank officials to Kathmandu. This upgrade in the seniority of the Indian envoy signals elevated importance given to the bilateral relationship in the neighbourhood.

Announcing Dalela's appointment on Friday evening, the Ministry of External Affairs said that he is expected to take up the assignment shortly.

Dalela served as India's ambassador to Bhutan between 2022 and 2025. In September last year, he was appointed as Secretary, Economic Relations, handling India's economic diplomacy; development partnership with countries in the Global South, multilateral economic relations. He has been India's Sherpa for BRICS, IBSA, and I2U2.

With the BRICS divided and polarised due to the war in West Asia, India had the difficult task to bridge the gap between UAE and Iran. It was widely perceived to be a diplomatically challenging task to come up with a BRICS declaration.

But, Dalela, as the BRICS Sherpa (the chief negotiator), led a team of negotiators and managed to build a consensus that led to the declaration.

His experience in multilateral negotiations came in handy, and is expected to be an important diplomatic skill in his tool-kit.

In fact, Dalela has served in critical roles in New Delhi, including Director in the Prime Minister's Office (2009-2011) during Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's stint, focusing on India's engagement with its South Asian neighbours.

Kuki-Zo woman killed after ambush in Manipur

Leivon Jimmy
Imphal, October 16

A KUKI-ZO woman was killed and two other civilians went missing after suspected militants ambushed four villagers travelling on two-wheelers in Manipur's Kamjong district on Thursday evening.

The incident comes a week after nine people were killed in a series of separate violent incidents involving the Naga and Kuki-Zo communities in Manipur's hill districts.

The attack occurred between 4 pm and 5 pm on the road between Molnoi and Phaikoh, when four residents of Chassad village were on their way to buy essential commodities, sources said. The victim was identified as Hatneikim Haokip. Her husband, Jangkhongam Haokip, sustained bullet injuries and escaped. Another couple, D Paokhothang Haokip and his wife, Boishi Haokip, remained missing till late Thursday night. Hatneikim's body was recovered later in the night.

Security forces and villagers launched search operations to trace the missing couple.

Deputy CM Nemcha Kipgen condemned the attack, describing it as a "grave criminal act".

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F.No. P-342/Pr.CCIT/Sports Quota Recruitment/2026-27/10703 **Date: 01/10/2026**

The Principal Chief Commissioner of Income Tax, Delhi Region, invites applications from meritorious sportspersons for recruitment to the following posts under the Sports Quota. Eligible candidates must meet the criteria prescribed in the detailed notification available on the Department's website **www.incometaxdelhi.gov.in.**

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Complete details regarding educational qualifications, sports eligibility conditions, selection procedure and instructions to candidates are available in the detailed notification. Eligible candidates may submit their application through online mode only by clicking on Sports Recruitment tab available on Department's website **www.incometaxdelhi.gov.in.** Applications in any other form will not be entertained. Incomplete applications will be rejected summarily.

Opening date for online application: 17.10.2026
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The borrowers concerned and the public at large are hereby informed that a public auction of gold jewellery/ornaments pledged as security in the loan accounts listed below is proposed to be conducted. These items were pledged by borrowers who have defaulted in repaying their dues as per the terms of the executed Loan Agreements, despite reminders issued by HDFC Bank Limited ("the Bank") directing them to clear their outstanding amounts.

The Bank had earlier issued notices granting the borrowers seven (7) days' time to repay the full outstanding dues in their respective loan accounts. As the borrowers have failed to regularize their accounts, the Bank, in exercise of its rights as pledgee under the Loan Agreement and applicable law, has decided to enforce the pledge and proceed with the sale of the pledged gold jewellery/ornaments by way of public auction to recover the dues.

The auction will be conducted at the branch(es) mentioned below from 3:30 p.m. onwards. If, for any reason, the auction of any pledged security cannot be conducted or completed on the scheduled date, the Bank reserves the right to continue or reschedule the auction on any subsequent date and time without further notice.

S. No.	Loan No.	Borrower's Name	Loan Amount (₹)	Place of Auction (Branch Address)	Date of Auction
1	4000753433	Nandita T Momaya	241000	HDFC Bank Ltd Anchorage Building, 170/171 Central Avenue, Chembur, Mumbai, Maharashtra 400071	27-10-2026
2	4001083634	Kiran Ramesh Bansode	211000	Shop No. 30 To 32 And 34 To 36, Vrundavan Shopping Centre, Near Evershine Gate, Vasai East, Mumbai, Maharashtra 401208	17-11-2026
3	4000897200	Prabhakar Bhagwan Upadhye	285000	Shop No. 1 And Shop No.2, Ground Floor, Fp No. 25, CTS No 5953, Bhaveshwar Bldg No.3, Bhaveshwar Lan, Mumbai, Maharashtra 400077	17-11-2026
4	4000593151	Vandana Anand Mishra	108000	Shreeram Trade Centre, Svp Road, Chamunda Circle, Opp Jain Temple, Borivali West, Mumbai, Maharashtra 400092	17-11-2026
5	4001273614	Ganesh Vitthal Mahadik	177000	Pranik Gardens, Pranik Arcade, Shop No 8/9/10/11, Mahavir Nagar, Kandivali West, Mumbai, Maharashtra 400067	17-11-2026
6	74346596	Ankit Harisingh Thagele	158861.2	HDFC Bank Ltd, Ground Floor, Varma Niwas Building, Shastrinagar, Opp Khopoli Police Station, Raigad, Khopoli, Maharashtra 410203	17-11-2026
7	4001541359	Vishal Dnyaneshwar Kharpude	180000	HDFC bank ltd Arizona Buld, Shop No.5, Opp. Kishin Leela Tower, Hardaswadi, Ganesh Purshottam Pai Road, Thane, Maharashtra 400603.	27-10-2026
8	4001029229	Ajay Mohan Bhosale	276000	HDFC BANK LTD, Ground & 1st Floor, Louisandra, Gokhale Road, Near Portuguese Church, Dadar West 400028.	17-11-2026
9	4000051610	Monu Ramavtar Yadav	140000	HDFC bank ltd Shop No.5-5A, Krishna Regency, Sunder Nagar, Near Dalmia College, Malad West, Mumbai, Maharashtra 400064	27-10-2026
10	76125635	Hussain Zakiyuddin Chawdiwala	97300	HDFC bank ltd Pardeshi Pura, Near Nagar Parishad, Nandurbar, Nandurbar, Maharashtra 425412	27-10-2026
11	4001208806	K Pravin Anand Shetty	320000	HDFC Bank Ltd., Upper & Lower Ground Floor, Hotel Sagar	17-11-2026
12	4000411655	Nilesh Ashok Kamble	57900	Inn, Sr. No 72/2/15 Manjari Bk. Pune Solapur Road, Maharashtra 412307	17-11-2026
13	4001510745	Sandhya Shrikant Gatkal	1169000	HDFC Bank Ltd., Ground And First Floor, Swami Chandraprakash Amarpur Dham (Trust) Opp To APMC Market, Dindori Road, Panchavati Nashik Maharashtra 422003.	17-11-2026
14	4001330025	Mayur Navnath Shingade	165000	HDFC Bank LTD., 71, Kapad Bazar M. G. Road, Main Bazar Peth , Shirur, Dist Pune-412210. Maharashtra	17-11-2026
15	76008257	Pranjal Pradeep Bagave	45200	HDFC Bank Ltd, Krishna Rajani Avenue, Near Kudal Post Office, Ganeshnagar, Kudal, Maharashtra 416502	17-11-2026
16	4001352823	Ravindra Ashok Dalavi	168000	HDFC Bank Ltd, C S No 506 K, Sirpiraji Road, A/P Murgud, Tal-Kagal Dist-Kolhapur, Murgud, Maharashtra 416219	17-11-2026
17	75701640	Suraj Prafulla Pawar	90000	Near Deepak Trading, Next To Bus Stand, S No 255/D, Dist - Buldhana, Malkapur, Maharashtra 443101	27-10-2026
18	4000990648	Aslam Ali Nusrat Ali	55700	Durga Chambers, Bus Stand Road, Dist - Akola, Akot, Maharashtra	27-10-2026
19	75577905	Gorakh Naganath Bagal	22300	HDFC Bank Ltd, Golwalkar Complex, Near Sargam Cinema, Dist - Solapur, Pandharpur, Maharashtra 413304	27-10-2026
20	75728743	Yogesh Popat Shinde	189000	HDFC Bank Ltd, Shop No 3, 4 And 5 Labh Avanue, Sector 11, Dist - Raigad, Kalamboli, Maharashtra 410218.	27-10-2026
21	76075367	Mayur Shahaji Borawane	83000	Gat No 2603, Pune Nagar Road, Hotel Sai Executive Lodging,	27-10-2026
22	75602962	Mayur Shahaji Borawane	50000	Opp Rakshak Hospital, Pabal Chowk, Pune, Maharashtra 412208	27-10-2026
23	4000698275	Gaurav Padamakar Davile	177200	HDFC bank ltd Opposite Medha Petrol Pump, Near Bus-Stand, Talegaon Road, Arvi, Maharashtra 442201	27-10-2026
24	75584568	Gausiya Azim Shaikh	200000	Shop No.15-20, Ground Floor, Dosti Aster, New Uphill Link Road, New Dosti Acres, Off Sm Rd, Wadala E, Mumbai, Maharashtra 400037	17-11-2026
25	4001484419	Parmeshwar Suryabhan Chamle	176000	HDFC bank ltd Ground Floor, Bulbule Complex, Behind Kadam Hospital, Nanded-Latur Road, Ahmadpur, Ahmadpur, Maharashtra 413515.	27-10-2026
26	4000649285	Akshay Vitthal Jagadhane	55500	Dnyaneshwar Complex, Miraj Road, At Post Sangole, Tal Sangole, Dist Solapur, Solapur, Maharashtra 413307	27-10-2026
27	75709383	Kailas Kisan Karande	42000		27-10-2026
28	4001365250	Sachin Chandrkant Markad	110400	Ground Floor, Hande Complex, Karmala Road, A/P. Tembhurni, Tal - Madha. Dist-Solapur, Solapur, Maharashtra 413211	17-11-2026
29	4001264519	Sachin Chandrkant Markad	70400		17-11-2026
30	76046975	Somnath Bajrang Shinde	203000	HDFC Bank Ltd., Ground Floor, Kurul Rd, Near Mseb Office, Opp. SBI, Vijapur Bypass, Mohol, Dist. Solapur, Maharashtra - 413213.	27-10-2026
31	4000386548	Imrankhan Babu Pathan	109000	HDFC Bank Ltd., 1St Floor, Opposite St Bus Stand, Manchar, Maharashtra 410503	27-10-2026
32	4001009560	Jadhav Sandip Bhimrao	76400	HDFC Bank Ltd, Shaguna Vyapari Sankul, Naldurg Road, Tuljapur Dist Osmanabad., Tuljapur, Maharashtra 413601	27-10-2026
33	74488601	Nilesh Ashok Kamble	48000	HDFC Bank Ltd, Ground Floor, Shop No 1, Gera Grand Society, Near Vrindawan Garden, T P No 438, Pune, Maharashtra 411037	17-11-2026

The auction shall be carried out strictly on an "AS IS WHERE IS", "AS IS WHAT IS", and "WHATEVER THERE IS" basis. The Bank makes no warranty or representation, express or implied, regarding the quality, purity, caratage, weight, or valuation of the pledged gold jewellery/ornaments. Prospective bidders are solely responsible for inspecting and satisfying themselves regarding the condition, purity, caratage, weight, and valuation of the pledged items prior to placing their bids. Inspection will be permitted 45 minutes before the auction, entirely at the bidders' cost, risk, and discretion.

By participating in the auction, bidders shall be deemed to have independently inspected the pledged items and to accept all associated risks without any reliance on representations by the Bank. No requests for return, exchange, refund, compensation, or cancellation will be entertained after the sale has been concluded.

All bids shall be subject to a minimum reserve price determined by the Bank in accordance with applicable regulatory norms. The auction value will be based on the lower of: (a) the average closing price of gold for the preceding thirty (30) days, or (b) the closing price of gold published by the India Bullion and Jewellers Association Ltd. (IBJA) on the immediately preceding day. The Bank retains sole discretion to finalise the reserve price and impose any additional conditions as deemed necessary.

Should any borrower repay the entire outstanding dues in accordance with the Loan Agreement before commencement of the auction, the pledged gold jewellery/ornaments for that account may, at the Bank's discretion, be withdrawn from the auction without further notice.

The auction and any resulting sale shall remain subject to any further terms and conditions that the Bank, in its sole and absolute discretion, may impose, amend, or prescribe from time to time.

Please note that the undersigned Authorized Officer of the Bank reserves the right to postpone, adjourn, modify, suspend, or cancel the auction proceedings without prior notice and without assigning any reason. The Authorized Officer also reserves the right to accept or reject any bid(s), in whole or in part, and any such decision shall be final and binding on all participants.

DATE : 17.10.2026
PLACE : MAHARASHTRA

SD/- AUTHORIZED OFFICER,
HDFC BANK LTD.

KERALA WATER AUTHORITY e-Tender Notice

Tender No: KWA/SP-07/2026-27/LIME
Supply and delivery of Hydrated Lime Grade C on running contract basis to various Divisions in Southern, Central and NorthernRegions of Kerala Water Authority for the year 2026-27 **EMD:** Rs. 555400 **Tender fee:** Rs. 25000 **Last Date for submitting Tender:** 30-10-2026 03:00:pm **Phone:** 8547638078 **Website:** www.kwa.kerala.gov.in, www.etenders.kerala.gov.in

Sd/-
Chief Engieer (HRD&Gl.)
Jalabhavan
Thiruvananthapuram

KWA-JB-GL-6-356-2026-27

Medical College & Hospital
Employees' State Insurance Corporation
(Ministry of Labour & Employment, Govt. of India)
Nr. New Civil Hospital, Majura Gate, Surat. (ISO 9001-2015 Certified)
Phone: 0261-2402374 • Email: dean-naroda.gj@esic.gov.in
Website: www.mchsurat.esic.gov.in / www.esic.gov.in

Rolling Advertisement no 02/2026

WALK-IN INTERVIEW

Walk in interview for Recruitment of Senior Residents, Assistant Professor, Associate Professor and Professors on Contract basis will be held on **26/10/2026 & 27/10/2026** for various departments.

This is a rolling interview. These interviews will be conducted on **every 4th monday** every month till December 2026. If 4th monday happens to be on Holiday, Interviews will be conducted on next working day.

Interested and eligible candidates are advised to check official website of ESIC (**www.esic.gov.in**) under Recruitment tab for detailed vacancy and terms & conditions.

-Sd/-
DEAN (I/c)
ESIC Medical College & Hospital, Surat

ADITYA BIRLA CAPITAL
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NOTICE

In terms of paragraph 11 of Reserve Bank of India (Non-Banking Financial Companies - Branch Authorisation) Directions, 2025 notice is hereby given that Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited proposes to close* the branch located at **Shop No. 101 to 105, First Floor, Siddhivinayak City Centre, Siddhivinayak Nagar, Shivajinagar, Ratnagiri - 415 612.** due to business consolidation. The nearest branch for contact is at **2nd Floor, Office No.- 202, 203, 204, 205, 206 & 215, Munoth Empress, F. P. 189, Opposite Panvel Bus Depot, Behind Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar Statue, Panvel, New Mumbai – 410206.**

***The branch will cease to operate after completion of three months' notice period as per regulatory norms.**

For Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd.
Sd/-
Authorized Signatory

Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Bebi Rizwana W/D/o Mohd Naim R/o 140 Mujahidpur Thana, Hussainpur City, Bhagalpur Bihar Also At:- Flat No. 207B, DCB Roshni Building, Rashmi Park, Shanti Park, Meera Road, Mumbai** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **case FIR No. 339/2013 U/s 420/467/468/471/174A/120B IPC & 12 PP Act PS: Indira Gandhi International Airport, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Bebi Rizwana** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Bebi Rizwana** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Bebi Rizwana** accused of **FIR No. 339/2013 U/s 420/467/468/471/174A/120B IPC & 12 PP Act PS: Indira Gandhi International Airport, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **14.01.2027.**

By Order
Sh. Pranav Joshi
ACJM-01, Room No.-02,
Ground Floor, Main Building
Patiala House Court, New Delhi

DP/14736/IGIA/2026
(Court Matter)

MITCON
Solutions for Sustainable Tomorrow

MITCON Power Trading Limited
(A subsidiary of MITCON Sun Power Limited)
Regd. Office: First Floor, Kubera Chambers, Shivajinagar, Pune-411 005
Telephone No.: +91 89563 15745, Fax: +91-20-2553 3206
Email: mptl@mitconindia.com Website: www.mitconindia.com
CIN: U35109PN2026PLC256879

NOTICE UNDER SUB-SECTION (2) OF SECTION 15 OF THE ELECTRICITY ACT, 2003

1) The person above-named, a company incorporated under the Companies Act, 2013 has made an application under sub-section (1) of Section 15 of the Electricity Act, 2003 for grant of Category-V license for inter State trading in electricity across India before the Central Electricity Regulatory Commission, New Delhi. The necessary details in respect of the applicant are given hereunder:

I) Share Capital in Rs Lakhs

(a) Authorised: 200
(b) Issued: 200
(c) Subscribed: 200
(d) Paid-up: 200

ii) Shareholding pattern (List of the shareholders holding 5% or more shares, numbers of shares held by each of them & % of share of the total paid up capital) of the applicant:

(a) Name: MITCON Sun Power Limited
(b) Citizenship: Indian
(c) Residential Status: India
(d) No. of shares held: 20,00,000
(e) Percentage holding of total paid up capital of the company: 100%

iii) The Applicant has a net worth of INR 200 lakhs and current ratio & liquidity ratio of 1:0 on the date of preparation of the special balance sheet. Applicant also fulfils technical qualifications under Regulations 3(2) of Trading License Regulations

iv) Management profile of the applicant including details of experience of the applicant and/or the persons on the management of the applicant in generation, transmission, distribution and trading of electricity or similar activity:

Mr. Dhawal Marghade: Director & Senior Vice President – Climate Change & Sustainability
Mr. Dhawal Marghade is a climate change and sustainability professional with over 13 years of experience, currently heading the Climate Change & Sustainability division at MITCON Consultancy & Engineering Services Ltd., Pune. He leads business development and delivery across carbon credits, GHG accounting, sustainability assurance, climate risk and biodiversity assessment. An Electrical & Electronics engineer with a PG Diploma in Thermal Power Plant Engineering, he is a BEE Certified Energy Auditor, a GARP-certified SCR Professional and an ACSAP by Account Ability, and has previously worked with TERI and Steag Energy Services. He has led multiple carbon credit projects under CDM and Verra VCS, and advises on BRSR, CBAM, TCFD/IFRS S2 and PCAF.

CA Gaurav Chaudhari: Senior Manager, Accounts
CA Gaurav Chaudhari is a Chartered Accountant and Information System Auditor (ISA) with over 10 years of experience in financial reporting, FP&A, internal audit and regulatory compliance. He is currently Assistant Vice President at MITCON Consultancy & Engineering Services Ltd., where he leads budgeting, cash flow projections, financial performance monitoring and division- and project-wise profitability analysis. He has consolidated financial statements for 17 group companies under Ind AS, supported ERP implementation and developed SOPs

v) Volume of electricity intended to be traded during the first year after grant of license and future plans of the application to expand volume of trading: Upto 500 Mus.

vi) Geographical areas within which the applicant will undertake trading in electricity: Across India

vii) Net worth as on 31st March of three consecutive years immediately preceding the year of application or for such lesser period as may be applicable and on the date of the special balance sheet accompanying the application:

Date	Net worth (INR in thousand)
18th September, 2026 (on date of special balance sheet)	20000
31st March 2026	NA
31st March 2025	NA
31st March 2024	NA

vii) Year-wise current ratio and liquidity ratio of the applicant for three years preceding the year in which the application is made, or for such lesser period as may be applicable and on the date of the special balance sheet accompanying the application:

Date	Current Ratio	Liquidity Ratio
18.09.2026	1:0	1:0

ix) (a) The applicant is authorized to undertake trading in electricity under the Memorandum of Association
(b) The specific provision is as:
"To establish and carry on the business as an energy trader, including purchase, sell, exchange, transmit, distribute, and dealing in electricity, power and energy, both conventional and non-conventional including inter-state and intra-state, through power exchanges, bilateral contracts, and open access mechanisms and other permitted modes, in accordance with the provisions of the Central Electricity Regulatory Commission (CERC), State Electricity Regulatory Commissions, Ministry of Power, Grid Controller of India Limited, and other applicable laws and regulations."

x) Details of cases, if any, where the applicant or any of his associates, or partner, or promoters, or Directors has been declared insolvent and has not been discharged: **NONE**

xi) Details of cases, if any, in which the Applicant or any of his Associates or partners or promoters or Directors has been convicted of an offence involving moral turpitude, fraud or any economic offence during the previous three years preceding the year of making the application and the year of making the applicant and the date of release of the above person from imprisonment, if any, consequent to such conviction: **NONE**

xii) Whether the Applicant or any of his Associates, or partners, or promoters, or Directors was ever refused license, and if so, the detailed particular of the application, date of making application, date of order refusing license and reasons for such refusal: **NO**

xiii) Whether the Applicant has been granted a license for transmission of electricity: **NO**

xiv) Whether an order cancelling the license of the Applicant, or any of his Associates, or partners, or promoters, or Directors has been passed by the Commission: **NO**

xv) Whether the Applicant or any of his Associates, or partners, or promoters, or Directors was ever found guilty in any proceedings for contravention non-compliance of any of the provisions of the Act or the rules or the regulations made there under or an order made by the Appropriate Commission, during the year of making the application or five years immediately preceding that year? **NO**

2) The application made and other documents filed before the Commission are available for inspection by any person with Mr. Dhawal Marghade, Director, 1st Floor, Kubera Chambers, Opposite Sancheti Hospital, Shivajinagar, Pune, Maharashtra 411005, Email: dhawal.marghade@mitconindia.com

3) The application made and other documents filed before the Commission have been posted on: https://www.mitconindia.com/group-companies/mitcon-power-trading-limited/

4) Objections or suggestions, if any, on the application made before the Commission may be sent to the Secretary, Central Electricity Regulatory Commission, 6th, 7th & 8th Floors, Tower B, World Trade Centre, Nauroji Nagar, New Delhi- 110029 E-mail: secy@cercind.gov.in within 30 days of publication of this notice, with a copy to the applicant.

5) No objections or suggestions shall be considered by the Commission if received after expiry of 30 days of publication of this notice.

Place: Pune
Date: October 16, 2026

For MITCON Power Trading Limited
Sd/-
Dhawal Marghade
Director

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DELHI CONFIDENTIAL



Prayers and Pep Talk

BJP PRESIDENT Nitin Nabin will embark on a two-day visit to Patna during the ongoing Durga Puja, which, according to party insiders, holds special significance for him as well as Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Nabin will visit different puja pandals in the city and seek the blessings of Goddess Durga. He will also participate in organisational meetings and interactive sessions with karyakartas and boost their morale at a time when the BJP-led NDA government finds itself confronting Opposition and civil society protests against CEC Gyanesh Kumar. On the first day, October 17, Nabin will visit the historic Dak Bungalow Chauraha pandal in Patna. On the second day, Nabin will visit multiple pandals before taking part in his scheduled programme from 9 am to 5.40 pm.

Busy Poll Calendar

WITH ASSEMBLY elections due in five states early next year, the Election Commission is sending teams of its senior officials to the states to oversee poll preparedness, before the visits by the poll panel itself. After visiting Uttarakhand earlier this week, the EC officials are set to travel to Manipur next week, followed by Punjab and then Uttar Pradesh in the first week of November, it is learnt. The visit to Goa is yet to be confirmed.

Centre amends Census rules

New Delhi: The Centre on Friday amended the Census Rules, 1990, allowing states and Union Territories to appoint teachers of "aided or unaided private bodies" as enumerators during the Census, in the backdrop of various HCs staying the orders of government officials requisitioning services of such staff.

A gazette notification said "teachers of any educational institution of the government, local authority, aided or unaided private bodies, societies; (ii) Clerks or any official of the central government, state government, local authority or establishment; (iii) Any person, as the state government or the Union Territory administration may consider suitable" can be appointed as Census officers. PTI

Spoke to PM Modi, he is visiting Canada on Dec 11-12, says Carney

Trade, energy, tech on the table, signals Indian mission

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, October 16

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi will visit Canada on December 11 and 12, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney and the Indian High Commission in Ottawa have officially confirmed.

PM Carney shared the news while speaking with visitors at a local restaurant in Calgary on Thursday morning. He said he "just spoke" to PM Modi about his upcoming visit. Carney said Modi will travel to Toronto and Ottawa, but added, "We'll see if we can broaden it out."

Later, the Indian High Commission in Ottawa posted on X: "PM Shri Narendra Modi will visit Canada on 11–12 December 2026. In the recent conversation with Rt. Hon. PM Mark Carney, both the leaders agreed to build on the positive momentum in ties and work towards concrete outcomes in trade, energy, technology, security and people-to-people ties."



PM Narendra Modi with his Canadian counterpart Mark Carney. FILE

Ministry of External Affairs' official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal on Friday said: "As you are aware, Foreign Minister of Canada visited India a few days back. She met with the External Affairs Minister (S Jaishankar) and discussed progress in bilateral ties. She also called on the Prime Minister. During the visit, the Prime Minister's visit to Canada came up for discussion. The dates for the visit are presently under discussion. We will announce the visit at the appropriate time."

PM Modi met visiting Foreign Minister of Canada Anita Anand on Wednesday and said India is committed to building a "constructive and forward-looking strategic partnership" with Canada that delivers "tangible benefits" to the people of both countries. Modi, after meeting Anand, said, "Pleased to meet Canadian Foreign Minister Anita Anand. We had a productive discussion on further strengthening India-Canada ties in trade, technology, security, energy, education and people-to-people exchanges."

"India is committed to building a constructive and forward-looking strategic partnership with Canada that delivers tangible benefits to the people of both countries," he posted on X.

During the meeting, PM Modi and Foreign Minister Anand discussed ongoing efforts to strengthen bilateral ties and expand cooperation in areas of mutual interest, including trade, science and technology, defence, security, energy, education, people-to-people ties and multilateral cooperation, the PM's Office said in a statement.

PM Modi emphasised the importance of sustaining momentum in bilateral engagement and translating it into tangible outcomes, including through early conclusion of negotiations on a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA), it said.

"They also exchanged views on regional and global developments of mutual interest," it said, adding that PM Modi conveyed his warm greetings to Prime Minister Carney and said that he looked forward to continuing their engagements.

Earlier that day, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar met Anand and said they "reviewed progress in our ties across trade and investment, education, energy, defence and people-to-people exchanges. Also exchanged views on key regional and global developments".

Advani admitted to hospital with chest infection

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 16

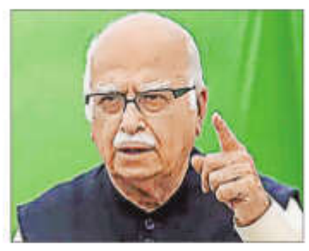
SENIOR BJP leader and former deputy prime minister Lal Krishna Advani was admitted to Apollo Hospital in the Capital on Friday evening with a chest infection.

He was brought to the hospital around 7.30 pm, said hospital officials. He has been admitted to the pulmonary department and is under observation by a team of doctors. Tests are underway, said the officials.

The 98-year-old leader was last admitted to Apollo in May this year due to age-related health complications. He was discharged after a few days.

Advani is among the architects of the modern BJP. He was party president for three terms — 1986 to 1990, 1993 to 1998 and 2004 to 2005.

On September 25, 1990, he set out on his Ram Rath Yatra from Somnath, a campaign that brought the Ram Temple movement from the margins to the centre of national politics. His yatra was halted following his arrest in Samastipur, Bihar, on October 23 that year.



Former deputy prime minister Lal Krishna Advani

On December 6, 1992, the Babri Masjid was demolished in Ayodhya. Years later, a special CBI court acquitted him and other accused in the demolition case.

In the NDA government led by Atal Bihari Vajpayee, Advani was Union Home Minister from 1998 to 2004, and Deputy Prime Minister from 2002 to 2004. The 1999 Kargil conflict and the 2001 attack on Parliament happened during his time in the Home Ministry.

Advani also served as Information and Broadcasting Minister in the Morarji Desai government from 1977 to 1979.

In 2024, he was awarded the Bharat Ratna, the country's highest civilian honour.

MHA portal to flag demographic changes gets 500 suggestions in two days

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 16

THE HIGH-LEVEL Committee (HLC) on demographic changes has received over 500 suggestions within two days of launching its dedicated web portal for people to provide details of unnatural demographic shifts.

The inputs will be used to develop a system for identification, detention and deportation of illegal immigrants residing in the country.

The Chairman of the Committee, Justice Prakash Prabhakar Naolekar (retd.), launched the portal — accessed via demography.mha.gov.in — on Wednesday (October 14) for public access, stakeholder submissions and data interaction.

"The portal facilitates Central government ministries/departments, state / UT governments, NGOs / institutions and individuals to give inputs / data / information on unnatural demographic changes, their causes and the underlying factors behind these changes, abnormal settlement patterns, etc," an MHA official said.

The official said the inputs will help the Committee analyse and identify the causes of demographic changes and recommend a well-organised, permanent operational system for the legal, fair and time-bound identification, detention and deportation of illegal immigrants residing in the country.

The Committee was constituted by the Ministry of Home Affairs on May 26.

EXPRESS special

Goa MLA claims over 50 voters transferred from one seat; CEO says will probe

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, October 16

LEGISLATOR AND Goa Forward Party chief Vijai Sardesai is learnt to have filed a complaint with the state's Chief Electoral Officer, alleging that some voters were illegally "transferred" from one assembly constituency to another in South Goa. The CEO told *The Indian Express* they will conduct an inquiry into the claim. Sardesai, the MLA from the Fatorda constituency, filed a formal complaint via email with the CEO's office on Friday, it is learnt.

In the complaint, Sardesai claimed that more than 50 voters from the Curtorim assembly constituency have been "unlawfully migrated" to the electoral rolls of the Fatorda assembly constituency, while retaining their original house numbers and therefore bypassing legal delimitation procedures.

"Those electors were part of the Curtorim assembly segment during the 2012 and 2017 general elections. However, they have mysteriously and illegally appeared in the electoral rolls of the Fatorda assembly constituency for the years 2022 and 2026... It has come to my specific notice that more than 50 voters, as detailed (in the) annexures attached to this representation, belonging to the Curtorim Assembly Constituency have been unlawfully migrated to the electoral rolls of the Fatorda Assembly Constituency while retaining their original house numbers...," he wrote in the complaint.



The matter was reported in South Goa

Sardesai said this raises concerns about the integrity and accuracy of electoral databases, compliance with notified constituency boundaries, and non adherence to procedures prescribed under the Representation of the People Act, 1950, the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, and relevant Election Commission of India guidelines.

"The territorial boundaries of an assembly constituency are strictly governed by the statutory delimitation orders and legally operative notifications. Electoral registration must strictly conform to these boundaries and the statutory requirements governing an elector's ordinary residence under the law," the complaint stated.

Claiming this is "merely the tip of the iceberg", Sardesai sought urgent intervention of the CEO office to inquire into the "unauthorised transfer of voters".

The complaint mentioned that the last general delimitation of Goa's assembly constituencies was conclusively carried out between 2002 and 2005, with final orders published in 2005 and subsequently incorporated into the Delimitation of Parliamentary and Assembly Constituencies Order, 2008.

Sardesai said the objective of the complaint is to safeguard the integrity of electoral rolls, uphold the legally notified boundaries of assembly constituencies, and maintain public confidence in the democratic process. He called for an impartial and time-bound investigation into what he claimed was a "deliberate attempt to manipulate electoral records." Along with the complaint, Sardesai enclosed the names of voters from the electoral roll of 29 Curtorim for 2012 and 2017, and of 30 Fatorda for 2021 and 2026.

The complaint further sought the immediate deletion of all voter entries allegedly shifted from Curtorim constituency to Fatorda constituency. "Initiate appropriate departmental disciplinary proceedings and criminal prosecutions against all individuals found responsible for negligence, misconduct, abuse of authority, or deliberate falsification of records. Conduct a state-wise audit to verify whether similar illegal shifting of constituency boundaries and voter migrations has been carried out in other constituencies," the complaint stated.

When contacted, Sanjay Goel, CEO, Goa, said, "We will check the complaint and get an inquiry conducted through the DEO (district election officer). If a complaint has come... from any channel... an inquiry has to be done."

SC to hear plea alleging Rahul pushed pregnant journalist

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 16

THE SUPREME Court said on Friday that it will list for hearing a plea which alleged that Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi pushed a pregnant journalist in the melee outside the registry while filing a petition.

A bench of Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi told senior advocate Gaurav Bhatia, who mentioned the matter, that it would be listed once the court reopens after Dussehra holidays.

The SC is on Dussehra recess for a week and will reopen on October 26.

Bhatia told the bench that he had mentioned the matter on Thursday when the bench took up petitions filed by Gandhi and others challenging the SIR of electoral rolls and the functioning of CEC Gyanesh Kumar.

The bench had also issued notice on pleas alleging harassment of women journalists by police during the Cockroach Janta Party protests in Delhi. Bhatia then urged the court to also take cognisance of the news that Gandhi allegedly pushed a pregnant journalist.

The bench, however, said it cannot take cognisance of oral submissions and would examine the issue if a petition is filed.

Earlier, Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge, wrote to the CJI seeking an audience to raise issues regarding Kumar, the ECI, the "arbitrary arrest" of students, the closure of Delhi Metro etc. The CJI, however, declined to meet them, saying that the issues "are already sub judice before the Supreme Court of India".

EC to hear rival factions of TMC on Oct 30 over party symbol & name

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, October 16

THE ELECTION Commission (EC) has called rival factions of the All India Trinamool Congress (AITC) for a hearing on October 30, the first hearing after they were barred from using the party symbol for West Bengal bypolls, officials said on Friday.

The hearing comes over a month after the EC issued an interim order on September 17 having heard leaders of the two factions led by Mamata Banerjee and Arup Roy, and directed that the matter required substantive determination by the poll body under provisions of the Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order 1968.

The EC had then ordered them not to use the party name and "Flowers and Grass symbol" during the West Bengal bypolls. Later, it had allocated them fresh symbols and names to contest the bypolls.

Reacting to the development, TMC joint secretary Derek O'Brien said they would appear for the hearing, and accused the rival faction of seeking multiple extensions. Leader of Opposition (LoP) in West Bengal Assembly Ritabrata Banerjee said they would appear for the hearing, and expressed confidence in their claim.

Asked about the hearing, O'Brien pointed out that the process started in July, and questioned why the poll panel delayed the matter.

"The traitors first wrote to the Election Commission on June 22. The EC asked us and them to reply by July 6. We promptly did. They did not," O'Brien told PTI.

"After this, all that the traitors did was to keep seeking extensions of time. That was their only communication to the EC — requests for more time," he said. The Rajya Sabha MP said the EC, in their generosity, gave the traitors 70 extra days.

"We have maintained all deadlines. The chronology of 14 dates exposes the hollow claims of the traitor group," he said.

Amid ongoing protests against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar over alleged irregularities in the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise, O'Brien said, "Much can happen between now and then." "We are still two weeks away from that meeting. The nation is enraged. Young and old are on the streets, protesting," he said.

Ritabrata Banerjee told PTI that they would appear before the poll panel, and expressed confidence in their claim. "This is the routine procedure; we will go for the hearing. We are very confident," he said.

The EC is hearing rival claims over control of the AITC, including the validity of its existing organisational structure and authorised signatories.

OVER THE PAST THREE DECADES, JANTAR MANTAR ALLOWED THOSE IN POWER TO BE CONSTANTLY REMINDED OF THE PROMISES MADE TO PEOPLE. NOW, PROTESTERS MAY BE AT RISK OF BECOMING INVISIBLE AND INAUDIBLE.

Jantar Mantar to the periphery: Will there be a cost for pushing protests out?



THE NEERJA CHOWDHURY COLUMN

WEEKLY INSIGHT INTO WHAT'S CHANGING IN NATIONAL POLITICS – AND WHY

FOR 33 years, Jantar Mantar was not just a designated protest site in the heart of Delhi, but one of those soft symbols of democracy almost as important as Constitutional guarantees.

Be it the 18th-century astronomical observatory whose status as a protest site now stands cancelled, or the Central Hall of the old Parliament, which was also done away with in the new building, these were spaces where people across the political divide freely exchanged views. Even the Holi Milans and Iftar parties that leaders across the political spectrum once hosted helped make hard political discord a shade softer.

However, these are now almost relics of the past and the de-notification of Jantar Mantar as a protest site pushes citizens further out to the peripheries, making it more difficult for their voices to be heard by those in power. The nature of power being what it is, those who get to the top have to be constantly reminded of the promises they made to those who put them there.

On Friday, the police imposed restrictions to stop the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) Tricolour march at Connaught Place, not far from Jantar Mantar. They detained its founder Abhijeet Dipke as well as Left student leader Neha Bora, the faces of the next generation of protesters.

Over the last three decades, Jantar Mantar enabled people to try and hold people in power accountable.

Protests in the past

Jantar Mantar, and before it the Boat Club, also not far from Parliament, represented a safety valve by which the citizens let off steam and did so peacefully. The idea was to ensure that differences in a democracy did not come to a head or explode. The wise amongst the rulers managed to defuse the situation before the pressure started to build.

It is not surprising that most democratic countries have their designated protest sites — there is the Hyde Park Corner and Parliament Square near Whitehall in London and Lafayette Square opposite the White House in Washington, DC.

Protest sites have shaped politics and that is how it should be in any vibrant democracy, provided it is done peacefully. When the Anna Hazare movement for public accountability was at its peak in 2011, senior BJP leaders quietly visited Jantar Mantar — the protest later moved to Ramlila Maidan — and returned convinced that the moment "to strike" had arrived. In 2014, Narendra Modi went on to dislodge the Congress-led United Progressive Alliance (UPA) from power.

Decades ago, Charan Singh held a mammoth meeting at Boat Club in December 1978. It was a show of strength by the Jat leader who had been thrown out of the Janata government and it compelled the then PM, Morarji Desai, to take him back and make him Deputy PM.



Jantar Mantar represented a safety valve by which the citizens let off steam and did so peacefully. EXPRESS FILE

In 1988, kisan leader Mahendra Singh Tikait organised a huge rally of 5 lakh farmers at the Boat Club. They came with their tractors and even charpoys to camp in Delhi. The meeting reinforced the pressure on the then PM, Rajiv Gandhi, whose own Finance Minister, V P Singh, had challenged him with allegations of corruption in defence deals. V P Singh went on to replace Rajiv as PM in 1989.

A rally at the Boat Club also influenced VP's decision to go in for the far-reaching decision to implement the Mandal Commission's report to give reservation to Other Backward Classes (OBCs) in government jobs. VP expected his estranged Deputy PM Devi Lal to demand the implementation of "Mandal", lure away the OBC MPs, and bring down the government. He announced the decision two days before a rally Lal had called, irreversibly changing politics.

How Jantar Mantar was designated

Similar apprehensions of a threat to his government led P V Narasimha Rao to ban the BJP's Boat Club rally on February 25, 1993. The party had planned to call for the PM's resignation, demand a mid-term poll, and push for the construction of a Ram temple at the site where the Babri Masjid had been demolished only weeks earlier in December 1992. Rao had an estimated 1 lakh security personnel out to prevent the protesters from entering Delhi.

It was then that Rao decided to designate the much smaller Jantar Mantar as the new protest site, thinking that the confined space with limited exit and entry points would be easier to manage.

But even in 1993, the government did not think of pushing the dissent venue to the city's outskirts. Governments over the decades accepted the premise that no matter how inconvenient, protesters should neither be invisible nor (politically) inaudible.

Given this history, Burari and the CBD Ground in East Delhi are really non-starters, being so far from central Delhi. Ramlila Maidan, the third designated protest site, could work, but it is so heavily booked that it may take months to get access to it.

The need to maintain public order versus the citizens' right to protest is the quintessential dilemma faced by successive governments. Ultimately, the answer, as suggested by many, may lie in walking the middle path. That is only possible when dialogue takes place between the executive and the aggrieved and when the search is for a political, and not a law-and-order, solution.

At present, as protests against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar continue, could the entire country become a Jantar Mantar, as Abijeet Dipke has declared? Or can the government find another way out that addresses the basic question of the protestors: how to restore the sanctity of the electoral rolls and the credibility of the electoral process? And to do it before the state elections next year.

All eyes are now on the Supreme Court, whose institutional response will be closely watched. But, clearly, something has to give way somewhere.

Neerja Chowdhury, Contributing Editor, The Indian Express, has covered the last 11 Lok Sabha elections. She is the author of 'How Prime Ministers Decide'

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Shah: Centre will seek report from Punjab on Jhota murder; Mann, Kejriwal hit back

Kanchan Vasdev
Chandigarh, October 16

UNION HOME Minister Amit Shah Friday said the Centre would seek a report from the Punjab government on murder of anti-drug activist Parvinder Singh Jhota in Mansa and a suicide case in Dirba, with Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann and AAP national convenor Arvind Kejriwal hitting back over border security.

On the same day, the Union Ministry of Home Affairs issued two separate communications to the state seeking detailed reports on both incidents.

Shah's remarks came ahead of a meeting Mann was scheduled to chair with senior Punjab police officers on Friday. The meeting came amid questions over drug menace, gangsterism and organised crime in the state.

Jhota, who had raised his voice against drugs, was shot dead in Mansa on Tuesday. In separate Dirba incident, a father consumed poison after succumbing to political pressure.

Shah said the Centre would seek responses from the Punjab government on both incidents.

In a post on X, he accused the Mann government of failing to ensure safety of Punjab's people and said the state was witnessing a growing threat from drugs and organised crime. "Bhagwant Mann ji, the people of Punjab do not want promises-they want answers..." Shah wrote.

Mann hit back with a post on X, questioning the Centre's responsibility in tackling drug trafficking and security threats. "Amit Shah ji, you should have consulted your advisers before speaking about me. The BSF has jurisdiction over the 50-km border belt. Around 3,000 kg of heroin is being seized at Gujarat's Kandla port..."

Kejriwal said,"You people are spreading drugs through Adani Port in Punjab! You people who provided protection in Sabarmati Jail to those spreading gangsters in Punjab. You people who, from 2007-2017, colluded with the Chitta Party to spread drugs in Punjab. And now, joining hands with that same party again, dreaming of earning billions of rupees by selling drugs in Punjab? Today, the highest drug menace is in those states where your governments have been in power for years.,"

Blocked by Centre, cleared by HC: Mann set for France trip

Kanchan Vasdev
Chandigarh, October 16

THE PUNJAB and Haryana High Court Friday allowed Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann to travel to France, granting relief to the Punjab government in its legal battle with the Centre over the denial of political clearance for his visit.

The Centre opposed the proposed visit, citing security concerns, including a potential threat from Khalistani elements. It also argued that Mann had not received a formal invitation from the French government.

The state government, however, accused the Centre of adopting a discriminatory approach towards the chief minister's foreign visits.

The bench of Justice Tribhuvan Dahiya heard arguments from both sides before allowing Mann to travel. A detailed order is awaited.

During the hearing, the counsel for the Centre, Satya Pal Jain, filed an affidavit and submitted that it would be difficult to put foolproof security arrangements in place at such short notice. He also questioned how the Indian embassy could facilitate the visit in the absence of a formal invitation from the French government.



Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann

The Centre also told the court that it had received a letter from the Punjab government flagging a threat to Mann from Khalistani elements in India and abroad. The letter, the Centre said, mentioned Sikhs for Justice chief Gurpatwant Singh Pannun.

The Centre argued that the "denial of political clearance was guided by concerns for Mann's safety and that no risk could be taken given the potential threat to his life". It also pointed to the absence of a formal invitation, questioning how the host country would extend the necessary protocol and courtesies to the chief minister. Citing large gathering expected at the food trade fair in France, the Centre raised further concerns over security arrangements required for the visit.

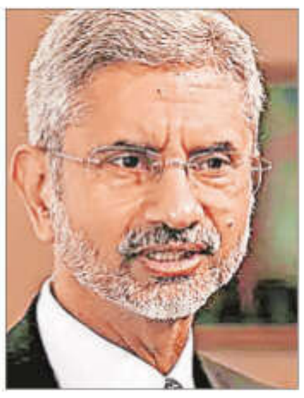
The Punjab government countered that the Centre could coordinate with French authorities to ensure adequate security, just as it facilitates security arrangements when foreign dignitaries visit India.

The state also pointed out that Mann had travelled to countries including Japan, South Korea and Australia in the past with the Centre's clearance. It questioned why his proposed visit to France was being treated differently and alleged that the Centre was applying its clearance policy selectively.

After the high court relief, Mann would take a midnight flight to participate in SIAL Paris 2026, an international food festival, from October 17 to 21.

Jaishankar will host UAE's Dy PM, Rubio in Mumbai next week: MEA

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, October 16



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar

HOURS AFTER Congress leader Rahul Gandhi questioned the government over US Secretary of State Marco Rubio's proposed meeting with Indian officials in Mumbai next week, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Friday that External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar will be travelling to Mumbai where he will host UAE's Deputy PM and Foreign Minister Sheikh Abdullah bin Zayed Al Nahyan on October 19-20 and Rubio on October 20.

The discussions with Rubio are expected to cover key areas of bilateral cooperation, including "energy, trade and investment, defence, critical and emerging technologies", said MEA's official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal.

Responding to questions at the weekly briefing, he said, "On 19-20 October, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar will host in Mumbai the Deputy PM and FM of UAE Sheikh Abdullah bin Zayed Al Nahyan for an official visit. On 20 October, the External Affairs Minister will hold talks with the US Secretary of State Marco Rubio and attend the celebration of the 250th Anniversary of the Independence of the USA as the guest of honour."

Defending the decision to host the US Secretary of State in Mumbai, he said, "It is the practice over the last decade to host foreign dignitaries from time to time in various cities of India."

He gave examples of PM Narendra Modi and Jaishankar hosting foreign leaders in different cities. "The PM hosted PM of Spain in Baroda; Chancellor Merz in Ahmedabad; PM of Mauritius in Varanasi", he said, adding that Jaishankar hosted SCO FMs meeting in Goa; Foreign Minister of Botswana in Kevadia; Heart of Asia conference in Amritsar.

Talking about the UAE Foreign Minister's visit, the MEA spokesperson said that it "will be an opportunity to review all facets of bilateral cooperation under the India-UAE Comprehensive Strategic Partnership".

"The two delegations will assess and take forward initiatives in the areas of energy, trade and investments, fintech, defence and connectivity. They will naturally be a detailed exchange of views on the situation in West Asia as also on global and multilateral issues," he said.

About Rubio's visit, Jaiswal said, "US Secretary of State's forthcoming visit will provide an opportunity for both sides to review India-US relations and discuss ways to further strengthen our Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership. Discussions are expected to cover key areas of bilateral cooperation, including energy, trade and investment, defence, critical and emerging technologies, and other areas of mutual interest. The two sides will also exchange views on regional and global developments."

"The visit will provide an opportunity to sustain the high-level engagement between the two countries and advance our shared priorities," he said.

Earlier in the day, Rahul Gandhi had claimed officials of the MEA were "confused" over it. He had said Prime Minister Narendra Modi may want to explain the matter. The Congress leader's remarks came a day after US envoy Sergio Gor said Rubio will meet Indian government officials in Mumbai and "we expect that minister Dr S Jaishankar will be there".

In a post on X, Gandhi said, "Mr Rubio has summoned his employee to Mumbai. Modi ji, your officials in the External Affairs Ministry are confused about what's going on. You might want to explain. Unless, of course, you want me to."

EXPRESS special

Nilekani-led panel considers question vault to prevent exam paper leaks

Task force also discussing creating a pool of questions and digital delivery of question paper minutes before test

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, October 16



Nandan Nilekani, the head of the six-member HPTF constituted after the NEET-UG paper leak, at an event in Mumbai on Thursday. PTI

A QUESTION vault mechanism backed by highly secure software, a pool of over one lakh questions prepared and vetted throughout the year and digital delivery of question papers minutes before an examination are among the key proposals being considered by the Nandan Nilekani-led High Powered Task Force (HPTF) on examination reforms to prevent paper leaks, sources said.

The task force is also discussing "debundling" examination-related responsibilities so that a single service provider is not entrusted with conducting exams, managing centres and preparing question papers.

Nilekani, the head of the six-member HPTF constituted after the NEET-UG paper leak, recently said one way to prevent leaks was to create a question bank and generate the paper at the last minute. "Why do we need to have something called 'A' question paper? Because the moment you have 'A' question paper, that creates an economic incentive for that to be sold or whatever. So the way to do that is to have a massive bank of question papers and only at the last minute generate the question paper for that day. Then the question paper does not go away and there is no economic incentive for that," he said at the Bloomberg New Economy Forum 2026 on Tuesday.

This mechanism is already being used by the Staff Selection Commission (SSC).

A government official described a question vault supported by advanced artificial intelligence (AI) technology as the future. "Let us say you have 1,000 experts for setting question papers, vetting and verifying them. Instead of informing them that they are preparing questions for a particular examination, you just ask them to keep preparing questions throughout the year," the official said. The questions would be vetted, verified, translated into the required languages and stored securely.

"If you create a pool of one lakh questions for the SSC examination and need a paper of 20–30 questions, you randomly select them from that pool and draw up the paper. This way, even the person setting the question paper would not know which questions are going to be asked. This is called a question vault," the official said.

Officials said translation had been identified as a "key vulnerability". "It happened in the recent NEET-UG leak. Marathi translator came to Delhi, translated, mugged up questions and reproduced them to earn money," the official said. "A secure, tech-backed vault could help address this vulnerability."

SSC Chairman S Gopalakrishnan said the Commission conducts computer-based tests for about a dozen recruitment exams a year, held at over 200 centres in about 140 cities spread across the country. "There has not been a single instance of paper leak in the last five years. But the more significant aspect is that a leak is impossible because we do not print our question papers. There will never be a leak of an SSC question paper, because of the encryption technologies and the processes followed in vetting, translating and delivering questions for any test through an internal digital vault," he said.

Regarding delivery, Gopalakrishnan said, "For instance, if an exam is scheduled at 5 pm, questions are randomly selected according to a predetermined design and blueprint specifying the difficulty level and question types. The question paper is assembled from the vault, compiled and encrypted at 4.45 pm and just before 5 pm, the encrypted question paper is sent to around 200 examination centres across the country. At 5 pm, when candidates log in and enter their passwords, they can see the question paper."

US arrests Ahmedabad man over 2024 vote claim

Aditi Raja
Vadodara, October 16

AN AHMEDABAD man has been arrested in the United States for allegedly posing as an American citizen to vote in the 2024 presidential election. He could be sentenced to a decade in prison if convicted.

Mukeshkumar Somabhai Chaudhari, an Indian national, is accused of falsely affirming his US citizenship on a voter certificate in Minnesota on November 5, 2024, when the country elected Donald Trump its president.

In a release on Friday, the US Department of Homeland Security (DHS) said Immigration and Customs Enforcement's Homeland Security Investigations (HSI) arrested Chaudhari in connection with the case. A federal grand jury in the District of Minnesota returned a two-count indictment against him on September 10, accusing him of knowingly making a false claim of US citizenship to vote.

According to the indictment, Chaudhari signed a voter signature certificate required under the Minnesota law on election day. The document required voters to swear or affirm that they were US citizens. Prosecutors allege that Chaudhari was not a US citizen but knowingly made the declaration to cast his ballot.

Meerut 'snakebite' murder case: Woman, her friend get death sentence

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, October 16



Ravita and Amardeep were arrested last year

A MEERUT court on Friday sentenced a woman and her friend, with whom she was in a relationship, to death for killing her husband last year and leaving a live snake beside his body to make it appear like a case of snakebite.

Additional District and Sessions Judge Jaiveer Singh Nagar awarded death penalty to Ravita Kashyap, 30, and Amardeep, 23, for the murder of Amit Kashyap, 32, court officials said.

The sentencing comes two days after Muskan Rastogi and Sahil Shukla were sentenced to death in the Meerut 'blue drum' murder case. The two murdered Muskan's husband, Saurabh Rajput. His dismembered body was found in a blue drum filled with liquid cement at their home last year. Ravita and Muskan share the same barrack — Barrack 2B — in the Chaudhary Charan Singh District Jail.

Amit, 32, earned his living laying tiles and stone in Meerut's Akbarpur Sadat village. Amardeep worked with him and regularly visited his home, where he allegedly grew close to Ravita. When Amit reportedly learnt about their relationship, the two allegedly conspired to kill him.

According to the prosecution, Amit was found dead on his bed on April 13, 2025, with a live horse-whip snake near his body and marks on his skin. Ravita told the family he had died of a snakebite, and they initially believed her. However, marks on Amit's neck raised suspicions among his relatives, who insisted that his body be taken to a hospital for a post-mortem examination. The report revealed that he had been strangled. It also emerged that the snake was non-venomous.

Police registered a case and questioned Ravita, who allegedly admitted to the crime and spoke of her relationship with Amardeep. The two were arrested and sent to jail.

During questioning, it emerged that the accused had bought a snake from a snake charmer for Rs 1,000, saying they needed it for worship at a devotional gathering.

On the night of April 12, after Amit had gone to sleep, Ravita allegedly called Amardeep to the house. The two allegedly killed Amit and released the snake on his bed. Amardeep then left, while Ravita went to sleep in another room.

The court had held Ravita and Amardeep guilty of murder and conspiracy on October 7. Amardeep, who had been out on bail, was taken into custody, while Ravita was already in judicial custody.

Inquiry ordered against IAS officer who 'misbehaved with' woman JKAS officer

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, October 16



A videograb of senior IAS officer Kumar Rajeev Ranjan abusing a woman officer during a review meeting.

A DAY after a video purportedly showing senior IAS officer Kumar Rajeev Ranjan abusing a woman officer during a review meeting went viral, the Jammu and Kashmir government has ordered an inquiry against him, while the National Commission for Women (NCW) has taken suo motu cognisance.

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah said he has taken up the issue "in the strongest possible terms" with the Chief Secretary, even as political leaders called for action against the senior officer. The Jammu and Kashmir Administrative Service (JKAS) officers, meanwhile, observed a pen-down strike.

The video came to light on Thursday. While reviewing a meeting of officers for Mission YUVA, Ranjan allegedly called the woman officer, Beenish Wani, "bl**dy sh*t", saying he can always talk to her like this. As the woman officer strongly objected to his language, he allegedly directed his subordinate to prepare her suspension order.

An inquiry order issued by the government on Friday reads, "Sanction is hereby accorded to the appointment of Ms. Mandeep Kaur, IAS, Commissioner/Secretary to the Government, Housing and Urban Development Department, as Inquiry Officer to conduct an in-depth inquiry into the matter of alleged misconduct by Mr Kumar Rajeev Ranjan, IAS, Administrative Secretary, Labour & Employment Department, with Ms Beenish Wani, JKAS, Assistant Director, Employment, Ganderbal, being reported in the print/electronic media. The Inquiry Officer shall submit her report within a period of 15 days from the date of issuance of this order."

The National Commission for Women asked Chief Secretary Atul Dulloo to submit an Action Taken Report in seven days, saying it had taken note of the viral video that allegedly showed Ranjan "verbally abusing, humiliating and threatening [a] junior woman officer".

"The Commission also called for safeguards against workplace harassment, victimisation and professional retaliation, along with protection and support for the woman officer... Every woman officer is entitled to a safe, respectful and dignified workplace. Abuse of authority and workplace humiliation must be addressed with utmost seriousness," it said.

Chief Minister Abdullah said, "I've seen the video of the online government meeting that is circulating on social media. Prima facie, the conduct of the senior officer was not in keeping with the standards expected of a senior IAS officer, and the subsequent threats issued to a junior JKAS officer only make matters worse. I've taken this up in the strongest possible terms with the Chief Secretary. Unfortunately, as a Union Territory, control over IAS officers rests with Lok Bhavan, but as CM, I've instructed the CS to ensure the JKAS officer faces no retributive action."

"Had J&K been a state, the IAS officer seen abusing a young JKAS officer would have been attached to the General Administration Department pending an inquiry into his conduct. As a UT, we expect the authorities with control over the IAS officers to set the right example and ensure abusive, threatening behaviour is not brushed under the carpet," he said.

J-K Congress president Tariq Hameed Karra wrote to Lt Governor Manoj Sinha, calling for his intervention. "If the allegations are substantiated, appropriate action should follow, irrespective of the position held by the officer concerned," Karra wrote.

Peoples Conference leader Sajad Lone called the incident "scary" while praising the woman officer for standing her ground. "We may pretend to be surprised, but reality as it exists is that it is normal for such behaviour to be exhibited. Workplace bullying by officers exists. This is a vicious circle. IAS officers bully their junior officers; their junior officers bully their junior officers; and the viciousness carries on in its most lethal form on to the common masses," he said.

In Jammu, members of the All India Confederation of SC, ST, OBC, Minority and Adivasi Organisations held a protest demanding Ranjan's termination from service.

रजिस्ट्री सं. डी.एल.- 33004/99 REGD. No. D. L.-33004/99

भारत का राजपत्र
The Gazette of India

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MINISTRY OF RAILWAYS
CENTRAL RAILWAY
NOTIFICATION
Mumbai, the 24th September, 2026
Notification under Section 20A of the Railway (Amendment) Act, 2008.

S.O.5350(E) In exercise of the powers conferred by sub-section (1) of section 20A of the Railway (Amendment) Act, 1989 (11 of 2008) and the Railways Act 1989 (24 of 1989) (hereinafter referred to as the said Act). The Central Government after being satisfied that for public purposes, the land, the brief description of which has been given in the schedule annexed hereto is required for execution of Special Railway Projects, namely, for **Panvel - Karjat Suburban Railway** project in District Raigad in the state of Maharashtra, hereby declares its intention to acquire such land.

Any person interested in the said land may, within a period of thirty (30) days from the date of publication of the notification in the official Gazette, raise objection to the acquisition and use of such land for the aforesaid purpose under sub-section (1) of section 20D of the said Act.

Every such objection shall be made to the Competent Authority, namely Dy. Collector (Land Acquisition) Raigad (O) Alibaug, District Raigad, Maharashtra, in writing and shall set out the grounds thereof and the Competent Authority shall give the objector an opportunity of being heard, either in person or by legal practitioner and may after hearing all such objections and after making such further enquiry, if any, as the Competent Authority thinks necessary, by order, either allow or disallow the objections:

Any order made by the Competent Authority under sub-section(2) of section 20D of the said Act shall be final.

The land plans and other details of the land covered under this notification are available and can be inspected by the interested person at the aforesaid office of the Competent Authority.

SCHEDULE

Brief description of the land to be acquired, with or without structure, for the Special Railway Project, namely, For Panvel-Karjat Suburban Railway Corridor project in Panvel taluka District Raigad in the State of Maharashtra.

Sr. No.	Village Name	Land Owners Name as per 7/12	Survey No.	Total Area as per 7/12 (ha)	Area of Land to be Acquired (ha)
1	Barwai	Shailaja Anil Naphade	63/1/A/1	25.39.00	0.07.04
		Pushpashil Anand Ozhe			
		Smita Arvind Karambelkar			
		Anjali Ramesh Gondhalekar			
		Sunita Kashinath Ozhe			
		Shubhada Rajendra Jathar			
		Sandhya Dilip Ozhe			
		Priya Yogesh Roy			
		Prachi Mandar Deoghar			
		M/s. Placid Farms Pvt. Ltd, represented by Director Zakarsis Kersi Vandrewala			
		M/s. Spartex Logistic Solutions Pvt. Ltd			
		Ravindra Bhaskar Deshmukh			
		Makarand Bhimrao Patil	63/13/1/A	0.60.78	0.01.81
		Ganata Yadi Reddy	63/13/1/B	0.30.00	
		Government of India Central Railway	63/13/2	0.28.30	
			Total Area	26.58.08 Ha	0.08.85 Ha

(F. No. G197/Panvel-Karjat/Barwai/MRVC/20A)

BHUVNESH KUMAR GUPTA,
CHIEF ADMINISTRATIVE OFFICER (CONSTRUCTION)

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WEB EXCLUSIVE
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Government of the people, by the people, for the people, shall not perish from the earth.
— *Abraham Lincoln*

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Export surge paves way for reform push

INDIA'S GOODS exports continue to record robust growth. In September, merchandise exports rose to $44.4 billion, up by a staggering 23 per cent. Strong growth over the past few months has pushed up exports in the first half of the year to $259 billion. Considering that growth has been sluggish for several years after the bump during the Covid period — in 2025-26, exports stood at $441 billion, up less than 5 per cent from $422 billion in 2021-22 — this uptick is welcome.

The disaggregated data shows that engineering and electronic goods are among the drivers of this growth. Exports of these segments have together crossed $100 billion in the financial year so far, up 26 per cent over the same period last year. This is a stunning performance. The two sectors now account for almost half of all non-oil exports in the year so far. Data also shows that the US remains the largest market for Indian exports. Despite the persisting ambiguity over tariffs, exports to America rose 48 per cent in September. Exports to China also grew at a robust pace and are up 36 per cent in the year so far. However, shipments to the Middle East — countries like the UAE and Saudi Arabia — remain depressed. On the other hand, China accounted for the largest share in the country's import basket. India's trade deficit with that country widened to $68.9 billion during April-September this year, up from $54.4 billion over the same period last year. Ratings agency ICRA expects the current account deficit to increase to $13-15 billion during the second quarter "amid a modest expansion in the merchandise trade deficit and an expected easing in invisible earnings".

The currency's decline is likely to have played a role in increasing export competitiveness. However, the fall has also prompted the RBI to announce several measures and intervene in the forex markets to stem the slide. While the RBI has repeatedly said that it intervenes only to contain excess volatility, it should resist targeting any rupee/dollar level. Alongside, the government must continue to push ahead with its reform agenda. In recent years, it has entered into several FTAs, but it must move forward on the more contentious ones as well. It should take steps to boost manufacturing activity and attract more foreign investments.

The siege within Khyber Pakhtunkhwa

PAKISTAN IS no stranger to political crises, but the suspension of the elected government in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KP) assumes particular significance because it effectively strips the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) of its last remaining provincial stronghold. The declaration of a state of emergency, ostensibly prompted by a surge in terror attacks across KP, came as the PTI was preparing for a long march to Islamabad to demand the release of its incarcerated leader, Imran Khan. The former prime minister and 1992 Cricket World Cup-winning captain has been in jail for over three years, facing more than 100 legal cases and multiple convictions in what his supporters and even some critics have described as a politically motivated witch-hunt. Governor's Rule marks a further escalation in the long-running confrontation between the military-backed federal coalition, led by Shehbaz Sharif's Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N) and Bilawal Bhutto Zardari's Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP), and Imran Khan's PTI, which won the most seats in the last general election through candidates running as independents. But the move could backfire and deepen political instability, as it did in Balochistan in 1973, when Zulfikar Ali Bhutto's dismissal of the provincial government triggered a four-year insurgency.

Terror attacks in KP have indeed been rising. But the timing of Governor's Rule invites questions about political motives. By suspending an elected government and removing what it claimed was a principal obstacle to counterterrorism — a federal minister has even alleged a "nexus" between the PTI and terrorists — the federal government has raised the stakes for its own security policy. If terror attacks continue despite the change in administration, the government will find it harder to justify imposing Governor's Rule. It will also reinforce the perception that the move was driven by political expediency, not security considerations.

The PTI will be tested on whether it can mobilise people without the administrative machinery of the now-suspended provincial government. The political clash will reveal whether, and to what extent, Imran Khan retains influence in terms of mounting a challenge to the federal government from behind bars. Finally, as Pakistan seeks to reintegrate itself into the international system by playing peacemaker in West Asia, the ease with which it has dismissed an elected government lays bare the fragility that continues to lie within.

On the trail of the cockroach

THE DUNG beetle adorned the sarcophagi of pharaohs and gods. Long before it became a trinket sold to tourists, the scarab was a symbol of power and prosperity in ancient Egypt. Butterflies, ants, termites, and spiders hold a place among the sacred, from the Americas to Africa and Asia. Not so the cockroach. That doesn't mean the formidable insect doesn't have a place in metaphor and imagination, as an object of fear, derision and, most recently in India, politics. The arthropod can be stomped on; its life ends by the much larger *Homo sapiens* with a macabre crunch. But it is equally a symbol of endurance, of the creature that will outlast most others in a nuclear apocalypse. And, much to the horror of the katsaridaphobic, it can — relatively rarely, but with surprising speed — take flight.

The diminutive insect entered India's political lexicon after a seemingly stray remark by the Chief Justice of India about the young and restless. From there, a viral social media phenomenon turned into a protest movement. Now, a symbol for the forgotten and stepped on is set to become larger than life: The Shree Keshav Ram Leela Committee, organisers of the annual Ramlila in Pitampura, has decided to burn a 30-foot effigy of a cockroach on Dussehra. The effigy-burning, it is also being said, is part of the Swachh Bharat campaign, and cockroaches will feature in the *asura* army.

The insect, feared and derided, and for long an object of disgust, is clearly having its moment in the sun. And, perhaps, its 15 minutes of fame. For those seeking to stamp out its current virality — digital and on the street — setting a 30-foot effigy on fire might help, or it might not. Because cockroaches and ideas can endure, and sometimes, suddenly take off.

NRI as the non-returning Indian: What gets lost in the US visa debate



SANJAYA BARU

UNITED STATES Vice President J D Vance and Union Minister of Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal were economical with the truth in their recent remarks on Indian H1-B visa holders in the United States. Vance is aware of the fact that US corporations, supporters of the Republican Party, have benefited from access to lower-cost Indian talent. Goyal knows well that governments in India, including his own, have long sought more US visas for people seeking access to American education and employment.

One must, however, appreciate the transparent honesty of Vance when he refers to H1-B visa-holding Indians as "foreign indentured servants". Despicable though that condescending view of professionals is, it sums up a view of the imperialist West with respect to Indian immigrants. Indentured is a word Vance would have picked up from his highly educated Indian-American wife, Usha Chilukuri. Servant is not a pejorative term but upper-class and upper-caste Indians view it as such. Serve other countries is what Indian emigrants do and H1-B holders are in the US on a contractual basis. Not surprisingly, Vance's put-down forced a government normally circumspect in dealing with the US to issue a rebuff.

India has been home to two centuries of organised labour export. British India shipped out hundreds of thousands of "indentured labour", as part of official government policy, to overseas territories where local labour was in short supply. The governments of free India have also encouraged the export of labour to countries where local labour is either in short supply or is simply unwilling to do the work that imported Indian labour is willing to, wanting to, waiting to. (With apologies to Bernard Shaw.)

Goyal, however, was being less than honest when he waxed eloquent on how any curtailment of H1-B visas would be welcomed by India since this would help retain talent at home. That is a welcome change in thinking and a departure from official policy that has consistently sought more opportunities for Indians to work overseas.

As I have recorded in my recent book, *Secession of the Successful: The Flight Out of New India* (Penguin Random House), there isn't much difference between British colonial policy on indentured labour and Indian government policy on low- and high-skilled labour emigration. In both cases, the government of the day provides legal cover for the export of labour. Rapacious businesspersons have, in both cases, short-changed desperate people seeking a better life.

Make no mistake. Nineteenth-century indentured labour were as desperate to get out of their homes in search of a better life as the 21st-century Indian middle classes have been. Governments of the day offered a legal framework for such business to go on. Of course, life on plantations was not comfortable. Nor was life in containers and concrete holes across most of the Arab world. Life in the West has been more comfortable and the earnings better but the bottom line is the same. Low-cost Indian employees may not think of themselves as "indentured servants", nor did the "*girmitiyas*", as the indentured labour on the Indian Ocean islands were referred to.

Not only have successive Indian governments sought more work visas from around the world, they have sought a multilateral framework for what the terminology of the World Trade Organisation refers to as "Mode 4" — the cross-border movement of labour for the purpose of overseas employment. Economists have justified this on two grounds, one theoretical and the other practical. In theory, they have sought a correspondence between free mobility of capital and labour. In practice, they have justified it on the grounds that the home country receives dollar remittances boosting foreign exchange reserves.

> The export of human capital is a necessity, not a virtue. It is useful to remember that even labour-importing economies often view the phenomenon as an avoidable necessity

More recently, the export of labour has been promoted through public-private partnerships seeking "global access to talented Indians". The Narendra Modi government has entered into memorandums of understanding with several countries ranging from Israel to Taiwan to export Indian labour. Unable to ensure employment at home and in the name of seeking foreign exchange, India has become an exporter of talent.

At a time when many, including government officials, economists and business lobbyists, mock the notion of "brain drain", even as their educated offspring depart for distant lands, Goyal used that unfashionable term to refer to the emigration of skilled professionals. "I wonder what would have happened if all of them had been doing their businesses, their research, in India?", he wondered. Indeed. a good question from a member of a government that has been busy celebrating the success of overseas Indians in distant lands.

In an era in which the developed and ageing economies are facing a demographic deficit, it is only natural that countries with a large, young and unemployed population would seek overseas opportunities for their youth. The export of human capital is, then, a necessity, not a virtue. It is useful to remember that even labour-importing economies often view the phenomenon as an avoidable necessity. When the going is good, immigrant talent is celebrated. When immigrant labour becomes an electoral hot potato, you get the Vance kind of put-down.

Migration is a natural phenomenon, common to all living species. Yet, nation-states have imposed curbs on human migration. These curbs will only increase. A labour-surplus economy would understandably look for opportunities to export labour but it must also contend with rising anti-immigrant sentiment globally, and the need to retain talent and capital at home.

With non-resident Indians (NRIs) becoming "never-returning Indians", and the next generation of India's power elite emigrating in larger numbers, the government has to come forward with a plan to both retain and attract talent. This requires a fundamental change in the mindset of the regime in New Delhi and the ruling power elites across the country.

The authoritarian and majoritarian instincts of the Modi government, apart from the persistent bureaucratism across all walks of life, discourages overseas Indians from returning home. Global talent seeks both opportunity and freedom. The highly bureaucratised Indian educational and research system is not very welcoming of free-minded talent. PM Modi may often face an enthusiastic audience of overseas Indians but their nationalism ends with mouthing "Bharat Mata *ki jai*". Few in those gatherings are queueing up to return home.

The writer is chairman of the board of trustees, Forum for National Security Studies, and Centre for Aerospace & Strategic Studies

Balance foreign investment with tax sovereignty



SURANJALI TANDON

FOREIGN INVESTMENT inflows are a barometer to gauge economic success. Bilateral investment treaties (BITs) are among the many factors that lure investors to our shores. BITs assure a steady regulatory framework, allaying concerns of unforeseen costs to investors. However, those very assurances often turn into high standards of protection that investors resort to in order to curtail sovereign regulatory powers. The Cairn and Vodafone cases were examples of how transactional specificities allowed investor rights that are agnostic of the intent of investment.

Some argue that the point is about safety. But what happens when standards such as fair and equitable treatment apply asymmetrically, that is, when there is no reciprocal protection of the tax base?

Another article of relevance in these treaties relates to expropriation. Historical experiences — the nationalisation of the oil industry in Mexico in 1938, the expropriation of foreign owned assets by Cuba in 1959 and the post-World War II nationalisation of industries in Europe — make this relevant.

The fears are not unfounded but are these concerns relevant? Energy supply and extractive industry contribute to a third of investor-state disputes, and so the standards are valid. But how far should these standards of protection apply, especially since the remedy for change in ownership of assets is not interchangeable with policy sovereignty?

Ironically, the countries that enforce these standards are often not in conformity with the rule of law. The US accounts for 17.4 per cent of investor-state disputes settlements (ISDS). Nevertheless, developing countries have to extend bilateral investment treaty protection from policy measures like tax.

Not only do the treaties assign foreign investors rights, such as arbitration in tax matters, beyond those available to domestic investors, but these are incompatible with the position India has held at multiple fora that arbitration in tax matters is not permissible.

This exclusion of tax from investment treaties is not peculiar to India, as many countries grapple with forum shopping. In the last decade, 134 tax-related ISDS cases were admitted, and tax treaties were available for dispute resolution in 53 per cent of these. Yet the claimants, mostly from Western Europe and North America, chose to invoke BITs. The standard practice is evolving across the world as the UN model is being revised to exclude tax from disputes covered by processes stipulated by investment and trade agreements.

There are also different ways to frame the mechanisms of dispute resolution. For example, Brazil's cooperation and investment facilitation agreements exclude ISDS and rely on state-to-state dispute resolution combined with joint committees for implementation. The state-state dispute resolution pursued by India under the mutual agreement procedure (MAP) for tax could be further bolstered. Thus, the explicit exclusion of tax by India in BIT is not atypical.

The other issue that concerns investors is the exhaustion of domestic remedies prior to proceeding with arbitration. For tax matters, the MAP process would in fact be relatively less time-consuming than alternative judicial processes.

Moreover, for all other covered disputes in its treaty with the United Arab Emirates, India has stipulated a timeline of three years to exhaust local legal remedies, making it more efficient than the 2015 model that allows for five years. The number of years specified is viewed with cynicism. However, a further expedited timeline for foreign investors should not delay justice for domestic investors or set up a fast-track mechanism based on the nationality of investors.

As India moves to formalise its BITs, what can be afforded to foreign investors is the right to find justice without impinging on the rights of other taxpayers, particularly domestic institutional investors. Empirical evidence is not overwhelming to support that BITs can shift the mood of foreign investors substantially. But what it can do is to comfort the investor distracted by higher relative returns.

> A further expedited timeline for foreign investors should not delay justice for domestic investors or set up a fast-track mechanism based on the nationality of investors

The writer is associate professor, NIPFP

Showcased in Delhi: Misuse of state's strong arm



C UDAY BHASKAR

RESOLUTE CITIZEN protests against the SIR, and the Narendra Modi government's draconian police clampdown in response, defined the Capital in early October. Thousands were detained, journalists manhandled, Metro gates shuttered and internet suspended. The Supreme Court saw enough to issue contempt notices to the Union Home Secretary and the Delhi Police Commissioner over alleged violations of its October 9 directions. On October 15, Commissioner Anurag Kumar tendered an "unconditional and unqualified apology" but Solicitor General Tushar Mehta clarified that such language is a standard template in contempt responses and not an admission of disobedience. An apology accompanied by a denial of wrongdoing leaves the transgression untouched: The manner in which batons, boots, and detention powers were used against protesters and journalists.

While the Commissioner "apologised" for Metro and internet restrictions, two more serious failures of accountability remain unacknowledged. First, the police themselves recorded that three female journalists reported sexual harassment by officers during the October 3 protest. As of mid-October, no FIR had been registered against any officer on those allegations. Instead, an FIR under the SC/ST Act and related charges was filed against one of the journalists on the officer's complaint. This is Orwellian, and the legal requirement that a cognisable offence be registered when a woman reports sexual harassment has not been met. The Court has flagged the allegations as serious, but the pattern persists: Complaints stay complaints when they implicate police.

Second, and more corrosive, is the documented presence of right-wing groups acting as parallel law enforcers. Multiple videos show saffron-clad men shouting, "Delhi Police *tum lathi bajao, hum tumhare saath hain*," threatening journalists and protesters, and in some cases assaulting them, including manhandling women, while police stood nearby. Hindu Raksha Dal chief Pinky Chaudhary posted that the men were his workers. Police arrested four of them after public outcry. Predictably, they were released on bail (with police not opposing). The videos show detention law being strictly enforced against protesters while these vigilantes moved freely, boasting that they would not be detained. A modern state must retain the monopoly on legitimate violence. When vigilantes are allowed to assault protesters and threaten journalists in the presence of officers, and when those officers later clear the same actors, this constitutionally granted monopoly is selectively privatised. The internal security implications are grave.

The contempt notice concerned Metro gates and related curbs. The deeper contempt is of the principle that police must register crime as per the law rather than manage the narrative to suit political compulsions. If the Commissioner wishes the apology to carry weight, the starting points are: Register the sexual harassment complaints as FIRs, place the named officers under proper investigation, and ensure vigilantes are kept far from the business of policing protests. Anything less is puerile procedural platitude. The protests continue; the citizen reposes faith in the sagacity of the highest court and its fidelity to the Constitution.

> Register the sexual harassment complaints as FIRs, place the named officers under proper investigation, and ensure vigilante groups are kept far from the business of policing protests

The writer is director, Society for Policy Studies, New Delhi

40 YEARS AGO

October 17, 1986


SAREES
INDIAN EXPRESS
Thalappans Jewellers
Sethi suspended from Congress-I
Sequel to Weekly interview
Wole Soyinka first African Nobel laureate
A haven that may become hell

Haven that may become hell

THE FIRE at the Bharatpur bird sanctuary has added another dimension to the misery of the birds in the Keoladeo National Park in Bharatpur. According to the Deputy Chief Wildlife Warden Rajen Mathur, the fire covered an area of 108 hectares, the grassland portion of the sanctuary. Fortunately, there were very few trees around, which could have added to the fire's intensity.

Congress suspends MP ex-CM

THE FORMER Union minister and chief minister of Madhya Pradesh, Prakash Chandra Sethi, was suspended from the primary membership of the Congress-I party. The Congress-I Disciplinary Action Committee took this decision after considering the interview given by him to *The Illustrated Weekly* and his subsequent statements criticising the party leadership.

Soyinka gets Literature Nobel

WOLE SOYINKA of Nigeria, a forceful writer of novels and plays, became the first African winner of the Nobel Literature Prize. Soyinka was cited by the Swedish Academy of Letters as a writer "who, in a wide cultural perspective and with poetic overtones, fashions the drama of existence".

Economics prize to Buchanan

THE NOBEL Prize for Economics was awarded to American James McGill Buchanan for his "synthesis of the theories of political and economic decision making"; it was announced in Stockholm. Buchanan, 67, is a professor at George Mason University in Virginia. The Royal Swedish Academy of Sciences cited his contributions in a field called new political economy, or "public choice", an area on the boundary of economic and political science studies.

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WHAT THE OTHERS SAY

Trump's fuel announcement shows that Washington's Ukraine policy is now being dictated by Moscow.

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An entitled generation and an Opposition that protests too much



SURJIT S BHALLA



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

WHAT'S GOING on, Alfie? Oh sorry, wrong generation, but the entitled Gen Z, nourished on Instagram tidbits, should understand. For two weeks, the Capital has been treated to the spectacle of a democracy (apparently) under siege. On October 5, the Congress president listed three "non-negotiable" demands: The resignation of the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC), the cancellation of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls, and a return to paper ballots. On October 10, more than 2,000 people were detained in Delhi as the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) upped Congress's demands: That the CEC should resign within 48 hours, that the SIR be frozen, that the rolls be rolled back to January 2025, and, for good measure, that elections be suspended.

Many, including this writer, have criticised the process of the SIR. But the events of the last two weeks make me very pessimistic about the prospects for logic or reform within the political Opposition. I have studied and commented on politics and economics for over 30 years. I have disagreed when facts demanded; more than agreed when the logic was compelling. But never, ever, have I found the opposition voices so lacking in common sense in pursuit of their common minimum programme of regime change. The Opposition has no plot, except protest. Oh sorry, they do have a plot: Protest for the sake of protest. What shall we do today? Demand the resignation of a minister. Tomorrow? Remove the CEC. Day after, elect cockroaches to Parliament. Demands invisible on both logic and substance.

We are now supposed to listen to the most entitled generation in the world, one bereft of all ideas except a supreme arrogance. The CJP website wants the CEC arrested under the anti-terror law if a single legitimate vote is deleted; their case is that votes were "stolen", backed by not one number.

Too extreme a view, you say? As my readers know, my motto is simple: Give logical evidence, not demands or platitudes. The CJP is short even on platitudes, betraying the fact that the only support they have is the belief that the deep state is behind them, so why bother. So here is the evidence on the SIR.

Let's deal with the known unknowns. First, start with how many adults India has. Carry the last (2011) Census forward with official birth and death rates, correct for the method's known overshoot, allow for Covid deaths and emigration, and India had about 1,008 million adults in mid-2026. The UN, the SRS and the government's own Technical Group all land within 1.5 per cent of that number.

Second, remember even though "painful" to the cause, that not every adult registers to vote. In India, registration is voluntary; you fill in Form 6 if you want to vote. The ECI's own pre-SIR data showed that in the 2024 Lok Sabha election, one in four Indians aged 18 to 29, 73 million young people, were not registered. Add a small allowance for older adults who have never registered, or who dropped off after moving, and about 8.5 per cent of adults are legitimately not on the rolls. That is less than in Britain or the United States, where nobody calls it disenfranchisement. A clean Indian roll, therefore, should hold about 91.5 per cent of adults, about 922 million names, not 1,008 million.

Third, apply that test state by state where the SIR is final: Bihar and the eight large states of phase II. A clean roll for these states, built from each state's adults less each state's own non-registration, should hold about 535 million names; the final rolls hold 528 million. Allowing for the legitimate removal of non-citizens, the best estimate is that about 7 million eligible voters (range 1 to 13 million) have been excluded from the rolls without adequate explanation.

Seven million is not nothing to those 7 million. But put it in perspective. It is less than 1 per cent of India's adults. Of the 58 million names removed in these states, 51 million had to go: The dead, the duplicates, those who had moved away for good. Seven of every eight removals were justified. And rolls have never been accurate to within 1 or 2 per cent. In 2004, after the last nationwide intensive revision, the roll held 4.4 per cent more names than there were adults, 28 million phantom voters. It was 3.1 per cent too high in 2014. There was no march on Nirvachan Sadan, no talk of vote theft, and no allegation that the ECI had doctored the rolls. (Incidentally, Congress, then in opposition, won the 2004 election).

What of the Cockroach-Congress much-mentioned 13 crore? It is the draft-stage figure of 133.7 million, including the known dead. Treating it as a count of the disenfranchised is like treating every patient admitted to hospital as a death.

What of the two states at the centre of the noise? In Bihar, where the outcry began, the final roll still holds about 6 million more names than a clean roll would; and in West Bengal, 6 to 7 per cent of adults (about 5 million eligible citizens) appear to have been removed without adequate explanation; the citizenship-style adjudication fell disproportionately on Muslims in Murshidabad and Malda, and on Matua Hindus.

Could the SIR have been done much better? Obviously. As I pointed out in this newspaper, ('I have voted for three decades. Why is my SIR incomplete?', *IE*, September 24), the process was hasty, demanded paperwork the poor and the migrant do not keep, and added a new declaration to Form 6 without a change in the rules, a move whose legality the Supreme Court has yet to decide. Those criticisms stand. But criticising the administration of an exercise is very different from claiming that it disenfranchised a seventh of the electorate. The evidence says the ECI has been much more right than wrong.

A serious opposition would demand that the ECI publish removals by reason, state and booth; that the West Bengal appeals be decided quickly; and that phase III rolls be tested against a clean roll when they are final. Those are reforms worth marching for. Instead we have resignations on demand, paper ballots, and cockroaches. It is, to borrow from *Macbeth*, a tale full of sound and fury, signifying, if not nothing, far less than claimed.

Bhalla is chairperson of the Technical Expert Group for the first official Household Income Survey of India. Views are personal

> Seven million is not nothing to those 7 million. But put it in perspective. It is less than 1 per cent of India's adults. Of the 58 million names removed in these states, 51 million had to go

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Financial stability

THE PROPOSED stake sale could attract investment, improve efficiency and strengthen competition in banking ('IDBI stake sale: Welcome signal, build on it', *IE*, October 17). However, the process must remain transparent, with careful scrutiny of prospective investors and fair valuation of public assets. The government should ensure that the transaction serves long-term financial stability rather than merely raising revenue. Equally important are safeguards for employees, depositors and customers. .

Pon Arunkumar, Namakkal

AI bubble risks

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE offers enormous opportunities, but excessive investment driven by unrealistic expectations could create financial instability ('A reality check on AI boom: Eight risks to look out for', *IE*, October 17). Companies must demonstrate genuine productivity gains rather than rely on market excitement. Regulators should monitor excessive borrowing, opaque valuations and concentration of risk among major technology firms. At the same time, workers need opportunities to acquire new skills as automation expands. Innovation must be encouraged, but sound financial practices and accountability cannot be overlooked.

M Barathi, Bengaluru

Listen to students

STUDENT UNREST often reflects deeper anxieties about educational quality, employment prospects and social mobility ('In France, student protest is a symptom and warning', *IE*, October 17). Governments should treat peaceful protests as an opportunity to understand genuine grievances rather than merely a law-and-order problem. Better career guidance, affordable higher education, practical training and transparent recruitment can restore confidence among young people. At the same time, protest organisers must respect public safety and essential services. Constructive dialogue is the best way forward.

B A Avyaan, Perundurai



SNEHA BHAGAT AND RADHIKA GUPTA

Reset with Canada, pragmatism with US

BY CONCLUDING a rapid succession of free trade agreements across Europe, the Gulf, and the Indo-Pacific, India has signalled that its economic statecraft is being redesigned to secure the supply chains, capital, and frontier technologies required for Industry 4.0. Now, in the final months of 2026, this strategic restructuring has entered its decisive North American leg.

Currently, India is hosting Canada's largest trade delegation in over three decades, a nearly 300-member mission advancing negotiations for a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) aimed at concluding by year-end and more than doubling bilateral trade to C$70 billion (US$50 billion) by 2030. Simultaneously, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio arrives in India today. The twin diplomatic tracks offer New Delhi a chance to move from compartmentalised dealings with Ottawa and Washington towards a mutually reinforcing footprint across North America.

Moving beyond the traditional reliance on the trade of raw commodities, the India-Canada bilateral agenda is pivoting towards science, technology, and innovation. What was once a relationship dominated by one-way migration is being reimagined around talent mobility and joint research through the new Joint Talent and Innovation Strategy. Similarly, capital flows are evolving from passive, one-way portfolio allocations by Canadian pension funds into active co-investment platforms, industrial joint ventures in data centres and clean energy, and R&D partnerships like the India-Canada Pulse Protein Centre of Excellence. Anchor pillars in energy and food security, highlighted by the $2.6 billion Cameco civil nuclear uranium agreement, critical minerals value-chain integration, and advanced potash technologies, are providing a durable commercial foundation. This federal momentum has been insulated and accelerated by vibrant sub-national diplomacy, led by provincial missions from Saskatchewan, Ontario, and British Columbia.

This revamp with Ottawa has the potential to reinforce, and be reinforced by, the deep structural foundation of India-US relations. While Washington's weaponisation of tariffs and talent mobility reflects a structural shift towards an increasingly transactional America, two decades of deep institutionalisation in defence, intelligence, and frontier technologies ensure that the strategic logic of India-US alignment remains intact. Their alignment in the Indo-Pacific, anchored by the imperative to balance China and de-risk strategic supply chains, provides an enduring ballast.

As Ottawa and New Delhi look beyond CEPA towards defence, maritime domain awareness, and security cooperation, they do not have to build in a vacuum. They can leverage the existing Indo-Pacific and technology-sharing architecture already operating between India and the US, as well as the deeply integrated US-Canada continental defence and industrial ecosystem. Deeper engagement with Ottawa effectively plugs India into the wider North American economic and security matrix.

For Canada, which has been hit hardest by Washington's tariff regime and recently saw its own US trade negotiations stall at the eleventh hour, the Indian partnership offers vital strategic diversification. Both countries are reinforcing this resilience by bringing each other into key minilateral platforms, from the Global Biofuels Alliance and the International Solar Alliance to the G7 Critical Minerals Action Plan. Pragmatism dictates that even if Ottawa achieves its goal of doubling non-US trade over the next decade, the Canadian economy will remain overwhelmingly oriented towards the US. As and when Washington and Ottawa reach a new North American equilibrium, an India that is institutionally embedded with both partners will stand to accrue strategic and commercial dividends.

By locking in technology, talent, and resource corridors with Ottawa while bargaining pragmatically with Washington, India can turn North American turbulence into enduring geoeconomic advantage.

Bhagat is assistant professor and Gupta is a research scholar at Centre for the Study of the Americas, School of International Studies, JNU

> The twin diplomatic tracks offer New Delhi a chance to move from compartmentalised dealings towards a mutually reinforcing footprint across North America



SHAMBHAVI GUPTA

The day I mistook fear for obedience in the classroom

IN MY fourth year of teaching Sociology to high-school students, I tried to change my pedagogy, specifically how I related to them. I had to teach a large class, and instead of being happy at how popular the subject was becoming, I grew afraid of the challenges that confronted me. After having difficulties with disciplining a large class, and tired of running after students for submissions, I wanted ease. I turned to a senior colleague's advice — that at the outset, it is good to be stern in order to ensure that students respect you; that strictness ensured the class progressed in structured and predictable ways. Sensing my scepticism, she added that once the relationship was established, I could open up a little.

My approach was pretty much contrary to hers: Building a fun environment, putting the students at ease, hearing their expectations and concerns. But I thought I would give the advice a shot. In the first class with the new batch, I listed out my rules and expectations. Usually this was a more open conversation where I assured them that I'm always there to guide them according to their needs.

In retrospect, I wish I had thought more about it. Despite planning interesting activities which could have led to rich discussions, I was met with silence. I knew something was wrong. When I asked colleagues about their experience with the batch, they said the students were always eager to share their views. Confused, I decided to ask the class why they were so quiet. One student admitted they were scared of me. I realised that my sternness had evoked in them fear, not respect.

This is a common misconception among teachers — that if students do not talk back or ask questions, they are being respectful. I had fallen prey to it too. Students do not want to learn in a classroom where the teacher does not make space for them. I came face to face with what Jiddu Krishnamurti meant when he said education is "freedom from fear".

From starting my career at a Krishnamurti school to this, I wondered what had changed. Certainly the environment and educational philosophy, but more importantly, me. Institutional circumstances and structures are often set for the long term and therefore difficult to change. Sometimes they can align with a teacher's personal values, mostly they don't. It falls on the teacher to work against the grain and be more resilient. Teaching is constant work and requires the will and courage to be different, as bell hooks mentions in *Teaching to Transgress*. The moment I realised my mistake, I reverted to my original pedagogy. It took a while for the students to open up — understandably so, because the edifice of the relationship was unequal.

Pedagogy, the central part of teaching, becomes secondary when teachers are hemmed in by administrative duties and measurable outcomes. Krishna Kumar, in a recent public lecture as part of the Act of Doing conference in Delhi, said that this is the most unfortunate thing to have happened. The purpose of pedagogy is to be surprising and unpredictable. At a time when lesson plans are meant to predict measurable learning outcomes, we must embrace serendipity and uncertainty. It is difficult to persevere, and not seek the easy path, to reorient and see a fun free-flowing class positively rather than judge it by quantitative outcomes set by the administration. But I believe it can be cultivated by engaging with educationists who keep reimagining and questioning the purpose of education. This could help ground these transgressions in a discourse rather than treat teaching merely as a technique.

Gupta is a Delhi-based writer and researcher in the field of Education and Sociology

> This is a common misconception among teachers — that if students do not talk back or ask questions, they are being respectful. I had fallen prey to it too

Cautionary tales from Ukraine & Hungary, about two billionaires



RAM RAJYA

BY RAM MADHAV

BEFORE VENTURING into Ukraine in February 2022, the Russian army knocked out the Viasat satellite communications link to that country — a crucial lifeline for all communications, both military and civil — by deploying wiper malware in the ground control systems. Without the Viasat link, Ukrainian army commanders couldn't contact field units, share information and coordinate the counter-attack. When the Russians landed in dozens of helicopters in Kyiv in the very first week of the war, they anticipated a simple surrender by the Ukrainians.

At that critical juncture, the Ukrainian leadership didn't rush to the Americans or Europeans for help. Instead, Deputy Prime Minister Mykhailo Fedorov turned to his X account to send an SOS to Elon Musk. Musk's company SpaceX owns a constellation of over 11,000 satellites called Starlink that provides communication links to countries and companies. "@elonmusk", tweeted poster Fedorov from his X account, "while you try to colonise Mars — Russians try to occupy Ukraine! While your rockets successfully land from space — Russian rockets attack Ukrainian civilians! We ask you to provide Ukraine with Starlink stations and to address sane Russians to stand." "Starlink service is now active in Ukraine. More terminals en route," he posted by the same evening. In the next couple of days, Starlink provided 500 terminals, and the Ukrainian army was back in full action to throw the Russians out of Kyiv.

"Starlink is indeed the blood of our entire communication infrastructure now," boasted Fedorov. But the story doesn't end there. Soon, Musk demonstrated to Fedorov that it was his whims that carry the day for Ukraine, not the commands of Volodymyr Zelenskyy or Fedorov. When Fedorov placed an emergency request for Starlink systems over Crimea for the Ukrainian army to conduct a strike on the Russian naval fleet using submarine drones, Musk sternly reprimanded him, saying that "if the Ukrainian attacks had succeeded in sinking the Russian fleet, it would have been like a mini Pearl Harbour. We did not want to be a part of that." In effect, Musk became the self-appointed NSA of Ukraine at that moment.

Last year, when the Ukrainian army launched a pivotal push to retake territory occupied by the Russians, Musk suddenly ordered his company to cut coverage of its services in those regions, severely disrupting and denting the Ukrainians' ability to move ahead, resulting in their failure to recapture Russian positions. Currently, Ukrainian forces are reporting sudden blackouts and severe speed restrictions at their communication terminal that are causing panic for the soldiers on the field operating drones and other advanced systems. Musk shrugged this off, saying it was a political decision by the US administration and his company was simply implementing it.

The Ukrainian experience is illustrative of two important lessons: One, that a tech giant like Elon Musk probably had more power to support the Ukrainians in war than Western governments, and two, he not only helps but ultimately controls the war and its outcome. That is the heteropolar order in action.

On a visit to Budapest at the end of 2023, I heard from many analysts of the then-ruling dispensation that the Prime Minister of Hungary, Viktor Orbán, faced a major threat not from the liberal European leadership or the Democratic dispensation in Washington, DC, but from a fellow Hungarian, George Soros. Soros is a 95-year-old Hungarian-American hedge fund manager with a net worth of over $7 billion. He founded the Open Society Foundation, a philanthropic arm with a stated aim of working for justice, democratic governance and human rights. He is an open supporter of liberal parties and left-liberal NGOs and often grants huge donations to all and sundry causes, from campaigns on campuses to clashes on the streets. He is seen as an open enemy of right-wing leaders, from Donald Trump in America to Orbán.

In fact, Orbán's government spent millions of dollars on a poster campaign against Soros, accusing him of leading an international cabal to destabilise right-wing governments in Europe and elsewhere. Soros and his foundation acquired notoriety as dubious conspirators of "regime changes" and agents of chaos. Finally, Soros succeeded in ousting Orbán from power after 15 years last year. Interestingly, Musk himself compared Soros to X-Men villain Magneto in a tweet in May 2023. When an X user defended Soros as having good intentions, Musk responded, saying, "You assume they are good intentions. They are not. He wants to erode the very fabric of civilisation. Soros hates humanity."

Welcome to the heteropolar world, where big-tech *dadas* and big-money daddies can try to outmanoeuvre sovereign nations. That world is active in India too.

The writer is national vice-president, BJP and president, India Foundation

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'Attacking V-C, vandalism': SRFTI rusticates 6 students

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, October 16

SIX STUDENTS at Satyajit Ray Film and Television Institute (SRFTI) in Kolkata were rusticated Friday over their alleged involvement in the manhandling of Vice-Chancellor Santosh Ajmera, vandalism, and disruption of academic activities.

The rustication orders affect students from the editing and animation departments, among others, and cover multiple semesters.

SRFTI administration also stated that academic activities will remain suspended till November 13, and asked those occupying the hostels to vacate the premises within 24 hours.

"All regular academic activities of the Film wing and the Electronic and Digital Media (EDM) wing will be suspended until November 13. All students occupying institute premises, including hostel and other spaces, are directed to vacate such within 24 hours of issuance of this order," the notice stated.

The disciplinary action comes as protests at the film institute under the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting entered their third week.

In the rustication notices, the institute said it had considered a "grave incident involving physical assault, intimidation, obstruction and abusive conduct towards the Vice-Chancellor" before recommending the action. The administration alleged that protesting students pelted stones at V-C Ajmera's office on Wednesday night and Thursday morning.

According to the institute, the incident occurred after heads of departments and section heads met to condemn the alleged vandalism of the V-C's office. The institute alleged that Ajmera's office was attacked overnight, with stones thrown at the premises, windows shattered, and water and air-conditioning lines cut. "The office was found strewn with broken glasses, stone/s and damaged furniture on Thursday morning," the statement read.

Saying that Ajmera termed the "intimidating unacceptable", the statement added, "He also said that the actions of few students have disturbed peace, order and normal academic activities at the institute. He added that these students are intimidating others not to join classes for the last eight days and some therefore had to leave the campus for their home." The SRFTI Students' Union rejected the allegations, describing them as "completely fabricated".



Silence at Dal

A deserted view of a jet ski point on Dal Lake after the Jammu and Kashmir High Court banned jet skis and fuel-powered motorboats on the water body until further orders, citing environmental concerns, in Srinagar on Friday. Government boats used for emergencies, rescue, disaster management, law and order, and safety have been exempted from the ban. PTI

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

11 GORKHA RIFLES REGIMENTAL CENTRE



Indian Army and 11 Gorkha Rifles Salutes its brave heart, No 9420331 Late Lnk Kamal Kumar Limbu of 2/11 GR, who made supreme sacrifice during OP Rakshak (J&K) on 17 Oct 2000.

Colonel 11 GR & Sikkim Scouts and All Ranks

BORDER SECURITY FORCE



HEAD CONSTABLE RAJENDER SINGH 43 BN BSF 15.06.1966 – 17.10.2003



CONSTABLE SRI GOPAL 43 BN BSF 01.09.1968 – 17.10.2003

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawans Head Constable Rajender Singh and Constable Sri Gopal on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained fatal injuries in a grenade blast triggered by militants in Srinagar area, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.



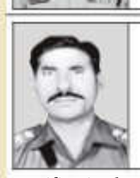
HEAD CONSTABLE VIJAY BHAN SINGH YADAV 117 BN BSF 08.11.1968 – 17.10.2019

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Head Constable Vijay Bhan Singh Yadav on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries in Counterpart firing in area of BOP Kakmarichar, Behrampur (West Bengal) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.



CONSTABLE HIRA LAL CHHETRY 91 BN BSF 22.07.1944 – 17.10.1971

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Hira Lal Chhetry on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he made ultimate sacrifice during Indo-Pak War in 1971.



INSPECTOR SOHAN LAL 62 BN BSF 13.07.1942 – 17.10.1994

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Subordinate officer Inspector Sohan Lal on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries while fighting militants in Kupwara area, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE



Veer Balidani Constable Naresh Lal 1 Bn 1-7-1942 To 17-10-1966

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Naresh Lal of 1 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice on 17 October 1966 after sustaining grievous injuries while valiantly countering an attack by insurgents in Manipur on 14 October 1966. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.



Veer Balidani Constable L. Shaktivel 18 Bn 4-7-1967 To 17-10-1991

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable L. Shaktivel of 18 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice in a cowardly attack by a terrorist in Punjab on 17 October 1991. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

WESTERN RAILWAY

SIGNALLING WORK

Sr.DSTE/North/Mumbai Central, 2nd Floor, Divisional Railway Manager's Office, Mumbai Central, Mumbai - 400 008, invites **E-Tender No: SG_216_2_173_WA_PH53. Work and Location:** Signalling work in connection with **(1)** Extension of High level Passenger platform at Nardana Paldhi under the section of ADEN/Amalner **(2)** Ukaisonghad-Jalgaon Section: Extension of Platform 1 AN & Platform 2 DXG with shelter hut cover shed on platform. **(3)** Amalner- Upgradation Development of station entry, PF surfacing work and extension of COP (PHASE-II) of Udhana-Jalgaon Section of Mumbai Division, Western Railway. **Approx. Cost of Work:** ₹ 1,06,87,459.43. **EMD:** ₹ 2,13,800/-. **Date & Time for Closure for Submission of E-Tender Documents:** Till 12.11.2026,15:00 hrs. **Date & Time for Opening of E-Tender:** On 12.11.2026 at 15:30 hrs. The tender can be viewed at website **www.ireps.gov.in** 0706

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EAST COAST RAILWAY

Tender Notice No. ST-OT-AMC-DATALOGGER-588, Dt : 14.10.2026

NAME OF WORK : PROVISION FOR COMPREHENSIVE ANNUAL MAINTENANCE CONTRACT OF EFFTRONICS MAKE: DATA LOGGERS OF DIFFERENT CAPACITY AT VARIOUS STATIONS/ LOCATIONS INCLUDING MAINTENANCE OF VARIOUS CENTRAL MONITOR EQUIPMENT/ SOFTWARE AT KHURDA ROAD DATALOGGER ROOM AND HEADQUARTER (BHUBANESWAR) OVER KHURDA ROAD DIVISION FOR THREE YEARS.

Tender Value : ₹8,00,00,169.94, **EMD:** ₹5,50,000/-, **Tender Document Cost :** ₹11,800/-

Bidding Start Date : 22.10.2026.

Tender Closing Date and Time : At 1100 Hrs. of 05.11.2026.

No manual offers sent by Post/ Courier/ Fax or in person accepted against such e-tenders even if these are submitted on firm's letter head and receipt in time. All such manual offers shall be considered invalid and shall be rejected summarily without any consideration.

Complete information including e-tender documents of the above e-tender is available in website : **www.ireps.gov.in**

Note : The prospective tenderers are advised to revisit the website 15 days before the date of closing of tender to note any changes / corrigendum issued for this tender.

Sr. Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer, Khurda Road

PR- 497/R/26-27

Tamil Nadu Power Distribution Corporation Ltd.

Notice Inviting Tenders (E-Tendering Process)

TNPDCL / SHORT / PP-47 / 2026-2027

TNPDCL invites E-Tender for procurement of power of 1000 MW for evening peak hours (18 - 24 hrs) for the period from 01.11.2026 to 31.05.2027 from both Interstate and Intrastate generators on firm basis from CERC / TNERC approved Traders / Generators. Bidding will be done as per the revised guidelines for short term procurement of power notified by the Ministry of Power vide resolution dated 30.03.2016 and as per amendments dated: 21.02.2022 through e-Bidding portal (DEEP) only and subsequent amendments thereof are applicable to this tender specification. The link for the e-Bidding portal is www.mstcecommerce.com and is also available on the website of Ministry of Power (www.powermin.nic.in) and PFC Consulting Ltd (www.pfcclindia.com). Specification is available in TNPDCL website and MSTC DEEP E-Bidding portal.

Chief Engineer / PPP TNPDCL

DIPR/3169/Tender/2026

झारखण्ड सरकार

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय

ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमण्डल, धनबाद

मोबाईल नं० : 7061981397 , Email : rdsd.dhanbad@rediffmail.com

पत्रांक:–1161 धनबाद / दिनांक–14.10.2026

शुद्धि पत्र

इस कार्यालय के पत्रांक 969 दिनांक 10.09.2026 के द्वारा आमंत्रित अति अल्पकालीन निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना सं0– RWD/SD/Dhanbad-34/2026-27 जिसका PR No. 389574 Rural Development (26-27)#D में प्रकाशित निविदा की तिथि में निम्नवत् संशोधन किया जाता है।

क्र0	विवरणी	पूर्व में प्रकाशित तिथि	संशोधित तिथि
1.	वेबसाइट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि	दिनांक 24.09.2026	दिनांक 30.10.2026
2.	ई0 निविदा प्राप्ति की तिथि एवं समय	दिनांक 24.09.2026 से दिनांक 03.10.2026 को अपराह्न 05:00 बजे तक।	दिनांक 30.10.2026 से दिनांक 07.11.2026 को अपराह्न 05:00 बजे तक।
3.	ई0 निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय	दिनांक 05.10.2026 अपराह्न 02:00 बजे।	दिनांक 10.11.2026 अपराह्न 02:00 बजे।

अतः अन्य शर्तें यथावत रहेंगी।

कार्यपालक अभियंता
ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमंडल, धनबाद

PR 391985 Rural Development (26-27) D"

WESTERN RAILWAY

PAY AND USE NORMAL TOILET BLOCKS

E-auction for the contract for operation and maintenance of Normal Pay and use toilet blocks over Mumbai Division has been invited by **ACM (R) - MMCT. Auction Catalogue No: MMCT-PnUT-26-33. Type of Contract:** ROMT-contract. **Category:** Pay and Use Toilet blocks. **Station and Location:** ROMT - Deluxe/Modern Standard Pay & Use Toilet Complex at Borivali station (SG-1) west circulating area. **Contract Period:** 10 Years. **Date of E-Auction:** 29.10.2026, **Time of E-Auction:**15:00 hrs. **Note:** Prospective bidders are requested to visit e-Auction leasing module on IREPS website **(www.ireps.gov.in)** The lot wise details are available there in under the mentioned catalogue. Initial cooling off period is 30 minutes. Successive Lot closing interval is 10 Minutes. Lot wise closing times can be viewed in e-auction module of IREPS. 0716

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WESTERN RAILWAY

CONTRACT WORK FOR PROVISION OF MANPOWER FOR TRAIN PASSING ACTIVITIES

Sr.DME(Co.)/Mumbai Central invites **Tender Notice No: Mech-TPA-2026 Dtd.14.10.2026. Name of Work:** Contract work for provision of manpower for Train passing activities at Coaching Depots- Mumbai Central, Bandra Terminus, Jogeshwari (AT), Vasai Road, Valsad, Bilimora, Udhna Junction, Surat & Nandurbar for a period of 4 (four years) due to shortage of manpower for core Train maintenance (Primary & Secondary). **Approx. Cost of Work:** ₹ 52,26,15,823.34 (All inclusive). **Bid Security:** ₹ 27,63,100/-. **Tender Submission Closing Date & Time:** On 12.11.2026 at 15:00 Hrs. For further details please visit our website **www.ireps.gov.in** 0713

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GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER

RURAL WORKS CIRCLE, BOLANGIR

25001/1346/2627

e-Procurement Notice

1.	**Name of work**	:	Construction of different Buildings (DIET and Court) in the district of Subarnapur for the year 2026-27
2.	**No. of works**	:	3 (Three) works
3.	**Time for completion**	:	9 (Nine) to 12 (Twelve) Calender months
4.	**Approximate estimated cost varies from**	:	Rs. 125.35 lakhs to Rs. 872.03 lakhs
5.	**Mode of Submission of tender**	:	Tender should be submitted online in www.tendersodisha.gov.in
6.	**Other details are as follow**		

Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No.	Availability of Tender online for bidding		Last date and time of seeking tender clarification	Date & Time of opening of Tender	
		From	To		Technical Bid	Financial Bid
Chief Construction Engineer, R.W Circle, Bolangir	BLGR. Online 26/2026-27	28.10.2026 at 11.00 A.M.	11.11.2026 upto 5.00 P.M	10.11.2026 upto 5.00 P.M.	12.11.2026 at 11.00 A.M	The date will be intimated Iater on

- Further details can be seen from the website **www.tendersodisha.gov.in**
- Any Corrigendum/Addendum will be displayed in the above e tender website only.

Sd/-
Chief Construction Engineer
R. W. Circle, Bolangir

OIPR- 25001/25118/1/26-27/0029

GOVT. OF ODISHA

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, RURAL WORKS DIVISION-II, NAYAGADA

25001/1360/2627

E-mail- Nayagadarvv2@yahoo.in

e-Procurement Notice

1.	Name of the work	:	Road & Building works.
2.	Total No. of Projects	:	2 Nos of project
3.	Class of Contractor	:	
	A) Estimated cost above Rs. 20.00 Lakhs & up to Rs. 3.00 Crore	:	**B** Class (of Odisha PWD) or relevant class of other licensing authorities.
	B) Estimated cost up to Rs. 40.00 Lakhs	:	**C** Class(of Odisha PWD) or relevant class of other licensing authorities
	C) Estimated cost up to Rs. 20.00 Lakhs	:	**D** Class (of Odisha PWD) or relevant class of other licensing authorities.
4.	Estimated cost put to tender	:	Rs.63.56 to 67.40 lakhs
5	Time for completion	:	05 (Five) calendar month
6.	Other details.	:	

Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No.	Availability of Tender on-line for bidding		Last Date & Time of seeking tender	Date & Time of opening
		From	To		
1	2	3	4	5	6
Superintending Engineer, Rural Works Division-II, Nayagada	Tender- Online - Divn.-II NAYAGADA - 10/2026-27	29.10.2026 at 10.00 A.M.	12.11.2026 upto 5.00 P.M	Dt. 12.11.2026 upto 5.00 P.M	13.11.2026 at 10.30 A.M.

Further details can be seen from the website www.tendersorissa.gov.in

Sd/-
Superintending Engineer
R.W. Division-II, Nayagadal

OIPR-25001/25144/1/26-27/0013

ONLINE TENDERING

Project Implementation Unit, Gandhinagar (Health & Family Welfare Dept.)

TENDER NOTICE PIU-101 (2026-27)

Online tenders for Health Care facilities Civil works of Various Districts Gujarat as below are invited by the Superintending Engineer, Project Implementation Unit, NRHM/PIU Building 4th Floor, Civil Hospital Campus, Gandhinagar. 382012, Ph. 079-23231434, 23231393,

Sr. No.	Name of Work	Est.Cost in Lacs (Rs.)	Tender Fee/EMD (Rs.)	Approved Regst. Class	Time Limit in Months	ID NO
1	New Construction of Government Spine Institute & Paraplegia Hospital, Rehabilitation Center, Spine College and Hostel block at New Mental Campus, Meghaninagar, Ahmedabad	23778.51	30000/-23800000/-	AA and Special Building Category-1	24	9108 & 9220

Pre Bid Dtd 30.10.2026 up to 12.00 hrs

On Line Submission Dtd. 18.11.2026 upto 18.00 hrs.

Submission of Tender Fee, EMD & Other Original Documents on Dtd. 18.11.2026 Online (Documents Shall have to be Scanned & put up Online. The Original Documents shall have to be submitted within 7 days through R.P.A.D Only)

Bid Opening of tender dtd. 25.11.2026 upto 12.00 hrs.

INF-1633-2026-27

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY

1st Corrigendum to E-Tender Notice No 175 to 176 of 26-27

E- Tender Notice No 175 to 176 of 26-27, scheduled to opened on 28.10.2026, in newspapers of Hindi & English publication in which E-Tender notice No. 163 to 164 of 26-27 has been published which may be read as E-Tender Notice No. 175 & 176 of 26-27. All other term's & conditions shall remain same **No. 580-W/CMS Crossing/Tongue Rails/SSA/ 2026 Dated-15.10.2026**

Divi. Rly. Manager/Engg. Bikaner

1500-DO/26

MAHATRANSCO

Maharashtra State Electricity Transmission Co. Ltd.

NOTICE INVITING TENDER CPD/61-2026-27

Tenders are invited through e-Tendering in SRM Two Bid system from the registered vendors for Supply of following:

Tender No. & Description of Material	Estimated Amount (in Rs. Lakhs) / Tender Fee (in Rs.) Excluding GST	Due Date & Time (Hrs.) for Submission & Opening of Tender
SP/T-0515/1026 RFx:5000001623 (1st Call) for Procurement of 145kV & 245kV WEB/WOEB Isolators (Total 283 Sets) for Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, Karad, Nashik & Pune Zones of MSETCL.	2662.34 Lakhs / 25,000.00	30.10.2026 17:00 Hrs / 30.10.2026 17.15 Hrs
Pre-Bid Queries to be Addressed to : The Executive Engineer (Group-V), MSETCL, "Prakashgad", Bandra (E), Mumbai	**On or Before** 19.10.2026	**Time** @17:30Hrs.

Contact Person: Office of the Executive Engineer (Gr-V)
CPA, C.O. MSETCL, 1st Floor, Prakashgad Building, Bandra (E), Mumbai.
Tel. No.:022-69852717/69852720
Email id: cecpa@mahatransco.in, secpa@mahatransco.in, eegrp5@mahatransco.in, eepc@mahatransco.in,
For further details visit our website **https://srmetender.mahatransco.in/**
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Sd/- **Executive Engineer (P&C)**

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Sr. DEN (South) Mumbai Central, Mumbai - 400 008. invites **E-Tender Notice No: BCT/26-27/190 dt.15.10.2026. Work and Location: Churchgate - Virar:-** Construction of Precast RCC drain during deep screening by BCM at Platform areas. **Approx. Cost of Work:** ₹ 4,43,79,968.80. **EMD:** ₹ 8,87,600/-. **Date & Time of Submission:** Till 13.11.2026, 15:00 Hrs. **Date & Time of Opening:** On 13.11.2026 at 15:30 Hrs. For further details please visit our website **www.ireps.gov.in** 0718

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S. E. RAILWAY – TENDER

Tender No. : T-PUB-GRC-2026-434 Dt. 13.10.2026. For on behalf of the President of India, the Sr. Divisional Engineer, South Eastern Railway, Garden Reach, Kolkata-700043 invites E-tender for the following works before 15.00 hrs on the date mentioned against items and will be opened at 15.30 hrs. **Description of Works:** Improvement of water treatment plant at South Eastern Railway Headquarter under the jurisdiction of ADEN/SETT/GRC. **Tender Value:** ₹ 4,39,02,124.78 (including GST). **Earnest Money:** ₹ 8,78,100.00. **Cost of Tender Documents :** ₹ 0. **Date of Opening :** 18.11.2026. **Completion period of the work :** 08 months. Any change in tender schedule, corrigendum, amendment, if any shall be available on the E-tender portal only and same will not be publish in the newspaper. Interested Tenderers may visit website **www.ireps.gov.in** for full Details / Description/specification of the Tenders and submit their bids online. In no case manual tenders for these works will be accepted. **N. B.** Prospective Bidders may regular visit **www.ireps.gov.in** to participate in all tenders. Help Desk cont. no. 033-2450-3783 **(PR-914)**

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3.	Senior Demonstrators of different departments	6	
4.	Junior Demonstrators of different departments	3	
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7	Senior Medical Officers	2	

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OPENING DATE FOR ONLINE REGISTRATION FOR FILLING UP OF ONLINE APPLICATION ON PGIMER's WEBSITE www.pgimer.edu.in (Recruitment link at Home Page)	16.10.2026
CLOSING DATE FOR ONLINE REGISTRATION & SUBMISSION OF ONLINE APPLICATIONS	13.11.2026
DATE FOR COMPUTER BASED TEST (CBT) FOR 75 MARKS	05.12.2026
EXAMINATION CITY	4 CITIES IN INDIA (CHANDIGARH (Tricity), DELHI/NCR, HYDERABAD & KOLKATA)

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Any person, individual, firm, or institution dealing with the Developer and/or its aforesaid partners with respect to, touching or concerning the Society's property or any part thereof shall do so at their own risk and responsibility, and the Society shall not be held liable for any claims or obligations arising therefrom. The Society shall hereafter be at liberty to deal with or create third party rights over the said property at its own discretion.

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Sd/-
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Date: 17/10/2026
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ANAND MOHAN J

PATIENT NO. 32, KAJAL SAIYYAM

DEATHS OF CHILDREN IN BALAGHAT, MADHYA PRADESH

Of the 32 children who recently died in Balaghat, a tribal district in Madhya Pradesh, was Kajal Saiyyam. She loved mathematics, wanted to get into a "bigger school", grow up to be a doctor. ANAND MOHAN J travels to Balaghat and finds that a lot can come in the way of a 10-year-old's dreams — social backwardness, malnutrition, and an underserved health system

THERE WAS something about Kajal Saiyyam. Something so remarkable that she filled the desolate tribal homes in her Mohanpur village, in Madhya Pradesh's Balaghat, with a rare kind of hope. The girl with a head for mathematics, the girl who helped her elder siblings with their textbooks, the girl who stood up "boldly" in class one day and said she wanted to become a doctor while the others around her giggled shyly, the girl who wrote and read out her Independence Day speech without a fault.

The 10-year-old had faced the school assembly that day, August 15, in her coffee brown school uniform, her braided pigtails held up with white ribbons, and delivered the speech, not once looking at the rolled up piece of paper that she clutched tightly in her right hand.

Now, as Kajal's mother Usha frantically looks for that paper, she empties out a plastic bag and her daughter's hospital discharge papers — detailing how the 10-year-old died of plasmodium falciparum malaria, septic shock and plummeting oxygen and sugar levels — tumble out.

The speech is soon found, just the way Kajal had left it, tucked away in a notebook. Usha smiles briefly at the recovery, before the pain takes over. "I never went to school, so I can't read what she wrote... *Meri pyari* Kajal (my precious Kajal)," Usha says, handing over the paper to her eldest daughter, Payal, 14.

"*Aap sabhi ko mera namaskar. Mera naam* Kajal *hai* (My greetings to all of you. My name is Kajal)," Payal begins. It's a short speech about national pride, courage, patriotism and sacrifice. "*Mujhe apne desh se bahut pyaar hai. Mujhe apne Bharatiya hone par garv hai* (I love my country. I am proud to be Indian). Jai Hind, Jai Bharat."

Usha listens with a mix of pride and bewilderment, using her saree *pallu* to wipe the tears that flow freely.

On August 29, Kajal ended up as Patient Number 32, the last of the children on the Balaghat health department's list of those who died after a cocktail of deadly diseases descended on the tribal villages in the lush green hills of eastern Madhya Pradesh, near the state's border with Chhattisgarh. The 32 victims, between 1 and 13 years, had reported high fever, rashes, red spots, stomach pain and ulcers.

With the deaths sparking political outrage, an investigation by the Centre's National Joint Outbreak Response Team found that between June and August, as measles, malaria, chikungunya and dengue coursed through a region with severe malnourishment levels, Balaghat district's disease surveillance system fell woefully short. The investigation found that Balaghat didn't have a public health laboratory, and the crucial posts of district epidemiologist and microbiologist lay vacant, with a data operator running the surveillance system.

Since then, the state has attempted to control the damage, with the Mohan Yadav-led BJP government suspending the district vaccination and malaria control officers. The government has now mobilised an army of health workers to stem the flow of the infections, vaccinating 40,000 children, identifying over 8,000 patients and admitting 745 of them to hospitals.

Emerging out of a gruelling meeting with officials of the health department, Dr Shatrughan Dahiya, Chief Medical and Health Officer of Balaghat, says, "There are gaps in manpower which we are working on."

Deep inside Balaghat

The outbreak spread primarily across Birsa and Baihar blocks of Balaghat that are inhabited by the Gond and Baiga communities. While the Gonds, the community to which Kajal belongs, are relatively well-off, the Baigas are one of Madhya Pradesh's three Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups. Their backwardness, combined with a reliance on local traditions, has meant that they are largely outside of the health system.

With no early warning systems in place, the health department missed the first infections that broke out among Baiga children in Matla, a village on the fringes of the Kanha national park.

Health workers say the first deaths were in Mahasingh Parte's house, a one-room, anthill-like structure that appears in sight at the end of a difficult uphill trek. The houses in Matla, part of Adori panchayat in Birsa block, are scattered across forested slopes and fields.

Mahasingh's children, three-year-old Ruhi and Ram, a little over a year old, died on May 18 after their bodies broke out in painful rashes. The same morning, a third child from the village, 10-year-old Sadesh, died after developing similar symptoms.

All three children had been taken to a *panda pujari*, a faith healer who sprinkled 'holy water' on them to appease "Choti Mata", as the Baiga tribals believed the infections to be the wrath of the local deity.



Kajal delivering her Independence Day speech in school. She died two weeks later



> **"Kajal sometimes took classes when there were no teachers. She was brilliant. It's impressive for a girl growing up in these parts."**
> SUNITA PARDI,
> KAJAL 'S CLASS TEACHER

In Matla, like in Korka, Bondari and Kondekasi villages that *The Indian Express* visited in Adori panchayat, the post of ASHA workers and ANMs — community workers at the frontline of the health system — lay vacant.

"Most ASHA workers are from the Baiga tribe. It's difficult for them to attend to calls for help... How can they, for instance, take a pregnant woman or a sick child to a hospital 40 km away in the dead of the night? Their husbands usually forbid them from working because of these challenges," says ASHA supervisor Vimla Yadav, who, since the outbreak, has been trying to reach out to Baiga families, document children left out of health records, identify symptoms and persuade parents to vaccinate them.

As more children started falling ill in these parts, on July 22, Parshuram Dhurwey, sarpanch of Adori panchayat, alerted then sub-divisional magistrate Arpit Gupta of three children dying in Bondari village.

"Until then, we thought the fever was just seasonal flu," says Gupta, who sent a team to the village the following day.

Over the next few days, as health officials went house to house, they found sick children in nearly every home. Bondari, where at least one child was sick in each of 103 homes, became the focal point of the response.

Baihar's Congress MLA Sanjay Uikey said the children could not be saved "because there is no healthcare system in Balaghat". "All the healthcare centres are 40-50 km away, and the ASHA and ANM posts are vacant. Many of the children were not given measles vaccine. Malnutrition was a big factor in the deaths, and the take-home ration that anganwadis give has been on hold for months now," he says.

Under the Centrally sponsored Integrated Child Development Services (ICDS) scheme, anganwadis distribute nutritional premixes to children and pregnant and lactating women. However, officials said, take-home rations had not been supplied in these parts for over six months.

Dr Dahiya, the Chief Medical and Health Officer of Balaghat, said, "We are resuming take-home ration packets."

The 'sabse alag' child

As more children died in Adori, 45 km away, in Kajal's Mohanpur village, there was no hint of the gathering storm.

She would walk to school with her sisters Payal and Aanchal, 12, while the family's youngest, three-year-old Abhi, attended the local anganwadi. Her father Prabhulal, who worked as a labourer, says, "I had to leave school after Class 5 and work for my family. But I ensured my children studied."

Prabhulal says he knew his second child was "*sabse alag* (different)". While most children her age spent hours playing hide-and-seek in the lush sal forests, Kajal spent hours solving sums from her mathematics books — first her own and then her sister Payal's, four levels higher.

The family was stumped when the girl cracked a block-level Math Olympiad conducted by the state government. "The teacher told us she cleared the block-level exam, but not the district level. She said some tuitions will help, but I couldn't afford that," says Prabhulal.

The family lives in a bare, two-room, unplastered house in Mohanpur. Outside, green fields stretch towards a row of trees and scattered houses.

In one of the two rooms, schoolbags and books are stacked on a wooden table that's pushed against the brick wall. It was here that Kajal spent hours studying or playing with her siblings, her favourite accessory a torch her father bought her recently. "Power cuts are a big problem here. Kajal would cry every time the lights went out and then use the torch on my husband's phone to study. One day, he bought her a small torch," says Usha.

Kajal loved the torch, using it to study for two hours in the evening, before she and her sisters goofed around with it, flashing it in each other's faces.

But of late, says Prabhulal, Kajal had been obsessed about getting into a "*bada* (bigger) school" — the Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya in Warseoni, 45 km away.

At the Government Higher Secondary School in Mohanpur village, Sunita Pardi, Kajal's class teacher, says she would burst into her classroom every morning and ask her if she had filled the form for the Navodaya examinations to be held in November — "Ma'am, *mera form bhara kya*?." Sunita says they finally submitted the form a few days after August 15.

Talking about her "favourite student", Sunita says, "Kajal sometimes took classes when there were no teachers. That's how brilliant she was. She won a gold medal this August 15 for scoring the highest marks in her class. It's impressive for a girl growing up in these parts. Children here can barely read or do basic mathematics. Their parents are almost all uneducated, and many take their children with them when they leave for temporary work outside the state," she says.

Sitting with her books on the terrace of their home, Payal, the eldest of the Saiyyam sisters, recalls how she would hang out here with Kajal for hours. "She wrote her Independence Day speech here. We would also click pictures together on my father's phone. I would edit the pictures with funny filters and make her laugh," says the 14-year-old.

Payal opens her English literature book, haltingly reads out from a page, before giving up. "Kajal used to teach me every evening," she says.

Her last words: 'Papa, I'm alive'

On a rainy August morning, Kajal and her siblings were walking to school, a 15-minute trek through the forests, when they noticed ambulances wailing in and out of homes. "We had never seen ambulances here... that too so many," recalls Anchal, Kajal's younger sister.

By then, children had been falling ill in Mohanpur and nearby villages. Payal fell ill, too, but she recovered.

Kajal was focused on writing her Independence Day speech and preparing for the Navodaya entrance exam.

The family had managed to borrow a guidebook from Punaram Bhalavi, who cracked the Navodaya entrance exam many years ago. Bhalavi, who eventually dropped out of his BSc course and now tutors children in his village, says, "I gave Kajal my copy. I had heard so much about her from our teachers. I wanted her to do well. It's not easy for children here to succeed. So many dreams get crushed."

When the old guidebook arrived, Kajal quickly got to work, making notes and studying into the night, her torch beside her. Then, on August 23, Kajal fell ill.

The family missed the danger signs. They allege no health workers visited them either. Kajal's teacher Sunita says, "The family did not take it seriously because Kajal has had malaria three times in the past and recovered each time. Which is why they kept sending her to school even after she fell sick. That was such a big mistake."

Prabhulal says they didn't think much of the fever. "She had a fever but was active and talking, excited about her exam," he says.

On August 27, things turned. "She told me, papa, I don't feel well. We fed her pomegranate and let her sleep," he says. She woke up in the middle of the night, crying, the fever splitting her head open.

The family knocked on the doors of their neighbours for help. With no mobile signal, they could not call an ambulance. Someone brought an autorickshaw and Kajal, shivering with fever, was taken to Balaghat, 28 km away, for Rs 1,500.

At Life Care, a private hospital in Balaghat, Kajal, who had had fever for about five days, was diagnosed with malaria. She suffered seizures, vomited, and fell unconscious as her blood sugar levels dropped to a critical 12 mg/dl. Doctors admitted her to the ICU, intubated her and put her on a ventilator.

The ICU stay drained the family savings. As the hospital bills climbed to Rs 90,000, Prabhulal sold his wife's gold bangles and mortgaged her earrings and necklaces.

For a brief while, there seemed to be hope. On August 28, as Kajal regained consciousness, Prabhulal rushed to his daughter's bedside, hoping she would fight back one more time. "*Papa, mein zinda ho gayi* (Papa, I am alive)," Kajal said, her last words before she drifted into unconsciousness.

At 4.29 am on August 28, Kajal was referred to a private hospital in Gondia, 44 km across the border in Maharashtra. Then, early on August 29, Kajal died. She was finally laid to rest in an open field, 500 metres from her home.

At her funeral, Kajal's relatives suggested that the family part with her belongings in line with tribal customs that mandate the erasure of physical reminders of the dead. As an inconsolable Prabhulal dropped Kajal's uniform, bags, and books into a ritual fire, her teacher Sunita pleaded with the community elders to spare her notebooks. "We managed to save her books just in time. She had the best notes. We will show them to our students as an inspiration."

THE CRISIS AND AFTER

After 32 children, aged 1 to13, died in Balaghat district of Madhya Pradesh, the state government carried out an intensive surveillance programme to stem the flow of infections

49,988 screened in 57 villages in Birsa & Baihar blocks of Balaghat

8,296 patients identified

745 patients hospitalised

8 still under treatment

40,848 children vaccinated

WHERE BALAGHAT LAGS

29.7% of children under five were stunted, against the state's 24.5%

34.8% were underweight, against MP's 30.5%

76.8% of households had an improved drinking-water source, against MP's 89%

66.9% of children aged 2–4 attended preschool, against MP's 70.1%



After the deaths, health workers have been reaching out to villagers



Kajal (third from left) and the other toppers with teacher Sunita Pardi (far left)



At Bondari village, Somwati talks of how she lost her daughter Pooja to measles

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Playing it by the Book

Shubhra Gupta

THE CASE against Ajmal Kasab, the terrorist who was captured alive during the attack on 26/11 was built by public prosecutor Ujjwal Nikam, whose painstaking methods left not a shred of doubt about the former's guilt.

Rajkummar Rao brings a dogged sincerity to his playing of Nikam, but the film never really shakes off its dominant quality — it is as by-the-numbers as it can get, in both re-creating the glimpses of that terrible night during which a terrorist group took Mumbai hostage, as well as the courtroom proceedings in which defence lawyer Abbas Kazmi (Sikandar Kher) works hard to dismantle the case, under the watchful eye of the judge (Ashish Vidyarthi).

Given the flood of films and serials based on 26/11 over the past years, the challenge was always going to be to give us something new. How do you make a 'hero' out of a workaholic who devotes all his time to his job, ignoring his family? Nikam is built for the audience as the kind of lawyer who believes in amassing every last shred of evidence duly documented in piles of *sarkaari* files: his righteousness is based on plodding process, not drama.

The easy option then is to create domestic conflict. Nikam's long-suffering wife (Wamiqa Gabbi) is made the centre of a conflict between husband and son (Ritvik Sahore). While that may have been intended as a way to show that well-regarded professionals also have blind spots, these portions also come off predictable: the thread of a workaholic father passing on his own father's expectations to his son had the potential to be thorny, but is conveniently resolved.

Ironically, a film intended to showcase the fairness of the Indian legal system, which holds off judgment till the case is watertight, is made interesting by its depiction of the bad guy. Lalit Prabhakar's Kasab gives us a believable villain through a range of emotions — from sly cruelty to straight-up lying and evasion during his trial, to the growing awareness of his crime as he waits in his cell. The creation of a 'jihadi' coming from a place of ignorance — *yahaan bhi Eid manaate hain kya*, he asks his prison guard — is a nice, if familiar touch.

The exchanges between Nikam and Pakistani legal eagle Zulfikar (Jaideep Ahlawat) give the film a chance to add sorely-needed nuance, and we see that at play in a smartly-written sequence, in which both men show mutual respect while coming to an accommodation over a feast. Refusing to take refuge in jingoism is also a noteworthy aspect, making the carnage a crime against humanity, not just reducing it to a religious divide.

The performances are all solid, with Ahlawat leaving a mark — no surprises there — even in a walk-on part. Good to see Ashish Vidyarthi properly back in the saddle, in a rounded role: he presides over his court with precision and empathy, making sure that, in the end, justice is done.

Overall, though, the film remains worthy, but stodgy.

PRAHAAR: THE UNTOLD STORY OF UJJWAL NIKAM
★★½
DIRECTOR: Avinash Arun
CAST: Rajkummar Rao, Lalit Prabhakar, Wamiqa Gabbi, Sikandar Kher, Ashish Vidyarthi, Ritvik Sahore, Ajinkya Deo



Swallowed by Spectacle

Shalini Langer

In this film, the way to a father's heart lies literally through a whale's stomach. Literally.

As if Austin Abrams wasn't put through enough hell in the recent Resident Evil, he returns for *Whalefall*, adapted from a book, where he spends 90 per cent of the time being tossed around in the belly of a beast which is a sperm whale.

It's an ambitious project for sure, and director Brian Duffield is seriously committed to it, not giving us a break from all that could lie in that giant mammal's insides, from digestive acids to the remains of things swallowed up by it, to a lot of other floating and hanging stuff that it's best left to one's imagination. What it boils down to is Abrams's Jay being squeezed multiple times between sinewy, slithering, throbbing walls and — you guessed it right — surviving.

What has landed the college-going Jay in this situation is memories of his dad Mitt (Josh Brolin), who was a well-known scuba driver locally — the kind of rough man's man who has many admirers for his ocean-hewn wisdom and knowledge but who does not know how to converse with his son.

Mitt also has a wife (Elisabeth Shue) and two daughters, presumably elder to Jay. So inconsequential are the three that the film doesn't even bother giving them a name.

After one particularly bad exchange with Mitt, who is already pretty beat due to cancer, Jay leaves to join college in Iowa. That would be their last meeting and, partly due to guilt, partly due to anger, Jay does not visit him during his last days in hospital, nor goes to his grave or read the letter Mitt left behind for each member of the family. Mitt did so before jumping to death into the sea.

So, Jay decides a year later to salvage that guilt by trying to find his remains. Once that expedition lands him inside the sperm whale's stomach, it is the many, many discourses Mitt delivered to him over the years about the sea and the whale that lead Jay out. During the course of this, the whale and Mitt become one, metaphorically.

It's not that dire as that sounds, but it is not much better either. Abrams, a fine actor, does what he can to convey fear in many forms, and Brolin's rippling-muscled, tattooed frame fits right into this world where people say things like: "Kids can be predators, you must become a dangerous prey"; "A whale is forever"; and "Survivors survive".

The sound effects and cinematography when Jay first dives into the ocean are stunning, particularly the clickety sound of the whale's movement, coming to us muffled through the water.

The story's arc, sadly, is not that convincing, neither Mitt's nor Jay's, with the women in their lives ignored to the point that it is criminal. Especially Shue, who has been waiting for a deserving role for a very long time.

Jay may have been swallowed whole but it is she who feels chewed and spat out.

WHALEFALL
★★½
DIRECTOR: Brian Duffield
CAST: Austin Abrams, Josh Brolin, Elisabeth Shue, John Ortiz

Setting the Record Straight

TENZING
★★★
DIRECTOR: Jennifer Peedom
CAST: Genden Phuntsok, Tom Hiddleston, Willem Dafoe, Caitríona Balfe
STREAMING ON: Apple TV

Alaka Sahani



THE BIOGRAPHICAL adventure drama, *Tenzing*, directed by Jennifer Peedom, chronicles the triumphant 1953 Mount Everest expedition, during which Nepalese mountaineer Tenzing Norgay and New Zealander Edmund Hillary became the first climbers to reach the summit of the world's highest mountain. Rather than adopting a triumphant tone, however, the film is reflective and reverential, paying homage to the majestic Everest, known as Chomolungma in Tibetan, which loosely translates to 'Goddess Mother of the Earth'.

The biopic is also a historical course correction, shifting the focus from the British-led expedition to Tenzing, the Bhutia climber whose contribution was crucial to its success. It traces his lifelong obsession with the mountain, beginning in 1924, when, as a young boy in a Tibetan valley, he gazed at Everest with awe. His fascination deepens as he grows older and attempts to join mountaineering expeditions. He first earns his place as a porter before eventually securing a spot as a climber in the 1953 expedition.

The film repeatedly returns to the mountain's grandeur, reminding viewers of its formidable presence and the indomitable human ambition to reach its summit. Admiring the majestic landscape, British Army officer John Hunt (Willem Dafoe), who led the expedition, wonders, "What's possible up there? What's the limit?" The film also pays a quiet tribute to legendary British alpinist George Mallory, recalling Tenzing's encounter with him as a child and, later, Hillary's reference to Mallory's book.

Through its multiple flashbacks, the film raises philosophical questions about human ambition, faith and the relationship between man and nature. The local belief that Everest is a goddess remains central to the narrative. When Tenzing seeks the blessings of a local deity and asks a priest how to reach the summit, he is told, "You will climb the way a child climbs into mother's lap".

However, as the narrative shifts between the expedition and Tenzing's life, the film struggles to maintain a sharp focus. While its reverence for Everest lends the story a contemplative quality, the frequent flashbacks interrupt the narrative's momentum, pulling attention away from the expedition. The film's strongest premise lies in reclaiming Tenzing's place in mountaineering history, but these digressions come at the expense of a more compelling account of how this indigenous mountaineer, through sheer determination, made history.

The cinematography by Stefan Duscio makes Tenzing a rewarding visual experience. Peedom, known for her climbing documentaries Sherpa and Mountain, captures the spectacular mountain landscape in all its glory while conveying the formidable challenges of climbing it. The performances of the three actors who portray Tenzing at different stages of his life are engaging. Samdrup Dorje Lama plays him as a boy, Tenzin Dalha as a young man, and Genden Phuntsok as the older climber who joins the 1953 expedition. Both Tom Hiddleston and Willem Dafoe are wonderful as Hillary and Hunt, respectively.

Peedom and writer Luke Davies also make a strong statement about outsiders who make history through grit and perseverance. Being a Bhutia, Tenzing was considered an outsider by the Sherpas, while Hillary, a New Zealander, was an outsider among the British climbers. Yet, both overcame these social and cultural boundaries to achieve what had long seemed impossible.

Tenzing works better as a social narrative about perseverance and historical recognition than as a thrilling cinematic account of one of mountaineering's greatest achievements.

All Spell, No Substance

Shubhra Gupta

LABELLING A good-looking, confident woman, unwilling to be boxed into the coy, submissive template, a *daayan* happens too often even in this day and age. To decode generations of social prejudice and conditioning across genders is a chance that films should take, even if they fear falling under yet another dreaded label — a 'female-oriented' movie.

When *Nayyi Navelli* begins, with Yami Gautam as the new *dulhan* who arouses the suspicions of her *devar* (Anurag Thakur) and his pal, you really want the film to deliver on the promise. Fronted by Gautam, who did a wonderful job in *Haq*, and an ensemble which looks like fun — the last time you had Mita Vashishth and Sushmita Mukherjee, both capable of delightful ditziness, sharing a frame was in the '90s — this one feels like it had so much potential.

Sadly, it is comprehensively squandered in scattered writing-and-execution.

Right from the time Mohini (Gautam) glides into her husband's (Addinath Kothare) joint family, she doesn't do the things that new brides are expected to, and each of those 'omissions' becomes an accusatory list, from the feet-not-dipped-into-*aalta*, to not-going-near-temples. Gasp.

The family, which is always to be found sitting in the courtyard of their large Meerut *kothi*, is suitably shocked. What is the secret Mohini is hiding? Is there really an artefact with amazing powers in the vicinity? Could brother-in-law Bantu — Anurag Thakur is the best part of the film — be wrong?

All seems ripe for a cracking yarn, wrapped in a genre that continues to thrive. Bollywood's rediscovery of horror comedies being a palatable way to tell these stories of subversion since *Stree*, has become a flood.

Films revolving around strong female characters will always be welcome, but those stories need to be told well. Once the premise is laid, this *Nayyi Navelli* rolls over into a creaky rigmarole in which, amongst other things, nestles a sub-plot about a not-so-good-looking *bua* (Vashisht) and her betrayed suitor (Kulshreshth). It is meant to be a statement against lookism, but leaves behind a bad taste.

There's more. A character declaims solemnly that Meerut's roots stretch back to a *yug* when the events of the Ramayan unfolded. So there's our Ram and Ravan, and the battle between good and evil, timed with Dussehra, with Gautam morphing into a flaming savior of all she surveys.

A disclaimer is safely in place to divest the film from the epic's traditionally acknowledged source-material, but no one warns us the extent to which it will become an exercise in patience. The feminist angle, which gave the film its initial fillip, is forgotten, replaced by an unwatchable mess.

NAYYI NAVELLI
★
DIRECTOR: Balaji Mohan
CAST: Yami Gautam, Addinath Kothare, Anurag Thakur, Mita Vashisht, Sonal Jha, Sunita Rajwar, Sushmita Mukherjee, Aaditya Kulshreshth, Suneel Sinha

• STREAMING WATCHLIST



The Invite
ZEE 5

Dark comedy *The Invite* explores the complexities of marriage, relationships and the unexpected turns an ordinary dinner party can take. When a couple invites their upstairs neighbours over for dinner, what begins as a seemingly casual evening soon takes an unpredictable turn, bringing unspoken tensions and complicated dynamics to the surface. Blending humour with relationship drama, *The Invite* offers a sharp and entertaining take on intimacy, marriage and the awkward truths that can emerge when people come together. The cast feature Olivia Wilde, Penélope Cruz, Seth Rogen and Edward Norton.



The Diplomat S4
NETFLIX

After *The Diplomat*'s shocking Season 3 finale, its Season 4 returns with surprises ahead for Ambassador Kate Wyler (Keri Russell), her husband Vice President Hal Wyler (Rufus Sewell). In the new season, one unfortunate moment shatters the peace Kate Wyler brokered between the US and UK, as well as the crumbling marriage she's trying to save. While she fights to stem the bleeding, President Grace Penn and VP Hal Wyler's conspiracy to steal Russia's most powerful weapon could nudge the United States toward war.

DC
SONY LIV



THE FILM follows Devadas, aka Das (Lokesh Kanagaraj), an outlaw who lives by his own moral code. His life takes an unexpected turn when he meets Parvathy, a singer, while Chandra (Wamiqa Gabbi) navigates a world shaped by survival. As their paths intersect, love, betrayal and revenge collide, drawing them into a web of conflict. Written and directed by Arun Matheswaran, *DC* also stars Sanjana Krishnamoorthy, Kasthuri Raja and Thalaivasal Vijay, among others.

Disclosure Day
JIOHOTSTAR



DIRECTED AND produced by Steven Spielberg, *Disclosure Day* is a science fiction thriller based on a story by Spielberg and written by David Koepp. The film follows a television meteorologist (Emily Blunt) and a cybersecurity analyst (Josh O'Connor) on a mission to reveal the existence of extraterrestrial life to the world. As they race to expose the truth, they must evade a government contractor (Colin Firth) determined to keep the secret under wraps. The ensemble cast also includes Eve Hewson and Colman Domingo.

Alaka Sahani

A Wooly Good Time

Shalini Langer

WITH 190 episodes over seven series, *Shaun the Sheep* is among the longest-running animated series on British and German television, with the characters around for over 30 years. In all that time, the sheep have hardly changed. It is a remarkable success given that the stop-motion animation involves no dialogue; its animals don't talk and its humans only utter unintelligible words.

The Beast of Mossy Bottom underlines why directors Steve Cox and Matthew Walker pull off a wholesome entertainer, which is simple, straight and touching, without having pretensions, or songs-and-dances, about being anything else.

In this one, Shaun (Justin Fletcher) decides to take tips from a Home-Made Science Experiments book to make their pumpkins grow fast enough for Halloween. The heart of the little sheep of the herd, who live with the Farmer (John Sparkes), is set upon this.

However, as experiments go, this one too overachieves, and not only do the pumpkins keep growing and growing, the Farmer who has applied the magic concoction to his balding pate, mistaking it for a hair-growth cream, develops hair all over his body. The timing could not be worse as the Farmer was planning to ask out the Vet (Nina Sosanya) for a Halloween date.

With the Farmer hidden behind all that hair, the Mossy Bottom village thinks he is a monster and starts chasing him down. Meanwhile, the Vet thinks the Farmer is actually Big Foot, and decides to save it by sending it away to 'Big Foot Island'.

There is a particularly marvellous sequence when the Vet drives out into the moonlit ocean chasing the ship carrying the Farmer, while making stops to retrieve various marine animals entangled in plastic waste.

Shaun's imaginative use of basic science is endearing, and the dog's grief for the Farmer moving.

How the sheep, the dog and the Vet figure it out, just in time, to save the Farmer is what The Beast of Mossy Bottom is about.

Agreed that its beast is not much of a beast by today's standards, where the bigger the better. But who does not wish for a world where the sheep lead the herd?

SHAUN THE SHEEP: THE BEAST OF MOSSY BOTTOM
★★★
DIRECTOR: Steve Cox, Matthew Walker
VOICES: Justin Fletcher, John Sparkes, Nina Sosanya, Kate Harbour



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• POLITY

Special Summary Revision: What EC announced, how it differs from SIR

Damini Nath
New Delhi, October 16

AMID PROTESTS against the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, the Election Commission (EC) on Thursday announced the schedule for the Special Summary Revision (SSR) for 17 states and Union Territories, including five states where Assembly polls are due in 2027.

The EC skipped the SSR, which is the annual update of rolls, in 2026, after announcing the SIR last year.

What is the SSR?

Article 324 of the Constitution empowers the EC to prepare electoral rolls for elections to Parliament and Assemblies. Its procedures are prescribed in the Representation of the People Act, 1950, and the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960.

Electoral rolls are made for each Assembly constituency, with an Electoral Registration Officer (ERO) authorised for the task. Under the 1950 Act, the rolls are to be revised "before each general election to the House of the People or to the Legislative Assembly of a State" and "in any year in the prescribed manner..."

Flowing from this, the EC conducts an SSR, in which the electoral roll is updated with additions of new electors and deletions of those who have died or shifted, before each election and also annually. All those aged 18 as of January 1 are eligible to be enrolled in the SSR roll.

What is the new announcement?

The EC has announced the SSR schedule with the qualifying date of January 1, 2027 in the states/UTs where the SIR has been completed in 2025 and this year, and in Assam, where it had decided not to conduct the SIR.

The schedule includes multiple stages — from rationalisation of polling stations, to be completed by November 2, to publishing of the final roll on January 4, 2027.

The 17 states and Union Territories are Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Assam, Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Goa, Gujarat, Kerala, Lakshadweep, Madhya Pradesh, Manipur, Puducherry, Punjab, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, and West Bengal. The ECI will announce the schedule for the remaining states, where the SIR is still on, later.

How is SSR different from SIR?

The EC broke from its practice of conducting the SSR annually when it decided in 2025 to conduct an intensive revision of rolls after 20 years. Its methodology for the SIR was also different from past intensive revisions, as all existing electors were required to fill forms and submit documents to establish their eligibility, including citizenship. Over 13 crore names were deleted in the draft stages nationwide.

While the SIR required every elector to fill an enumeration form to enter the draft roll, existing electors will automatically be on the draft SSR roll. Electoral officials can delete deceased or duplicate voters, but they must follow the statutory process, including issuing notices and holding hearings.

After the draft is published, electors have a month to make claims and objections. In the SIR, after the draft roll, the EC issued centrally generated notices to those flagged by its software for "logical discrepancies" in their documents. They then had to provide additional documents and attend hearings to prevent deletion from the final roll. No such exercise is planned in the SSR.



• CONSUMER AFFAIRS

E-commerce: Why the price you see is not what you pay

Dark patterns, 'convenience' charges, 'platform' fees: Small add-on charges are adding up to big revenues for companies and costs for customers



SOUMYARENDRA BARIK & ANIL SASI

THE FURORE over Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on UPI transactions has brought back into focus other charges that run counter to the idea of catalysing India's digital push. These include platform fees and convenience charges, which have become an industry-wide practice across online services spanning food and grocery delivery, e-commerce, entertainment and travel.

Compounding this are so-called 'dark patterns' used by online platforms, which can further obfuscate the real price a consumer has to pay, including by revealing charges late in the checkout process or adding services without explicit consent. What started small — as an experiment by Swiggy three years ago with a modest Rs 2 per transaction add-on — has since become standard practice across major food and grocery delivery platforms, including Zomato and Blinkit. Even Amazon India now charges customers Rs 5 for servicing on most orders.

The charges now cut across almost every major category of online consumption. Ordering food on Swiggy or Zomato attracts a platform fee; buying goods on Amazon India comes with a marketplace fee; booking a movie ticket on BookMyShow attracts an internet handling or convenience fee; booking a train ticket through IRCTC comes with a convenience fee; and similar charges are imposed by airlines and online travel aggregators when customers book flights.

That spread is significant given how online transactions have evolved from being an alternative to physical channels into the default mode of accessing many of these services. Food delivery is inherently an online business, while a large majority of reserved railway tickets are now booked digitally. Movie and flight bookings, too, have steadily shifted online.

Yet, rather than the cost of transacting digitally getting subsumed within the price of the underlying service, a separate layer of charges has increasingly become standard across these sectors.

• THE DARK PATTERNS OF ONLINE SHOPPING

How e-commerce platforms use deceptive tactics to influence purchases and increase costs

DRIP PRICING
Advertising a lower price upfront, but revealing additional charges such as platform fees, handling fees or convenience fees only at checkout.



FALSE URGENCY
Displaying misleading messages such as "Only 2 left" or countdown timers to pressure customers into making immediate purchases.



SUBSCRIPTION TRAPS
Making subscriptions easy to activate but difficult to cancel, often through hidden cancellation options or lengthy procedures.



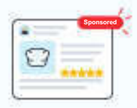
BASKET SNEAKING
Automatically adding paid services, subscriptions, insurance or charity donations to a customer's cart without their consent.



BAIT AND SWITCH
Advertising a product or service at an attractive price, but offering something different or more expensive when the customer proceeds.



DISGUISED ADVERTISEMENTS
Presenting paid promotions as ordinary product recommendations, reviews or other content without clearly identifying them as advertisements.



Paying for 'convenience'

Far from remaining small add-on charges, both platform and convenience fees have become significant revenue streams for the companies that levy them.

IRCTC collects convenience fees on e-ticket bookings at the rate of Rs 15 + GST per ticket for non-AC classes and Rs 30 + GST per ticket for AC classes. For users who make online payment for e-tickets through the BHIM/UPI payment mode, the fee is slightly reduced to Rs 10 per ticket for non-AC classes and Rs 20 along with applicable GST for AC Class. IRCTC says the reduction for these specific payment modes is to "promote digital payments, thereby fulfilling the Digital India mission of the Government of India".

In the June 2026 quarter, IRCTC made Rs 248 crore from convenience fees, accounting for over 18% of the company's total revenue in the period, which stood at Rs 1,369 crore, but more than 68% of the platform's Rs 361 crore revenue from e-ticketing services. Though Swiggy and Zomato do not report specific breakdowns of how much they earned from platform fees, industry analysts estimated that each company makes roughly Rs 1,000 crore to Rs 1,200 crore from these charges annually.

But these charges present multiple contradictions. Take platform fees, which

Whose convenience?

Online transactions actually save companies costs and resources on things such as staff and physical infrastructure.

•

Yet, even as online transactions have evolved into the default mode of accessing services, it is customers who find themselves saddled with a separate layer of charges.

jack up the final pricing of products while obfuscating their real cost until the final step of checkout. Similarly, convenience fees represent an inflated add-on charge, even as an online transaction actually saves the company offering the service both costs and resources on things such as physical staff and brick-and-mortar infrastructure.

"The word convenience charge itself is an anomaly, given that it is the service provider who is benefiting by offering that service online. Say, ticket sales: instead of needing to have a physical counter with staff to see tickets, the entire thing is now happening online. It's a gain for the service provider. Instead, the customer is saddled with an additional charge even though the service provider is benefiting by offering it the digital way. That is ironic," a retired chief of a technology regulator told *The Indian Express*.

What changes from headline price to final bill

Then there is the question of how and at what stage these additional charges are disclosed to a consumer.

The Department of Consumer Affairs had earlier intervened after receiving complaints against e-commerce platforms charging extra for cash-on-delivery, a practice classified as a dark pattern that misleads and exploits consumers. On these charges, there is a certain policy ambivalence.

In August, India's Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) observed that quick commerce firm Zepto was showing a lower price initially to lure consumers, but was adding additional handling charges and applying a fee for its membership plan without customers' consent. Calling this a case of 'basket sneaking,' the CCPA imposed a fine of Rs 7 lakh on Zepto and directed it to discontinue its "dark patterns".

Dark patterns on e-commerce are deceptive user-interface designs that trick shoppers into making unintended purchases or sharing data. Basket sneaking is a deceptive design tactic where a platform automatically adds an extra product or service to users' shopping carts without their explicit consent, usually through pre-checked boxes, hidden line items, or forced bundles during the checkout process.

In the online ticketing sector, the price initially shown to a consumer can change over the course of the booking process.

Take travel aggregator Yatra. A search for a flight ticket first shows all available options along with the cost. Upon clicking a suitable option, the following page that loads gives a breakdown of the fare, which includes the base fare, fuel surcharges, user development fees, and GST.

Until here, there is no mention of the so-called convenience fee that Yatra.com charges, and it is only revealed on the subsequent page when a user clicks on 'proceed to pay'. So, it takes three webpages to load, and right when a user has to input her payment details does the website reveal an added convenience charge. This is not a Yatra-specific strategy, but is prevalent across the sector and platforms like MakeMyTrip and Goibibo, among others.

This strategy is commonly referred to as 'drip pricing'. India's Guidelines for Prevention and Regulation of Dark Patterns, 2023 define it as a practice where elements of prices are not revealed upfront or are revealed surreptitiously within the user experience; or revealing the price post-confirmation of purchase, i.e. charging an amount higher than the amount disclosed at checkout. In short, drip pricing is a deceptive sales tactic where companies advertise only a low initial 'headline price' and then reveal mandatory fees, taxes, or service charges incrementally ('dripping' them) as the customer moves through the checkout process.

• ECONOMICS

Why bond yields are rising in all major countries — except China



GRAPHS, DATA, PERSPECTIVES
BY UDIT MISRA
WEEKLY ECONOMIC AND POLICY INSIGHTS USING DATA

GOVERNMENT BONDS are the most risk-free investments one can make in any economy. After all, everyone expects the government to pay back its debt. The yields refer to the returns an investor can expect to earn by lending money to the government.

But as government bonds are traded among investors, their prices fluctuate, and so do their yields. If a bond's price falls, its yield rises, and vice-versa. Simply put, rising bond yields signal higher borrowing costs for governments and, by extension, higher interest rates for all borrowers in the economy, since lending to the government is the safest bet. Higher costs are expected to drag down economic growth.

The chart shows how remarkable the shift has been since the start of the US-Iran war at the end of February. For instance, the yield on US 10-year bonds has increased by 125 basis points. Given that trillions of dollars of government bonds exchange hands everyday, even such seemingly minuscule changes have huge consequences.

One exception: China

In sharp contrast to all others, government bond yields have actually fallen in China, which is not only the world's second largest economy but single-handedly rivals the size of the euro-zone economy.

A large part of the concern about rising bond yields globally has been about the rising cost of borrowing for all the governments concerned. From that perspective, it may seem like a boon that the Chinese government's borrowing costs are coming down.

But there is a flipside as well.

Falling bond yields are a cause of deep concern since they signal a weak domestic economy in China's case. To understand that one needs to understand why bond yields are falling in China to begin with.

Why are bond yields falling in China?

Globally, yields are going up because inflation rates are rising in every country and investors are demanding better returns for the money they lend, even as central banks raise interest rates to contain inflation.

But in China, the domestic inflation rate has been absolutely flat; in fact, there are phases when China has experienced deflation. Deflation is when prices actually fall from one year to another.

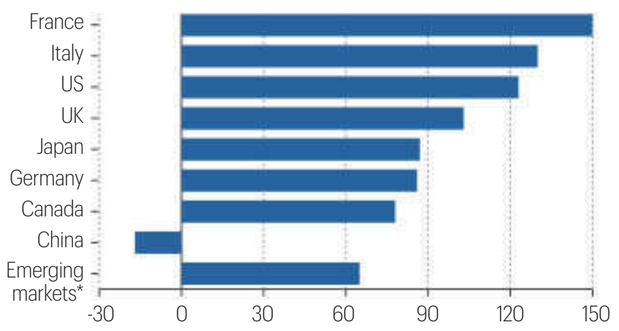
China's inflation rate in 2025 was 0% — meaning that prices did not change at all over their 2024 levels. In both 2024 and 2023, the inflation rate for consumers was 0.2%.

Even now, with all the increased prices of oil and supply disruptions, the inflation rate is only expected to inch up to 1% in 2026.

Since inflation is low, there is no reason for China's central bank to raise interest rates for short-term lending.

• GOVERNMENT BORROWING COSTS HAVE RISEN SINCE WEST ASIA WAR BEGAN

Change in nominal sovereign 10-year bond yield since February 27 (basis points)



Source: IMF, **Note:** Data through September 30; Emerging markets exclude China, reflect the weighted average of Brazil, Hungary, Indonesia, Malaysia, Mexico and South Africa.

Why is China's inflation rate low?

This has two main reasons.

One, China's growth rate has moderated quite sharply over the past decade. Gone are the days of double-digit real GDP growth rates. In such a booming economy, inflation tends to run hot. Over the past few years 4% to 5% is the new normal.

Moreover, unlike most other economies where growth happens on the back of the consumption demand of citizens, in China, growth is driven by exports — that is, the consumption demand of foreigners for China's goods. The Chinese by themselves do not consume as much as their policymakers would want them to.

As a result, there is a glut of savings within China with not many attractive avenues to invest in; the property market used to absorb savings but it has been in a slump as well. Furthermore, there are massive restrictions on investing outside China.

As such, most Chinese savings flow towards buying safe government bonds. As more and more people buy government bonds, the bond prices rise and yields fall.

• HISTORY

Roman Empire to US: The evolution of public executions as a tool of state power

Arav Shah
New Delhi, October 16

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump has scrapped the plan to livestream former US Army Major Nidal Hasan's execution by firing squad, just days after the proposal was floated by Secretary of War Pete Hegseth.

Hasan, who shot and killed 13 people at the Fort Hood US Army post in Texas in 2009, was scheduled to be executed on December 3. During his rampage, he was shot by law enforcement officers. This paralysed him from the waist down and forced him to use a wheelchair — something Trump was reportedly not aware of when the live broadcast plan was announced.

Had the plan gone through it would have been the US's first public execution in 90 years. In much of history, however, public executions were commonly wielded as instruments of state power.

A display of authority

Around 33 CE, the governor of Judea authorised the execution of a man earlier found to have no charge against him. It would become one of history's most widely recognised public executions — the crucification of Jesus Christ.

Capital punishment has long been codified, including in ancient Babylon and Athens, where death was the punishment for all crimes in the 7th century BCE. Executions in the Roman Empire were known for their flamboyant approach, organised as spectacles that incited great delight among their audiences.

Many pre-modern polities also viewed a serious crime as much an affront to the supreme ruling authority as it was a violation of the social contract. As such, any punishment was expected to carry a demonstrative purpose, acting as a public deterrent.

This strategy was not without criticism. Roman philosopher Seneca the Younger argued in the 'Moral Letters to Lucillius' that being a part of such events had adverse effects on the individual psyche. In the 20th century, French philosopher Michel Foucault argued that the condemned individual's body became the site on which the State exercised its influence, with measurably visible violence projecting a larger message.

Such executions could also reinforce a moral and religious worldview. Ceremonies, public proclamations and the condemned person's final words helped frame death as the restoration of an established moral order. The execution was represented as justice being carried out, rather than arbitrary violence. This model was also based on maintaining a certain dynamic between the crowd and the State, where a condemned person garnering sympathy from the crowd could result in an active pushback against the State's theatre of power.

Shift over 18th, 19th centuries

Through the last millennium, save for a brief period during William the Conqueror's reign (1066-1087), public executions were the norm across Europe.

Around 1571, gallows were erected in London for tens of thousands of paying spectators to witness hangings from open galleries, or in rented upper-story rooms of nearby houses and pubs.

In Paris, death took the form of the guillotine — then championed as a humane form of execution. Its zenith was marked by the executions of King Louis XVI and Queen Marie Antoinette in 1793 in the French Revolution. Eyewitness accounts described a crowd of 40,000 armed men lining the streets, with the executioner holding the king's severed head aloft while the crowd tore his coat to pieces as souvenirs.

In colonial settings, particularly British India, public executions were instruments of subjugating subjects of a foreign land. After the mutiny of the Bengal Army, part of the Revolt of 1857, British forces hung 144 Indian rebels from a sacred Banyan tree. By utilising flora sacred to the natives, the State deliberately sought to desecrate indigenous cultural spaces.

The 19th century brought about the legacy of the Enlightenment — a movement of philosophy, science and art that began two centuries prior in Europe, stressing rationalism over blind faith. A growing middle class internalised these ideals of humanism and viewed the theatricality of punishment as a spectacle that threatened civic order. This added to a waning appetite for public executions. Foucault observed that the State shifted its approach to the "discipline of the penitentiary" around this period.

In the UK, the Tyburn tree of London that housed wooden gallows was dismantled in 1783, and executions transitioned from public festivals to administrative procedures. By 1868, the British Parliament had formally abolished public executions. In the US, Pennsylvania became the first state to move executions behind closed doors starting in 1834.

The 1936 hanging of Rainey Bethea, a Black man who allegedly confessed to the rape of a White woman, drew a rowdy crowd of 20,000 and is considered the last legal public execution in the US.

There has been no legal public execution in independent India. The last recorded public execution in British India took place in 1934. Two "dacoits" were hung in front of a crowd of around 10,000 in Shahdadkot, Sindh, in present-day Pakistan, according to the UK Parliament Library.

What US courts have ruled

In the US, the First Amendment guarantees the freedom of the press and the right to access government proceedings. The Supreme Court has recognised that trials are open to the public.

The limits of these guarantees were determined in 1977, when a TV reporter sought permission to film the first execution in Texas since the reinstatement of the death penalty the previous year. The court reasoned that because the general public of Texas was barred from attending or filming executions, the press had no constitutional right to do so. Similarly, in 2001, an Indiana court ruled that filming an execution conveys nothing of substantive fact that cannot be conveyed through written and verbal journalistic accounts.

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TRUMP CALLS UKRAINIAN ATTACK ON RUSSIAN REFINERY 'A DISGRACE'

Zelenskyy slams Trump diesel deal, calls Russian peace move a 'parody'

EU leaders host summit in Brussels, reaffirm support for Ukraine president

Reuters
Brussels, Kyiv, October 16

UKRAINIAN PRESIDENT Volodymyr Zelenskyy took aim on Friday at US President Donald Trump's diesel deal with Russia and welcomed the prospect of European allies stepping up their role in talks, calling Moscow's stance a "parody" of peace negotiations.

At a European Union summit in Brussels, Zelenskyy said Russia did not want peace. He added Ukraine was still experiencing disruptions to the SpaceX Starshield satellite system used for battlefield operations and to down Russian drones attacking cities far from frontline.

EU leaders rallied around Zelenskyy after Trump again criticised Ukraine, calling its strikes on Russian refineries a "disgrace". On arriving at the summit, Zelenskyy pointedly referred to his counterparts there as "real leaders".

Trump blindsided Zelenskiy last weekend by announcing that Ukraine and Russia had agreed not to target each other's energy facilities. Facing US midterm elections in November, Trump has blamed Ukrainian strikes on Russian refineries for pushing up energy prices that could cost him at the ballot box.



Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy with EU leaders during a meeting on the sidelines of the EU summit in Brussels, on Friday. AP

His diesel deal with Russia angered Ukraine and European allies. "And now we can see how cash will start flowing back into Russia through the diesel deal," Zelenskyy told a press conference on the sidelines of summit.

"This diesel deal will never be enough to offset the impact of the Strait of Hormuz on global markets. But it will put more money straight into Putin's pocket to fund this war."

Zelenskyy also accused Russian President Vladimir Putin of not being interested in peace talks in any form.

"Putin does not want peace talks at the moment, in any form," he said. "He's playing with words, claiming they respond... Quite simply, it looks like a parody of a genuine desire to end the war."

In an interview, Estonian Prime Minister Kristen Michal told *Reuters* EU would probably have to provide a new loan to Ukraine to help cover its budget gap for next year. "Last winter was already hell, this one will be once again like hell," Michal said.

"We have a lot of gaps to fill, and this is a European mission to fill the gaps Ukraine needs. Because always, at the start (and) at the end of every conversation, people need to be reminded that ... we cannot get tired of the war in Ukraine, because they are fighting ... for us."

Ukraine's leadership has been alarmed by disruptions to the Starshield satellite system. A source in Ukraine's defence ministry said Starshield receptors were only working at speeds of up to 160 kph, complicating their use for military missions.

A US official has denied that Trump ordered a deliberate slowdown of Starshield, which is the military-grade version of the Starlink service run by Elon Musk's SpaceX, and Trump said this week intelligence sharing with Ukraine continued.

Ukraine struck a Russian oil refinery after Zelenskyy declared Kyiv was abandoning the energy ceasefire Trump had announced. "All he's doing is making the world oil price higher. Well, I think that's a disgrace," Trump said in an interview with Newsmax news outlet.

Building non-negotiable 'security zone' in Ukraine along border: Putin

Moscow: Russia is establishing a "security zone"" inside Ukraine along their border, which will be non-negotiable in any future talks with Kyiv, President Vladimir Putin said on Friday.

Putin, wearing military uniform and speaking during a visit to a command post, said the operation was in response to Ukraine's 2024-25 incursion into Russia's western Kursk region.

"The Russian armed forces were tasked not only with expelling the enemy from our land but also with establishing a security zone in the adjacent territory. This task is being carried out successfully," he said in televised comments.

"Our goal is to ensure the absolute security of Russia's border regions for the future, and we do not plan to make this a subject for potential peace negotiations with Ukraine."

Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said the planned security zone spanned 660 km, of which 70% was currently under Russia's control. REUTERS

EU LEADERS BACK UKRAINE

"We are working on the new sanctions package to put the pressure on Russia, and we of course hope that we do this with all our partners around the world"
KAJA KALLAS, EU FOREIGN POLICY CHIEF

"I am unhappy with the number of countries that have been willing to pledge new financial support to Ukraine"
ROB JETTEN, DUTCH PRIME MINISTER

"Last winter was already hell (for Ukrane), this one will be once again like hell. We have a lot of gaps to fill, and this is a European mission to fill the gaps that Ukraine needs."
KRISTAN MICHAL, ESTONIAN PRIME MINISTER

"A lot of concern around Europe in terms of what's happening in Ukraine right now."
MICHEAL MARTIN, IRISH PRIME MINISTER



Katie Zacharia during her briefing at the White House, Tuesday. REUTERS

Katie Zacharia out after 5 days as White House Press Secretary

Associated Press
Washington, October 16

WHITE HOUSE Press Secretary Katie Zacharia was "let go" from the role, a White House official said on Friday, after President Donald Trump said he had told her to reconsider the job following public scrutiny.

"I told her: 'I think you're better off being happy, and I'm not sure you can ever be happy in this stuff.' There's nothing easy about this stuff," Trump told reporters while departing the White House. He added: "I said to her honestly, 'If I were you, I'd reconsider... think about it. But I would reconsider.'"

Fox News, citing a White House official, later reported Zacharia was "transitioning" out of the role of press secretary.

Zacharia started the job on Monday and held her debut White House briefing on Tuesday. She had said she received a call about the role of press secretary last Wednesday and got offered the job to succeed Karoline Leavitt last Friday.

Trump later announced her appointment. In his announcement, he described her an attorney. Over the last week, the issue of whether Zacharia, a graduate of California's Pepperdine University law school, had actually passed the bar — making her an attorney — came under fire.

On Friday, during a *Fox News* interview on Thursday, Zacharia said she did not pass the bar. Anthony Scaramucci served director of communications for 10 days during Trump's first administration.

"I think you're better off being happy, and I'm not sure you can ever be happy in this stuff.' There's nothing easy about this stuff. If I were you, I'd reconsider... think about it..."
DONALD TRUMP, PRESIDENT OF UNITED STATES

16-year-old gunman shot dead after killing four at Oregon school

Reuters
Oregon, October 16

A 16-YEAR-old shooter opened fire on Thursday at an elementary school in Bend, Oregon, killing four people including three children, before being killed by an armed member of the community who had pursued the assailant into the school, police said.

The shooter entered Silver Rail Elementary School by firing through locked doors, police said, without offering any details beyond the suspect's age.

The dead were children aged 5, 8 and 11 and one teacher. In addition, a 7-year-old student and a 54-year-old teacher were taken to hospital with critical injuries, Bend Police Chief Mike Krantz told a press conference.

Oregon Governor Tina Kotek, appearing at same briefing, thanked the community member who "heroically intervened to stop further loss of life."

"No parent should have to have this kind of day, and no community should have to live through this kind of day...," Kotek said.



People attend a candlelight vigil in Oregon after the shooting at Silver Rail Elementary School. AP

Krantz said the community member, whom he did not identify, saw the suspect enter the school and pursued him.

Krantz said every Bend police officer went through a full day of active shooter training in August. "Unfortunately, this is something we train for on a regular basis, and we must," Krantz said. "This is going to be a long investigation."

US military weighs the use of largest non-nuclear bomb against Iran: *CNN*

Moscow: The US military has developed strike plans that could include using the GBU-43/B Massive Ordnance Air Blast Bomb, also known as "mother of all bombs", against Iranian energy infrastructure and nuclear sites if President Donald Trump orders renewed combat operations, CNN reported on Thursday citing US officials familiar with the matter.

The potential deployment of largest non-nuclear bomb in the US arsenal would mark a significant escalation in the conflict, although officials familiar with military planning discussions told CNN questions remain over its effectiveness. REUTERS

Trump says US may need to strike Iran's Pickaxe Mountain

Reuters
Washington, October 16

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump said the US may have to target Pickaxe Mountain, a site linked to Iran's nuclear program, as he aims to ensure Tehran does not get a nuclear weapon.

In an interview with *Newsmax* on Thursday night, Trump also said he would not use a nuclear weapon in the war on Iran, which began in February with US-Israeli strikes.

Trump said the US wanted to make sure Iran will never have a nuclear weapon "because if they had it, they would use it."

"Their nuclear is buried under millions of tons of mountain. Now we're looking at Pickaxe Mountain. We may have to go there. We'll take a shot at that one. We'll knock it out fast," Trump told the news outlet.



US President Donald Trump speaks to reporters as he departs the White House for Joint Base Andrews on Friday. AP

Pickaxe Mountain is a fortified facility buried deep underground near one of Tehran's main nuclear sites.

The US president said there was no need to use a nuclear bomb in Iran. "I wouldn't use nuclear. We don't have to." Trump reiterated he was not considering using US ground troops in Iran

Trump did not say if he had authorized use of GBU-43/B Massive Ordnance Air Blast Bomb, also known as "mother of all bombs,"against Iranian energy infrastructure and nuclear sites. He did say the MOAB bomb was not a nuclear bomb.

BRIEFLY

VATICAN CITY

Pope to make Sunday appearance after 'steady improvement': Vatican



Pope Leo XIV celebrates Mass while recovering from surgery. REUTERS

Pope Leo is showing steady improvement in hospital after undergoing surgery for lung cancer this week, the Vatican said on Friday, adding that he is now able to do normal daily activities with full autonomy. The pope will make his first public appearance since his hospitalisation on Sunday to deliver the traditional Angelus prayer, while preparations continue for his planned November trip to South America, the Vatican said. Leo was diagnosed with lung adenocarcinoma, the most common form of lung cancer, and doctors removed the lower lobe of his right lung in an operation on Tuesday. The Vatican released Friday the first images of the pope since his surgery, showing him celebrating Mass and standing unaided. REUTERS

ITALY

Rome extends Schengen visa curbs with Spain

ITALY HAS extended by another week its suspension of EU's border-free travel arrangements with Spain over a surge in migrant arrivals in Ceuta, an Italian government source said Friday. A Spanish government spokesperson said the interior ministers of both countries would work over the coming week on lifting the border controls. The extension by aligns with countermeasure taken by Madrid. REUTERS

TURKEY

Istanbul hit by worst floods in 80 years, 4 dead

CATASTROPHIC FLOODING in Istanbul was the worst in more than 80 years, Turkey's interior minister said Friday as the death toll rose to four. Istanbul, the largest city with 16 million residents, was hit by more rain in the 48 hours up to Thursday than the combined historical average for September and October, state-run *Anadolu Agency* reported. Homes were flooded as water covered streets across the city. AP

Israel election: Arab-led parties could turn kingmaker if others decide to join coalition

Associated Press
Baqa al-Gharbiyye, October 15



Israeli politician Mansour Abbas. FILE

MANSOUR ABBAS has done what Israel asks of Palestinian citizens. The leader of the Arab Islamist Ra'am party condemned Hamas' October 7, 2023, attack, seldom discusses Gaza's war and focuses on crime. In 2021, he broke a taboo by bringing an Arab party into an Israeli coalition.

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and rivals say they will not form a coalition with Abbas' party or any other Arab-led party after the October 27 election. That risks gridlock, though Arab parties could help choose Israel's next prime minister.

Palestinians who remained in Israel after 1948 war and their descendants form 20% of Israel's population. They can vote, but many Jewish Israelis distrust them over support for Palestinians and the West Bank. Arab citizens face discrimination and high crime rates, which activists blame on police neglect.

The homicide rate among Palestinian citizens is more than 22 times that of Jewish Israelis.

The Abraham Initiatives recorded 184 crime-related killings in Arab communities; only 12% of cases reported were solved.

Rights group Adalah says authorities curb expression by breaking up anti-war protests, restricting Palestinian flags and arresting hundreds over social media posts. Israel cites security concerns. "We have to choose between the danger of being killed and being discriminated against," said Hassan Jabareen, Adalah's director general.

Abbas, 52, says coalition membership gives Arab leaders a voice. Critics say he avoids the wider Israeli-Palestinian conflict; he says tackling crime serves constituents. The government he joined lasted just over a year before the 2022 election returned Netanyahu to power.

Yousef Jabareen, leader of Joint List of Arab parties, less conciliatory than Ra'am, called the election's stakes "existential". He said parties must use their power to prevent further deterioration, speaking at a Tel Aviv event before exiting through the back to avoid far-right protesters.

No party is expected to win the 61 seats required for a Knesset majority. Netanyahu, rival Gadi Eisenkot and opposition leader Yair Lapid have ruled out partnering with Arab-led parties. They could reconsider or accept outside support; otherwise, Arab gains could prompt another election.

$700mn in Congo Ebola funds missing: Africa's top health body

Dakar: Africa's top public health body and Congolese health authorities this week called for greater transparency in the use of Ebola response funds, saying financial information provided by aid organisations left more than $700 million of donor money yet to be accounted for.

Dr Jean Kaseya, director general of the Africa CDC, told *Reuters* on Thursday it was too early to speak of embezzlement, but described the gap as a major transparency and financial reporting problem that prevented officials from having a full picture of resources mobilised and spent.

International donors have disbursed about $962 million to organisations implementing Ebola response activities in Congo, rather than to the government, Kaseya sai. REUTERS

OVER THE PAST DECADE, THOUSANDS OF PEOPLE HAVE BEEN DISPLACED BY EARTHQUAKES, LANDSLIDES AND FLOODS, ONLY TO FACE NEW RISKS IN TEMPORARY SETTLEMENTS BUILT IN VULNERABLE AREAS

Nepal's devastating flood exposes the risks of resettling disaster survivors

Associated Press
Khalte (Nepal), October 16

WHEN THE flood came, Chheku Lama ran uphill, shouting for people to flee. A group followed him, but none survived, he said.

Lama's Khalte village in Nepal's Rasuwa district had been set up as a temporary settlement after a 2015 earthquake destroyed villages. But it offered little protection from floods, with homes clustered along Trishuli River in a narrow valley.

When floodwaters surged through on August 26, residents had few routes to escape. At least 375 people were reported missing, according to residents. The village was wiped out.

Nepal is still recovering from the devastating floods that killed more than 1,400 people and left thousands missing in its mountainous border region with China. Another flash flood in north-central Nepal last week left at least five people missing.

Over the past decade, tens of thousands of people in Nepal have been displaced by earthquakes, landslides and floods, only to face new risks in temporary settlements built in vulnerable areas. Khalte's destruction highlights those dangers.

Survivors say the government must go beyond emergency relief and temporary shelter to provide safe, permanent places where displaced people can rebuild their lives.

The 2015 earthquake, which killed nearly 9,000 people nationwide, destroyed villages where many families had lived for generations. Under a government relocation plan, about 257 vulnerable households were moved to Khalte, which geological assessments later classified as a "red zone" because of landslide and avalanche risks.

Bam Bahadur Tamang, a Khalte resident now living in a government relief center, said he and many others had opposed the decision to resettle them there but they were eventually forced to move. He said any new relocation must account for both safety and access to basic services.



A temporary holding center for survivors of the flash floods in Nepal in August this year stands on a hillside in Nuwakot district. AP

"Wherever the government resettles us now, it must first ensure the place is safe," he said. "We are not cattle to be moved from one place to another."

Tamang's worries point to a challenge that extends beyond finding safe ground. Displaced families also need access to schools, healthcare, roads and livelihoods if a temporary settlement is to become a viable home.

Nepal's government says it plans to build a new city for flood victims, with industries, hospitals and schools, and that displaced residents would not be sent back to settlements destroyed by the flood. It is also considering involving private developers in reconstruction, including a model in which they build homes in cooperation with landowners.

Dharam Raj Uprety, chief executive of Nepal's National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority, said the government was identifying land for settlements in safe areas. Experts would assess land use, and flood-prone areas could be declared uninhabitable, he said.

The government could also convert vulnerable riverbanks into forest land and build homes on safer ground.Uprety stressed, however, that agencies responsible for infrastructure and urban planning need to coordinate more closely.

"The disaster authority cannot do all the work itself. Its role is largely to coordinate and create an environment in which other agencies incorporate disaster risk into planning," he said.

Nepal has previously taken steps to reduce flood risks, including river monitoring, early-warning systems and community preparedness. But its remote mountain valleys remain at risk of sudden floods caused by landslides and glacial lake outbursts.Scientists warn rising temperatures and unstable mountain landscapes make better monitoring and stronger early-warning systems ever more important for Nepal.

For Khalte's survivors the question of where to rebuild remains unresolved. Many are reluctant to return to places where they lost family members, saying a new relocation plan may do little to reassure them. AP

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MUSK BLAMED 'CERTAIN OLIGARCHS' FOR BLOCKING STARLINK

Competition welcome, but all must abide by Indian laws: Reliance

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, October 16



Reliance sees competition as the truest test of who serves the customer best, the company said in a statement. REUTERS

RELIANCE INDUSTRIES has said it welcomes competition in the satellite communications space, including from Elon Musk's Starlink, in its first official response to the billionaire's allegations that "certain oligarchs" were responsible for delaying the launch of Starlink in India, where he also questioned whether the group's chairman and managing director Mukesh Ambani was the 'real boss of India'.

"In light of recent remarks about Reliance and the Indian market, we wish to place the facts on record. Like every Indian enterprise, Reliance has grown in an India that welcomes investment and innovation, homegrown or international, that improve the lives of the people. That openness rests on the rule of law. As the Government of India has stated, it applies the same process to every applicant, Indian or foreign. Jio's own satellite services await clearances," Reliance Industries said in a statement Friday morning.

"At Reliance, we have never feared competition. We see it as the truest test of who serves the customer best. Jio itself entered India's crowded telecom market in 2016 as the newest player, with not a single customer. In just ten years, Jio has earned the trust of over 530 million customers and given Indians some of the best digital infrastructure and most affordable data in the world," it said.

"We welcome competition in satellite communications, including Starlink. Every player, Jio included, must serve the people of India and abide by the laws and policies of the land," the group added.

Starlink is among the operators that have secured GMPCS (global mobile personal communication by satellite) licences and other statutory approvals needed to launch satellite communication, or satcom, services in the country. Others who have received it include Bharti-backed Eutelsat OneWeb, and Jio Satellite Communications Ltd, a wholly owned subsidiary of Jio Platforms. Jeff Bezos-owned Amazon Leo is also in contention for a licence.

Last week, Musk took to social media, blaming "certain oligarchs" for blocking Starlink in the country, and calling it a "crime against the people of India". The Centre has said satcom applications were pending security clearance at the Home Ministry, saying the country's regulatory framework for satcom services is fair and non-discriminatory.

In a statement the Ministry of Communications has said, "The Government has put in place a fair and non-discriminatory authorisation framework for all telecommunication services, including satellite communication services... Under the terms and conditions of licence, every such licensee is required to demonstrate compliance with security conditions...aimed at ensuring that services provided meet various security requirements to ensure safety of all users and their data," the ministry said without explicitly naming Musk.

"Security assessment as part of this process is currently underway in respect of all the three licensees. As and when this process is completed for a licenced entity, it may proceed to the next step of seeking assignment of spectrum. At present, all the three entities are at broadly the same regulatory stage. As such, the suggestion that the framework or its application is unfair or discriminatory is baseless and misconceived," it added.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

IDBI Bank and why disinvestment takes time

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, October 16

THE SELECTION of Prem Watsa-led Fairfax Financial as the buyer of 60.72% in IDBI Bank completes a journey that essentially began more than seven-and-a-half years ago in January 2019 when Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) stepped in and provided much-needed funds to the struggling lender while acquiring a majority stake.

The IDBI Bank deal announcement also comes almost exactly five years after Tata Sons was confirmed as the buyer of Air India, the last big disinvestment the government undertook. Sure, there have been others in the interim – Neelachal Ispat Nigam Limited, Ferro Scrap Nigam Limited, and Indian Medicines Pharmaceuticals Corporation Limited – but they are dwarfed by the sheer scale of the money involved. But will the lifting of the IDBI-sized weight give the Ministry of Finance's disinvestment efforts a second wind?

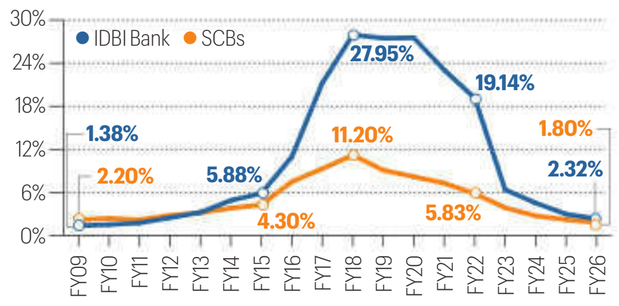
India's disinvestment history

As the transaction with Fairfax expected to be completed – which requires final regulatory approvals – by March 2027, the central government has essentially met its full-year disinvestment target of Rs 80,000 crore with the entirety of the second half of the fiscal still left.

The Centre has already raised Rs 55,757 crore from disinvestments so far in 2026-27 and will get Rs 26,544 crore from the IDBI Bank stake sale, taking the total to Rs 82,301 crore. This may not seem much – it is only 1.5% of the government's estimated expenditure of Rs 53 lakh crore this year – but purely in terms of disinvestment proceeds, it is already the third-highest ever, ranking only behind Rs 1 lakh crore in 2017-18 and Rs 84,972 crore the following year.

In fact, in nine of the last 12 years, the Centre has got more money as dividend from its shareholding in companies than by selling shares in its enterprises.

HOW IDBI BANK'S BAD LOAN PROBLEM WAS WORSE THAN INDUSTRY'S



NOTE: SCBs IS SCHEDULED COMMERCIAL BANKS, FIGURES ARE GROSS NON-PERFORMING ASSETS RATIO AT END OF FINANCIAL YEAR, SOURCE: IDBI BANK, RBI

A long process

One should not expect the resolution of IDBI Bank to lead to a flood of other, if smaller, deals. Why? Because of how difficult and involved the process is. Bids had to be invited twice after the first set were significantly lower than what was expected. Two different methods were then used to value IDBI Bank, which resulted in an average per share valuation of Rs.75.99. Fairfax's winning bid turned out to be Rs 81 per share.

Of course, IDBI Bank's circumstances did not help the entire process.

Like pretty much every other Indian bank, IDBI Bank's bad loan ratio – the percentage of loans given out that were not being repaid by borrowers – started climbing steadily around 2010. But the bank's situation was clearly far worse than that of others, with nearly a third of the entire loan book having turned bad by September 2018.

The bank was put under a corrective framework in May 2017 and the curbs were lifted only in March 2021. Over these four years, it posted a loss of nearly Rs 35,000 crore. Its deposits, a bank's lifeblood, shrunk 14%.

Since then, profitability has improved, but IDBI Bank has paid the price for years of weakness. In March 2010, it accounted for 3.7% of all bank deposits. This has fallen to 1.3% now. Similarly, its share in loans has declined from 4.3% to 1.2%.

The disinvestment process is no cakewalk. While some major ones have been completed, several others have fallen by the wayside for a variety of reasons.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Parekh, Sukthankar to advise Fairfax on IDBI, NS Kannan to be Chairman

George Mathew
Mumbai,October 16

FORMER HDFC Ltd Chairman Deepak Parekh and former Deputy MD of HDFC Bank Paresh Sukthankar will advise Fairfax Financial Holdings on its proposed acquisition of IDBI Bank, Fairfax founder, chairman and CEO Prem Watsa said.

Parekh and Sukthankar were instrumental in the phenomenal growth of the HDFC banking group in India.

Parekh stepped down as HDFC Chairman in June 2023.

Fairfax has also identified NS Kannan for the chairman's position, subject to approval from the Reserve Bank of India. Kannan previously served as managing director and CEO of ICICI Prudential Life Insurance and as Executive Director and CFO of ICICI Bank.

CVR Rajendran, former CEO of CSB Bank, will also work closely with Fairfax as an adviser.

The appointments form part of Canadian billionaire Prem Watsa-led Fairfax's plans to acquire a controlling stake in IDBI Bank, in a transaction that marks a significant foreign investment in India's financial sector.

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs has approved the sale of a 60.72% stake to Fairfax for Rs 52,878 crore. The transaction is expected to be completed by March 2027.



Deepak Parekh. REUTERS

In a conference call, India-born Watsa has described the proposed acquisition as a rare opportunity to expand the group's presence in one of the world's fastest-growing major economies.

"This is a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to purchase a majority interest in a bank in one of the world's fastest-growing economies," Watsa said, outlining Fairfax's ambition to combine banking with its insurance and investment banking businesses.

He said the group intended to support India's journey towards Viksit Bharat and the goal of becoming a developed economy by 2047.

"We intend to support India's journey towards Viksit Bharat and a $30-plus trillion economy," Watsa said, adding that Fairfax wanted to play a critical role in achieving that vision.

Combining IDBI Bank, Digit and IIFL Capital would create an entity that would transform the lives of average Indian citizens providing meaningful and significant benefit to Indian consumers and businesses and will also benefit IDBI Bank, Digit and IIFL Capital and Fairfax for many decades to come.

On Fairfax's India strategy, Watsa said, "Nothing is guaranteed in life but the growth possibility in India we think, could shock everybody."

On his management philosophy, he said, "We believe in decentralised operations. That's one of the reasons for our success. And we continue to believe in that."

Rakesh Sharma, current CEO of IDBI Bank, has "done a superb job and will continue as CEO", Watsa said.

IDBI Bank, founded in 1964, had faced significant financial difficulties between 2016 and 2020. It faced lending failures and huge non-performing assets. Its recovery gathered momentum in 2018 when the clean-up of the bank's balance sheet started.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

YES Bank sees 250 basis points hit on AT1 revival

Christina Titus
Mumbai, October 16

The reinstatement of YES Bank's Rs 8,415-crore additional tier-1 (AT1) bonds following the Supreme Court's ruling will erode the lender's common equity tier-1 (CET1) capital ratio by 250 basis points (bps), even as its overall Tier 1 capital ratio is expected to remain unchanged.

In an exchange filing on Friday, the private sector lender said the reinstatement would reduce its CET1 capital, including profits, by 250 bps based on its capital position as of June 30. However, its Tier 1 capital ratio is expected to remain unchanged at 14%.

YES Bank reported a CET1 ratio of 14% and a capital adequacy ratio of 15.1% at the end of June. CET1, a bank's highest-quality capital, acts as the first line of defence against losses during financial stress. The regulatory minimum CET1 requirement is 5.5%, excluding additional buffers.

The disclosure came a day after the Supreme Court (SC) upheld the Bombay High Court's decision to quash the write-off of YES Bank's AT1 bonds. The apex court ruled that the bank's administrator lacked the authority to extinguish the instruments under the reconstruction scheme. It also said the annual coupon payments would remain unaffected by the outcome of the appeals. FE

BRIEFLY

Forex reserves drop by $8.58 bn to $726 bn

Mumbai: India's forex kitty dropped by $8.58 billion to $726.03 billion during the week ended October 9, the RBI said on Friday. In the previous reporting week, the reserves had dropped by $12.95 billion to $734.61 billion. The reserves had touched an all-time high of $785.71 billion for the week ended September 4, driven by a heavy flow of currency as part of a special concessional swap for deposits from the diaspora, through which banks raised a record sum of nearly $133 billion, but have been on a declining trend ever since. PTI

PNB Q2 profit rises 13% to Rs 5,532 cr

New Delhi: Punjab National Bank (PNB) on Friday reported a 13% rise in net profit to Rs 5,532 crore for the second quarter ended September 2026, driven by improved core income and a moderation in bad loans. The country's second-largest public sector lender had logged a profit of Rs 4,904 crore in the year-ago period. The bank's total income increased to Rs 38,185 crore in the second quarter from Rs 36,214 crore a year ago, PNB said in a regulatory filing. Interest income rose 9% to Rs 34,585 crore in the September quarter of FY27 from Rs 31,872 crore in the year-ago period. PTI

MF houses halt subscriptions in gold FoFs

New Delhi: More than a dozen mutual fund houses, including SBI Mutual Fund, HDFC Mutual Fund, ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund and Kotak Mutual Fund, have temporarily suspended fresh subscriptions in their gold fund of funds (FoFs) starting this Friday. The suspension will remain in force until further notice, according to the notices issued by the respective fund houses. Gold FoFs invest money into Gold Exchange Traded Funds rather than buying physical gold. PTI

Welfare schemes improved 22 cr lives, West Bengal benefitted most

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, October 16

THE STANDARD of living of four out of every 10 people in West Bengal improved because of the government's welfare schemes – the highest proportion of any major state – as per a new study by statisticians from the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI). At 40.5%, the percentage for West Bengal is comfortably the highest, with Chhattisgarh second with 29.2%, Assam third (29%), and Karnataka fourth (28.4%).

Nationally, around 22 crore people saw an improvement in their level of living due to in-kind social transfers, the MoSPI staff paper found.

Using unit-level data from the 2022-23 Household Consumption Expenditure Survey, the paper compared the relative change in households' Monthly Per Capita Consumption Expenditure fractile class with and without imputing the value of free or subsidised goods such as foodgrains, laptops, bicycles, and school uniforms, among others.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

RBI approves merger of Emirates NBD branches with RBL Bank

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, October 16

THE RESERVE Bank of India (RBI) has approved the amalgamation of the Indian branches of Emirates NBD Bank with RBL Bank, with the merger set to take effect from December 1, 2026.

Following the amalgamation, all Indian branches of Emirates NBD Bank will operate as branches of RBL Bank from the effective date.

On October 18, 2025, Dubai-based Emirates NBD Bank agreed to acquire a controlling stake in RBL Bank through a primary capital infusion of approximately $3 billion (around Rs 26,850 crore).

The proposed investment involved a preferential issue of shares that could raise Emirates NBD's stake in RBL Bank to up to 60%, subject to regulatory approvals and other customary closing conditions.

As part of the transaction, Emirates NBD also made a mandatory open offer to acquire up to 26% of RBL Bank's shares from public shareholders, in accordance with the Securities and Exchange Board of India's (SEBI) takeover regulations.

Emirates NBD has maintained a representative office in India since March 2000. In 2016, it received RBI approval to open its first branch in Mumbai and commenced operations in India on July 3, 2017. It subsequently expanded its presence by opening two additional branches in Gurugram and Chennai.

Emirates NBD is 56% owned by the Dubai government through the Investment Corporation of Dubai and Dubai Holding Group.

AI risks may exceed opportunities without safeguards: IMF chief

Reuters
Bangkok,October 16

THE RISKS of artificial intelligence may exceed its opportunities if no adequate safeguards and ethical framework are put in place, IMF chief Kristalina Georgieva said on Friday, backing a blend of industry self-regulation and input from key governments.

The nascent technology was a dominant topic at this week's annual meetings of the IMF and World Bank in Bangkok, where the IMF on Tuesday flagged significant growth and financial stability risks from a potential end of the AI investment boom, high debt levels and a prolonged war in the West Asia.

Georgieva said AI was already strengthening the global economy, but could also deliver negative shocks if it failed to deliver major productivity gains as quickly as hoped.

"If there are no safeguards, then the risks may exceed the opportunities. And above all, we do need an ethical foundation, and I'm not sure we are there as a society," she said.

MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold ▲	US Dollar ▼
74,729.27	23,146.15	₹1,46,426	₹94.96
413.66	148.80		
0.56%	0.65%		
		Silver ▲	Oil ▼
		₹2,10,918	$119.39

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION DATA GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1 KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF OCTOBER 15, 2026

THE TRAVEL INSURANCE FACILITY IS CURRENTLY AVAILABLE FOR E-TICKETS ONLY

SC order on train insurance: Who will be covered & how much compensation is offered

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, October 16

THE SUPREME Court has directed the railways to extend the insurance facility to passengers who book tickets from station counters, a move which will extend the insurance net to those coming from disadvantaged sections and from remote areas. The court on October 6 told the Railway Board to implement the order by October 27.

Currently, over 87% of all reserved tickets are booked online. The remaining over 12% tickets — purchased offline through counters — don't provide the third party insurance cover that passengers can avail by paying 45 paise extra while buying a ticket online.

But what is the status of insurance in Indian Railways? Who is eligible, and how much compensation can one receive in the event of an accident? We explain.

Railways has to pay compensation in case of death or injury to a bona fide passenger due to accidents or untoward incidents, as defined in the Railways Act, 1989.

The optional third party insurance

Railways also offers optional travel insurance for e-ticket passengers. The claim and liabilities fall between the passengers and insurance companies. Railways only provide links with insurance companies through its website to take insurance cover for the passengers.

According to the IRCTC, the scheme is applicable only for Indian Citizens. Foreign nationals are not eligible under the scheme for travel insurance coverage.

For Indians, the travel insurance facility is provided only for confirmed, partly confirmed and RAC tickets at the time of booking only.

This means that waiting ticket passengers, who are allowed to travel only at counter ticket, are not covered under the scheme.



Over 87% of all reserved tickets are booked online. REUTERS

The premium of the insurance per passenger is 45 paise, inclusive of taxes, and it was fixed on February 17, 2024.

The scheme covers death, permanent total disability, partial disability, and hospitalisation expenses for injury and transportation of mortal remains following rail accidents or untoward incidents. The sum insured under the insurance scheme ranges from Rs 2 lakh to Rs 10 lakh based on the severity.

Counter ticket and general class passengers

With the push for digitisation in Indian Railways, counter ticket bookings have declined sharply in recent years. Currently, over 87% of all reserved tickets are booked online. However, passengers who continue to rely on offline bookings largely include those coming from the lowest strata of the society and remote areas, as recognised by the Supreme Court as well.

That is why the intervention of the railways was important for ensuring the safety of such passengers.

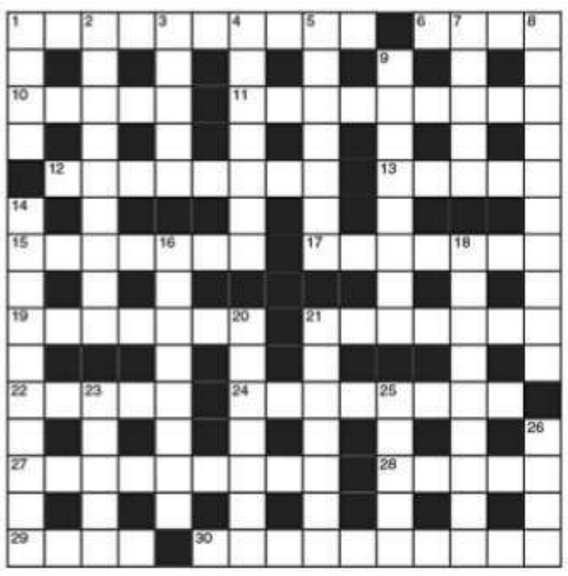
"Court has granted sufficient time to the authorities to devise a mechanism for extending such coverage to persons belonging to the lowest strata of society, who, in most cases, purchase their tickets at the railway reservation counters while undertaking journeys by train," said the top court. Apart from counter ticket passengers, the second class or general class passengers, who constitute maximum train travel, are also not covered under the insurance policy. Even for the reserved classes (SL, 1AC, 2AC, 3AC), the insurance scheme is not available in passenger trains and sub-urban trains.

The travel insurance is also not applicable for the children below 5 years of age who book the ticket without berth or seat. It is applicable for the children of 5-11 years of age who book the ticket with berth or without berth.

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CROSSWORD 6122



ACROSS

1 Fats Waller's rippling cascades (10)
6 Quiet atmosphere of match (4)
10 Miss a blank space (5)
11 So in love as to be transformed in demeanour (9)
12 A diet put out for fitness (8)
13 Constructive member of society (5)
15 He reads about what paste does (7)
17 The case of the broken latches (7)
19 Meals for father in breaks from work (7)
21 Untidy fringe in which there's nothing alien (7)
22 Postmark said to be valued in Zurich formerly (5)
24 Ann becomes engaged to a lean historian (8)
27 Charge follows an agreement for an instrument (9)
28 Say there's nothing in sin (5)
29 Sunday; a day in Germany set aside for men (4)
30 Well-known way in which Christmas is enjoyed (10)

DOWN

1 Fold paper around a shawl (4)
2 Nothing unusually posh in a voyage in this (9)
3 They have a central meeting place (5)
4 A beautiful woman describes Eastern ways (7)
5 Casual footwear for bakers? (7)
7 Hanging wasn't good enough for Polonius (5)
8 Together they may make a catch (3,3,4)
9 He trains regularly before work (8)
14 Twin propellers (4,2,4)
16 Taken by those sick and tired of work? (4,4)
18 An irritating habit (4,5)
20 A minute stretch of ocean? (3,4)
21 Can be converted into acceptable money (7)
23 Bill's getting a new car; that's capital (5)
25 He's got a pound left — to press his suit? (5)
26 Go ahead actor's role (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6121 **ACROSS:** 1 Coronet, 5 Hopes, 8 Sensation, 9 Tag, 10 Etch, 12 Doublets, 14 Craven, 15 Boston, 17 Wildfire, 18 Eyes, 21 Eft, 22 Easy going, 24 Diets, 25 Respect **DOWN:** 1 Caste, 2 Run, 3 Noah, 4 Tailor, 5 Handbook, 6 Patiently, 7 Signs on, 11 Charlotte, 13 Leaflets, 14 Cowherd, 16 Eraser, 19 Sight, 20 Ages, 23 Ice

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

The American temptation is to believe that foreign policy is a subdivision of ___. - Robert F.Kennedy (10)

EOARS

KLOUCP

DSITY

CILRHY

SOLUTIONS: Arose, Ditsy, Lockup, Richly
ANSWER: The American temptation is to believe that foreign policy is a subdivision of **psychiatry**. - Robert F. Kennedy

OVER THE HEDGE

BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS



CALVIN & HOBBES

BY BILL WATTERSON



MARVIN

BY TOM ARMSTRONG



SUDOKU 6474

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s
INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy;
3s = Medium; 4s = Hard;
5s = Very Hard;
6s = Genius

8								9
		1	6		8	4		
	3						8	
9			2		1			8
		2		3		1		
5			7		4			2
	7						9	
		8	5		7	3		
2								1

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6473

3	9	2	7	1	6	5	4	8
4	8	7	5	2	9	3	6	1
6	1	5	3	4	8	9	7	2
2	3	1	4	6	7	8	9	5
8	5	4	2	9	1	7	3	6
9	7	6	8	3	5	1	2	4
1	6	8	9	7	2	4	5	3
5	4	9	6	8	3	2	1	7
7	2	3	1	5	4	6	8	9

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Today your most intimate and personal life might be on public display more than usual. Some people might know personal details. Be aware of blurring the distinction between professional and personal relationships. Tonight: You're noticed.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Today you might feel a strong urge to "get away from all this." Travel would be a great option, but even being a tourist in your own city will please you. You'll feel excited to learn something new and interact with people from different backgrounds. Tonight: Explore.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Today, your emotional experiences might be more intense than usual. Conflicts with others might be more emotional. Therefore, guard against knee-jerk reactions. Tonight: Check your finances.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Something will turn your attention to your most personal relationships today. These people seem more important to you, which is why you might even feel jealous if they pay attention to someone else. Tonight: Make a warm connection.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Today you might have to put your own needs and wants second to the needs and wants of someone else. Someone requires your help, assistance or support in some way. Tonight: Get better organised.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Romance is more important to you today. If you're involved with someone, you might feel protective towards them. You might feel a crush on someone — someone famous, someone you've never met in person. Tonight: Socialise.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): This is the perfect day to enjoy the privacy of your home and relax among familiar surroundings. Take it easy. Take a moment to look at your attitudes and feelings. Tonight: Cocoon at home.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Today your communication with someone is important to you. You want to be heard. You want to have the freedom to speak to somebody at a gut level. This is why you won't be satisfied with superficial chitchat. Tonight: Thoughtful discussions.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): For whatever reason, it's easy to identify with your possessions today and feel a stronger attachment to them. You also might have to defend yourself in areas where you really have nothing at stake. Tonight: Check your money.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Today the Moon is in your sign, which can make you more emotional than usual, but it can also bring you a bit of extra good luck. This is the day to ask the universe for a favour!
Tonight: You're in charge.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Solitude in pleasant surroundings will appeal to you today. You feel the need to contemplate and ponder profound questions. You might not feel like socialising, which is entirely fine. Do your own thing. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Your emotional contact with friends is important to you today. This is why you might feel protective and supportive of someone you know. This is also an excellent day to examine your overall goals. Tonight: Be friendly.

Rajasthan Medical Services Corporation Ltd.
D-Block, Swasthya Bhawan, C-Scheme, Jaipur - 302005
Ph. No. 0141-2223887, Fax No. 0141-2228065, E-Mail-edepmrmsc-rj@nic.in
Ref. No. :- F-8() RMSC/EPM/M-2/NIB-959/2026-27/917 Dated :- 13/10/2026
NOTICE INVITING BID
Bid for item Yellow Plastic bag for Immunization are invited from interested bidders up to Date: 03-11-2026 : 06:00 P.M. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on Procurement portal website **"https://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in"** or **"www.dipronline.org"** or **"https://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in"** or website **http://rmsc.health.rajasthan.gov.in.**
UBN : MSC2627GLRC00070
Director (P)
Raj.Samwad/C/26/12032 Rajasthan Medical Services Corporation

Mumbai Railway Vikas Corporation Ltd.
INVITATION FOR TENDER: MRVC-W-277
(Single Packet e-Procurement Tender Process)
Mumbai Railway Vikas Corporation Ltd. (MRVC) having its corporate office at Second Floor, Churchgate Station Building, Mumbai–400020, invites e-Tenders for the **"Provision of KAVACH (TCAS) alteration (M/s Medha make) in connection with 5th & 6th line work in Borivali (BVI)–Virar (VR) section and 3rd & 4th line work in Virar (VR)–Dahanu Road (DRD) Sections."** Details of Tender and Tender document are available on e-procurement website https://www.eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app The last date for completed e-Tender submission at website https://www.eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app is **17.11.2026 up to 15:00 hours. Corrigendum, if any, will be posted on the website only.**

Rajasthan State Pollution Control Board
Headquarter, 4, Institutional Area, Jhalana Doongri, Jaipur-302004, Phone: 0141-2711263, 2716816
e-mail: member-secretary@rpcb.nic.in Toll Free HelpLine No.: 18001806127 Ext. 7
क्रमांक :- एफ.3 (632)/राप्रनिमं/स्था./2718 दिनांक :- 16/10/2026
बोली संख्या : संस्थापन / 01/2026-27
बोली सूचना
राजस्थान राज्य प्रदूषण नियंत्रण मण्डल द्वारा "मशीन विद मैन (कम्प्यूटर मय ऑपरेटर, चतुर्थ श्रेणी कर्मचारी एवं वाहन चालक की सेवाएं (जॉब बेसिस पर)" हेतु जारी बोली संख्या संस्थापन /01/2026-27 दिनांक 16/10/2026 के अन्तर्गत बोली आमंत्रित की जाती है। बोली का विस्तृत विवरण राज्य के e-Proc पोर्टल **http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in,** लोक उपापन पोर्टल **http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in** या मण्डल की वेबसाइट **http://environment.rajasthan.gov.in/rpcb** पर देखा व डाउनलोड किया जा सकता है। बोली जमा कराने की अन्तिम तिथि 04.11.2026 समय सायंकाल 06:00 बजे तथा तकनीकी बोली खुलने की तिथि 05.11.2026 समय प्रातः 11:00 बजे है।
(बोली का UBN No.PCB2627SLOB00059)
राज.संवाद/सी/26/12132 सदस्य सचिव

RAIL WHEEL FACTORY
Yelahanka, Bangalore - 560064
web site: www.rwf.indianrailways.gov.in
TENDER NOTICE NO.: RWF/S/P1/14/2026-27 dt:15.10.26
On behalf of the President of India, Principal Chief Materials Manager invites E-Tenders from Vendors for supply of following items as per RWF specification on IREPS E-Portal **http://www.ireps.gov.in:** (i) **Tender No:** P1263017; **Item: 300mm x 300mm RCS R43 Steel Blooms; Qty:** 1113 MT; **Due Date:** 19.11.26. (ii) **Tender No:** P1262825; **Item: Calcined Lime; Qty:** 8690 MT; **Due Date:** 29.12.26.
Principal Chief Materials Manager
TENDER & TENDER NOTICE No: RWF/PCEE/EL/TD/2026-27/03RT dt 14.10.26
On behalf of the President of India, Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer invites E-Tenders for the work of **"Electrical improvement works in West & East Colony at RWF using Solar Energy installations"** on IREPS E-Portal **http://www.ireps.gov.in** (Works) **Estimated Cost:** ₹ 1,79,64,366.10; **EMD:** ₹ 3,59,300/-; **Due Date & Time:** 07.11.26 @ 11:00 Hrs
Deputy Chief Electrical Engineer
Detailed Tender documents & corrigendum will be available in IREPS E-Portal.

SOUTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Follow us on @SCRailwayindia Details of the Tender Notices of S.C Railway can be seen on our website : www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in
TENDER NOTICE PUB/730
On behalf of The President of India, Sr.Division Signal & Telecom Engineer, Hyderabad Division, South Central Railway, Secunderabad Invites Open Tenders for the following works through **E-Procurement** Up To 11.30 hours of **dated.05.11.2026 TENDER DATE 14.10.2026**
1. Tender No. : Y/SG/36/2026-27/22 **Name of the work:** Hyderabad Division: (1) Reliability improvement of GWD-PASR & PASR-RC Section Block Circuits and Provision of Multi Section Digital Axle Counter (MSDAC) Complete System in dual detection to existing Track Circuits at PASR Station Yard & (2) Modification of Circuits to suit Kavach at 4 Stations i.e, BMO, FM, UR & DTP as per new policy - Signal & Telecom arrangements. **Tender value (₹):** 9,96,32,055.07 **EMD (₹):** 19,92,700.00
For Bid document and other details, login to **http://www.ireps.gov.in.** Any corrigenda will be issued online only.
Sr.Division Signal & Telecom Engineer, Hyderabad
Open E-Tender Notice No. CAO/Con/RSP/SC/07/2026-Capital (works) dated 10.10.2026 PUB/731
For and on behalf of President of India, the undersigned invites e-tender for the following works up to 11.00 hrs on 03.11.2026
1. e-Tender No. : CONST-CAO-RSP-26-15 **Name of the work:** HYB division-SC-MUE section: Construction of RUB in lieu of LC.No.255 at Km 616/700-800 between Cavalry Barracks- Malkajgiri station by Air-pushing with RH-girder **Approx. Tender Value in (₹):** 19,88,89,373.85 **EMD (₹):** 39,77,800.00 **Completion period (in Months):** 12 **Defect liability period (in Months) :** 48 **Works considered similar in nature towards Standard eligibility criteria:** A.III Any Bridge work by Box Pushing/Air Pushing method under the Railway Track and under Traffic conditions.
· Tenderers should participate through e-tendering only and no manual offers will be considered.
· Tender conditions/other particulars are available in the Tender documents on IREPS website at **ireps.gov.in** which can be downloaded, view modification, if any and can be participated through the website as mentioned.
Dy.Chief Electrical/Con/RSP/Secunderabad
A846
For further tender conditions / details and for downloading the tender documents, Please visit website at https://www.ireps.gov.in or www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

MAHARASHTRA EX-SERVICEMEN CORPORATION LTD, PUNE, (MESCO)
2nd Floor, "Raigad" Building,
Opp National War Memorial, Ghorpadi, Pune 411001
Contact: 020-26302659, Mob No. 9373164962
E-mail : contact@mescoltd.co.in
MESCO web site: www.mescoltd.co.in
Applications are invited from eligible candidates specifically Maharashtra Government retirees with administrative experience for contractual appointments to the following positions at the Maharashtra Ex-Servicemen Corporation Ltd. (MESCO), Pune, for an initial period of 3 months, extendable up to a maximum of 6 months:-

Ser. No.	Name of Post
1.	**Administration Consultant - 01** (i) Mumbai - 01

1. Terms and conditions for the above posts have been uploaded on MESCO website www.mescoltd.co.in
2. Interested and eligible candidates should submit their applications in person or by e-mail to the postal address and e-mail given on the MESCO website.
3. Last date for receipt of applications is **30 Oct 2026.**

MANAGING DIRECTOR, MESCO, PUNE

कार्यालय कार्यपालन अभियंता, जल संसाधन संभाग कांकेर, जिला उत्तर बस्तर कांकेर (छ.ग.)
e-mail: cewrknk@cgwrd.in
// निविदा निरस्तीकरण सूचना //
क्रमांक/3114/व.ले.लि./2026-27 कांकेर, दिनांक 13/10/2026
इस कार्यालय द्वारा आमंत्रित निविदा सिस्टम क्र. 190407, सूचना क्र. 03/व.ले.लि. / 2026-27 दिनांक 08.05.2026 कार्य का नाम कांकेर जिले के विकासखण्ड कांकेर अंतर्गत बागोड़ एनीकट का पुनः निर्माण सह उद्वहन सिंचाई योजना का निर्माण कार्य (राशि रुपए 2177.50 लाख) कार्य हेतु प्रथम आमंत्रण, छ.ग. शासन, जल संसाधन विभाग, मंत्रालय, महानदी भवन, नवा रायपुर-अटल नगर, के पत्र क्र.-PROJ/5030/2026-WRD/F-1/ नवा रायपुर, दिनांक 09/10/2026 एवं मुख्य अभियंता, गोदावरी कछार, जल संसाधन विभाग, जगदलपुर के पत्र क्रमांक / सामान्य / 2026/3289 जगदलपुर, दिनांक 13.10.2026 के निदेर्शानुसार शासनहित में निर्णय लेते हुए पुनः निविदा आमंत्रित प्रस्तावित की गई है। जिसके परिपालन में प्रथम निविदा निरस्त किया जाता है।
जिसका प्रकाशन जी.नं. 262702248 दिनांक 23.07.2026 है।
हस्ता./-
कार्यपालन अभियंता
जल संसाधन संभाग कांकेर
जिला- उत्तर बस्तर कांकेर (छ.ग.)
No.262703976/7

कार्यालय नगर निगम, अजमेर
झलकारी बांई स्मारक के सामने, पंचशील रोड़, अजमेर (राज0)
Phone No. :- 0145-2429953
E-mail :-ajmermc@rajasthan.gov.in Web site :-www.lsg.rajasthan.gov.in/mcajmer
क्रमांक : H.O./2026-27/1075 दिनांक : 13.10.2026
निविदा सूचना
अजमेर नगर निगम वित्तीय वर्ष 2026–27, 2027–28 (कुल 12 माह) की अवधि हेतु नगर निगम अजमेर व राजकीय विभागों में नियमानुसार संवेदको/फर्म से ऑनलाईन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। संवेदक द्वारा निविदा प्रपत्र व विवरण पोर्टल **www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in, www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in** पर देखा जा सकता है।
NIB Code : ANN2627A0112 & UBN NO. ANN2627SLOB00132
राज.संवाद/सी/26/12112 स्वास्थ्य अधिकारी

उदयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, राजस्थान
No. :- F-2(01)Acct/Contract/2026-27/202 - 204 Date :- 12/10/2026
ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या : 55/2026-27
उदयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, उदयपुर द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्यो मय डिफेक्ट लाईबिलिटी अवधि के लिये जो कि निविदा प्रपत्र में अंकित है के लिये उपयुक्त श्रेणी में पंजीकृत संवेदको से निर्धारित प्रपत्र में ई–टेण्डरिंग के माध्यम से ऑनलाईन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है :–

निविदा कार्यो की कुल लागत	रूपये 485.00 लाख (01 कार्य)
ऑनलाईन निविदा प्रपत्र डाउनलोड/अपलोड करने की अवधि	15.10.2026 को प्रातः 10.00 बजे से 10.11.2026 को सांयः 6.00 बजे तक
Online EMD, Tender Fee & Processing Fee जमा कराने की तिथी	15.10.2026 को प्रातः 10.00 बजे से 10.11.2026 को सांयः 6.00 बजे तक
ऑनलाईन निविदा खोलने की तिथी	12.11.2026 को प्रातः 11:00 बजे (तकनीकी बिड)

विस्तृत विवरण वेबसाईट **urban.rajasthan.gov.in/uitudaipur**, **www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in** व **www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in** पर देखा जा सकता है।
UBN No. : ITU2627WSOB00348
राज.संवाद/सी/26/12088 अधिशाषी अभियन्ता - तृतीय उदयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण

SOUTH COAST RAILWAY
VISAKHAPATNAM
Follow us on @SCoRailway
Website: scor.indianrailways.gov.in
NOTICE INVITING e-TENDER (through https://ireps.gov.in) PUB/SCoR-406
Chief Administrative Officer, Construction Organization, South Coast Railway, Visakhapatnam respectively, invites e-tender on behalf of the President of India for the following works:
1. NIT No : EPC-CAOCVSKP 2026-008 Date: 10/10/2026 **Name of work :** Guntakal Division - Construction of 3rd and 4th lines of track from Guntakal (W) (incl.) to Bellary Jn (excl.) from Km. 208.520 to Km 254.500 (45.980 Km) including Civil, Electrical (OHE & GE) and Signalling works with Kavach in connection with Quadrupling of Bellary Jn -Guntakal West section in Guntakal division of South Coast Railway in the states of Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka. **Estimated Cost:** (₹) 1067,04,00,000.00 **EMD (₹):** 21,34,08,000.00 **Completion Period:** 900 (Nine Hundred) Days. **Date of Opening:** 23.11.2026 15:00hrs
i) For bid document and other details, please login to website **https://ireps.gov.in**
ii) Tenderers can submit their offers online during tender submission period which is the Fifteen days period prior to closing of tender.
iii) Tenderers should watch for any corrigenda (issued online only) up to the date of commencement of the tender submission period.
Chief Administrative Officer, Construction, Visakhapatnam
SCoR-A450
For further tender conditions / details and for downloading the tender documents, Please visit website at https://www.ireps.gov.in or www.scor.indianrailways.gov.in

JAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
Indira Circle, Jawahar Lal Nehru Marg, Jaipur-302
No.: JDA/EE & TA to Dir. Engg.-I/2026-27/D- Date : 16.10.2026
NOTICE INVITING BID
NIB No. : EE & TA to Dir. Engg.-I/23/2026-27
Bids are invited from interested bidders for following works :-

S. No.	UBN No.	Cost of Work (Lacs)	Nature of Work	Last Date
1	JDA2627WSOB00366	339.69	Electrical Work	02.11.2026
2	JDA2627WLOB00374	4165.38	Construction of Underpass	04.11.2026
3	JDA2627WSOB00380	270.32	Construction of Footpath	04.11.2026
4	JDA2627WLOB00382	820.98	Road Work	06.11.2026
5	JDA2627WLOB00384	1688.30	Holistic Development Work	06.11.2026

Other particulars of the respective bid may be visited on Procurement Portal website www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in, www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in and www.jda.rajasthan.gov.in
Executive Engineer & TA to Dir. Engg-I
Raj.Samwad/C/26/12129

MAHARASHTRA EX-SERVICEMEN CORPORATION LTD, PUNE, (MESCO)
2nd Floor, "Raigad" Building,
Opp National War Memorial, Ghorpadi, Pune 411001
Contact: 020-26302659, Mob No. 9373164962
E-mail : contact@mescoltd.co.in MESCO web site: www.mescoltd.co.in
Applications are invited from eligible retired Officers, JCOs and ORs or equivalent ranks in the Navy and Air Force and their dependents for appointment on following posts on contractual basis:-

Ser. No.	Name of Post
1.	**Manager - 02** (i) Malad - 01 (ii) Latur - 01
2.	**Clerk - 03** (i) Mumbai - 01 (ii) Pune - 02
3.	**MESCO Supervisor - 01** (i) Jalna - 01

1. Terms and conditions for the above posts have been uploaded on MESCO website www.mescoltd.co.in
2. Interested and eligible candidates should submit their applications in person or by e-mail to the postal address and e-mail given on the MESCO website.
3. Last date for receipt of applications is **30 OCT 2026.**

MANAGING DIRECTOR, MESCO, PUNE

SOUTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Follow us on @SCRailwayindia Details of the Tender Notices of S.C Railway can be seen on our website : www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in
NOTICE INVITING BIDS FOR EMPANELMENT OF ADVERTISING AGENCIES PUB/740
GeM Bid Number: GEM/2026/B/8161736
Date of Issue: 16.10.2026
Online bids are invited through the **Government e-Marketplace (GeM)** portal from eligible and accredited advertising agencies for empanelment on South Central Railway, subject to the eligibility criteria and terms and conditions stipulated in the Bid Document.
Details of the Bid:

Name of Work/Service	Empanelment of Advertising Agencies on South Central Railway
Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)	₹1,00,000/- (Rupees One Lakh only)
Period of Empanelment	Two (02) years
Bid Submission End Date and Time	16.11.2026 at 15:00 hrs

The complete Bid Document, containing detailed eligibility criteria, scope of work, and terms and conditions, is available exclusively on the Government e-Marketplace (GeM) portal at **https://gem.gov.in**
Registration on the GeM portal as a Service Provider (Seller) and enrolment under the "Custom Bid for Services" module are mandatory for participation in this empanelment process. Unregistered or incorrectly registered agencies will not be able to access, download, or submit bids via the portal. Manual, physical, or email submissions will be summarily rejected. Interested agencies are advised to complete the required GeM registration and submit their bids within the stipulated time.
A859 **Chief Public Relations Officer South Central Railway**

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Was in rehab for 26 days: Chahal on his alcohol addiction

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 16

CRICKETER YUZVENDRA Chahal has opened up on his struggles with alcoholism and having anxiety attacks in a podcast with former India opener Aakash Chopra. Chahal also spoke about his personal life becoming fodder for social media chatter after his divorce.

Chahal was asked by Chopra on the Baith and Bol podcast about why he decided to quit alcohol.

"*Zyada ho gaya tha. Limit cross kardi thi* (It got a bit too much. The limit was crossed). I went to a rehab center where I stayed for 26 days. Now, I know how to handle drinking — what to do, how things work. That made a huge difference for me. Even in my personal life, I started understanding things much more maturely. My emotions have toned down a bit," he said.

Chahal added, "At last year's IPL, my body felt like I was 30 years old again. I'm doing my gym work perfectly, practising fielding, training... I realised everything fell into place once this bad habit left my life. I am much more mature. Now I don't need that substance just to talk or function."

Talking about his divorce and how it became conversation on social media, Chahal said: "When you are a public figure you basically give everyone an invitation to comment on your personal life. When things started to be said about my personal life, it felt bad. It also had an effect on my cricket."

Chahal then opened up about his anxiety: "My face used to shrink during a panic attack. I couldn't even speak. Sometimes when it happened, my lips would get so tight and pulled to one side that you could easily figure out something was wrong with me.

"That's when I realized these things were happening. Then I took steps to address it, and as it gradually faded away, I was like, 'Forget what happened. People on social media will keep on talking, you can't shut them up. Let's start afresh.'"

INDIA VS WEST INDIES

Bhuvi could be X-factor at favourite hunting ground

Recalled for NZ series, 36-year-old may play in decider if injured pacer Arshdeep sits out

Sandip G
New Delhi, October 16



Bhuvneshwar Kumar could return to the lineup ahead of initial plans, replacing Arshdeep Singh. REUTERS

THE LONG and tedious wait of Bhuvneshwar Kumar to wear the national stripes again could get shorter. The selectors picked the seamer after a four-year wilderness for the New Zealand tour next month. But should Arshdeep Singh lose his race to attain optimal fitness for the tie-breaking T20I against West Indies, the well-worn seamer, called as a cover for the left-armer after he copped a blow on his elbow in Hyderabad, could be fast-tracked to international cricket in the familiar setting of the M Chinnaswamy Stadium, his home ground in the IPL.

India's bowling coach Morne Morkel asserted that Arshdeep, India's most prolific wicket-taker in this format, would certainly play if fully fit. But if not, the seam-bowling metronome's reintegration seems inevitable, to round off another glorious comeback in his career.

Reverting to a 36-year-old seamer, who would turn 38 when India defend their crown in 2028, is not so much a panic choice as it is a reward for his exemplary consistency in IPL.

He will, hypothetically, offer instant solutions to the puzzles that had confounded India's bowling firm in Jasprit Bumrah's absence. An immense repertoire of skills and control, variations matched by few bowlers in the squad, if not the world; a wealth of experience amid a pool of callow bowlers acquainting with the international rigours; a quiet guiding force that could shepherd the young pack to harness their untapped gifts; a knack of wearing different roles, and for the sake of immediacy, a familiarity with the caprices of Chinnaswamy.

In 18 games in the paradise of sixes, he has snaffled 26 wickets and bled 8.45 runs, commendable numbers when you consider the demons piquing the bowlers. Short boundaries, early onset of dew and pan-cake surfaces. Last IPL season, six of the 10 totals were in excess of 200. Twice were 200 totals overhauled. RCB lost only one of the five games, and Bhuvneshwar gobbled up 11 wickets and maintained an economy rate of 7.8 runs an over. The wicket-spreadsheet shows that he ejected batsmen in every phase of the game, with the new-ball in the power-play, as an enforcer in his rare middle-over cameos, and a devil at the death. He was one of the pillars behind RCB's maiden title run (28 wickets at 17).

He produced a season the selectors could no longer ignore. It's hard to cast a blind eye to his craft, in perpetual evolution, in search of bowling zen. It's a familiar and fascinating story of upward trajectory, like a bird collecting all the colourful feathers it could and dancing with the hues. The boy born with durable fingers and a wrist that could make a piece of dead leather recite doomed verses for batsmen.

Who consigned the great Sachin Tendulkar to his first first-ball zilch in domestic cricket and learned to swing the ball away from the right hander. Who added pace and skid, gulped up the cutter menu, devoured the slower-ball variations, and mastered deception with different lengths, and the wobble seam. Who suffered the sort of injuries that would have ended careers, but is still in search of perfection. "Never seen a better student of the game," his mentor and friend Praveen Kumar once told this daily.

Whether he is a short-term fix with a side experimenting to find the perfect fast-bowling permutation is unsure, but he offers dimensions incredibly rare in the format. A bowler who could seamlessly switch his lengths, with little discernible change in his action; who reads the batsman's mind like a clairvoyant, who has the cricketing intuition to understand which ball to bowl at which batsman at which time with an unhurried awareness.

He would be unlike any other seamer the West Indies batsmen had faced in this series. He swings and seams the ball. So did Arshdeep, but Bhuvi does with better control. He doesn't hurry batsmen with pace like the Yadavs, Mayank and Prince, but disorients their reflexes with slower balls. He creates that illusion in batsmen—he is fast when batsmen think he is slow; he is slow when batsmen assume he is skiddy. He is a one-man encyclopaedia for all the tricks and guiles the format has seen—paradoxically for a bowler once misconstrued as a mismatch in this format.

He embodies everything Morkel wants from his seamers, as he detailed in the press conference. "It's about the bowler on the night there assessing the conditions," he began his verbal treatise. "Is the ball swinging? Is the ball seeming? If it's not swinging, how can we create angles on the crease? Can we be smarter in terms of if the batsman hits us off our lengths? Or are we going to go to plan B quickly?"

An admission came next: "At the moment that is something that we've not been good at." And something Bhuvneshwar often is extremely good at.

Yet, given the format's fickleness, it could be that Bhuvneshwar could endure a horrible night back into international cricket if he indeed returns. No bowler, not even Bumrah, is weather-proof in this format. But a fervent hope that he could make the difference lurks. To believe that a bowler could be the antidote in a batsmen-smitten world itself is a nod to the masterful, yet metamorphosing art of Bhuvneshwar.

Fastest-scoring T20I series ever heads to Chinnaswamy for finale

Lalith Kalidas
New Delhi, October 16

India and West Indies have turned their T20I series into a record-breaking batting spectacle, with sixes and strike rates soaring to unprecedented levels

OVER 4000 matches and 550 bilateral series have been played across two decades of men's T20Is. In the last 10 days, its two most successful teams have combined to butcher almost every existing record in a series with little to no meaningful context.

The ongoing India-West Indies T20I series, played seven months after the summer's World Cup, will likely be forgotten by the next World Cup in two years. Those who will carry an ick from this series will be the bowlers, buried in an unprecedented boundary avalanche launched by batters who have made the format all about themselves.

Some backdrop to this carnage is that it has been unleashed across India, home to the IPL, with an increasingly uniform set of pitches for white-ball fixtures.

Bowling plans have seldom been rendered so obsolete in a series, so much so that a wily West Indies finger-spinner has emerged as the pick of the bowlers. With six wickets in four matches, Roston Chase is the only bowler to have sent down at least 10 overs without a sub-10 economy rate in this series.

98 sixes have been struck in only 918 balls, a maximum pinging off the bat every 9.3 deliveries. No bilateral series involving Full-Member Nations have seen a greater haul of sixes at such rates ever, and only three have recorded more maximums across five games.

If 23 sixes are struck in the fifth T20I on Saturday at the holy grail of six-hitting in India - the M Chinnaswamy Stadium - the teams would have bettered the record 120 sixes by England and West Indies from 2023.

The contests have been as much an indictment of placid wickets as a benchmark reflecting soaring power-hitting standards.

Fastest series in history

Across the four games in Lucknow, Ranchi, Indore and Hyderabad, West Indies and India became the first two teams to smash 2000 sixes in T20Is. Historical leaders in unrelenting big hits, West Indies have struck a six every 14 balls in the format, substantially better than India at 16.19 deliveries. That has seamlessly translated into this series as well, in the backyard of the world champions.

Both teams have scaled over 800 runs in four matches, with West Indies producing 126 boundaries to India's 124. Shai Hope's men, however, distinctly top the six-hitting charts with 57 sixes, a strike every 8.1 deliveries. India, on the other hand, have smote 41 maximums, one every 10.8 deliveries.

Dot balls have had little effect on the mind or muscle this series. Despite playing out more dot balls (153), accounting for over 32 per cent of the balls they have faced, West Indies have outscored India. They set the highest chase (252) against India at home in Ranchi before smashing the highest first-innings score (247) against the hosts in the country in Hyderabad.

Despite falling on the six-hitting front, India have produced more fours (81) and encountered fewer dots (112). The batters have collectively accorded a 184.94 strike rate, eclipsing West Indies' 179.83 for 15 more runs this series.

A precedent for such frightening levels of hitting was set in January this year when India and New Zealand combined to produce 1948 runs in five games on the heels of the World Cup. 116 sixes were struck then, with the series strike rate reading 176.28. India and West Indies have raised the bar further, striking at 180.93, making the current aggregates the fastest-scoring T20I series, involving at least four matches.

India's batting cohort has largely been alive to the six-hitting task at hand this year, a cornerstone of their successful World Cup defence in March. Across 20 matches at home this year, the Indians have walloped 247 sixes - a six every 8.8 deliveries - nearly doubling the tally from their previous best of 130 sixes from 2022.

A fleet of unyielding pitches, now bearing largely similar characteristics under the floodlights, has fuelled this rapid surge. This year, 865 sixes have been hit in 47 T20Is in India so far. It is the highest-ever tally for a calendar year in the country, eclipsing the 335 sixes struck in the previous T20 World Cup year in 2016.

More of the same spread is on the cards in the series decider. If the rain cover persisting around Bengaluru relents, the Chinnaswamy could still bear a downpour of belligerent, potentially record-breaking batting.

INDIA VS WEST INDIES, 5th T20I, Live on Star Sports Network and JioHotstar, 7 pm.

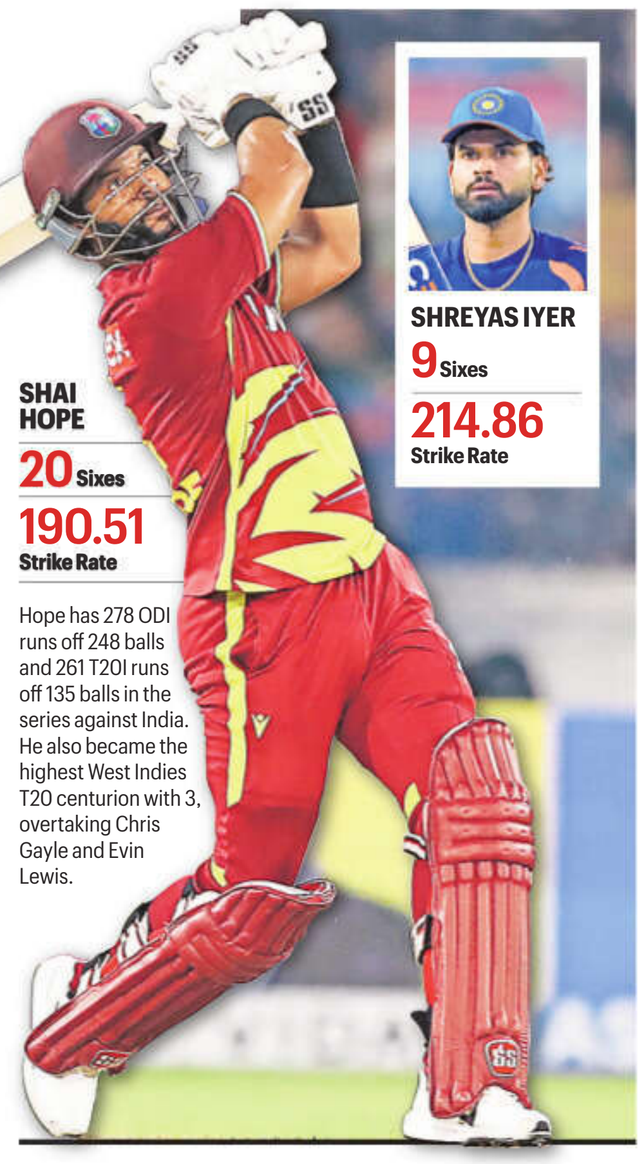
• SIX-HITTING MAYHEM

TEAM	M	RUNS	AVE	SR	4S	6S	BALLS/6	DOTS
WI	4	838	34.92	179.83	69	57	8.1	153
Ind	4	823	31.65	184.94	83	41	10.8	112

Highest SR in a T20I bilateral series*

TEAMS	YEAR	SR
Ind vs WI	2026	180.93
Ind vs NZ	2026	176.28
WI vs Aus	2025	160.62
Eng vs Ind	2026	156.13
WI vs Eng	2023	153.63

* MATCHES INVOLVING FULL-MEMBER TEAMS ONLY



Hope has 278 ODI runs off 248 balls and 261 T20I runs off 135 balls in the series against India. He also became the highest West Indies T20 centurion with 3, overtaking Chris Gayle and Evin Lewis.

Deepti, with 49, fashions nervy win over Zimbabwe

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, October 16

DEEPTI SHARMA'S contributions to India's success over the last few years have mainly come with the ball. On Friday, with India's bowlers having restricted Zimbabwe to 114/5 in the first T20I at Raipur, she would have hoped her job was done after the first innings.

Nyasha Gwanzura, however, had other ideas. The off-spinner rocked India early, reducing them to 19/4 with three wickets inside the powerplay. With the innings in tatters, India needed Deepti the batter to step up, and she did so in the crisis, with a 37-ball 49 that went a long way in preventing a scare and helping India win by four wickets.

At the other end was Niki Prasad, making her India T20I debut, and it was their 82-run stand that took India home on Smriti Mandhana's captaincy debut.

Niki absorbed the pressure first. She got off the mark from the fifth ball she faced, but once she settled in, the boundaries followed. Two fours in the sixth over got her moving, and she continued to pick off the loose balls.

That allowed Deepti to take her time. She was watchful early, then began opening up as the partnership grew. She hit a couple of boundaries in the fifth over, then found more in the ninth and 11th, steadily taking control of the chase.

Deepti's experience gave Niki the time to settle, while Niki's ability to keep the scoreboard moving allowed Deepti to play herself in before taking charge. They didn't try to do too much. They just kept chipping away at the target without taking unnecessary risks.



Deepti Sharma scored a vital 49 off 37 in India's tense win. CREIMAS

The partnership had grown to 82 when Deepti fell for 49 off 37, but Niki stayed unbeaten till the end, scoring the winning runs with a boundary and giving India a 1-0 lead.

Earlier, India's bowlers kept Zimbabwe in check for much of the innings, but two contrasting knocks from Kelis Ndhlovu and Sharne Mayers helped the visitors post 114/5.

Ndhlovu anchored Zimbabwe's innings with a patient 42 off 44 balls, hitting six fours. The 20-year-old left-hander has already overcome a serious setback this year after being struck by a bouncer in New Zealand and hospitalised. She held Zimbabwe's innings together in the middle overs before Arundhati Reddy dismissed her with a slower ball that beat her swipe and hit the off stump.

Mayers provided the late acceleration, scoring an unbeaten 43 off 33 balls with three fours and a six. She initially struggled to find momentum but shifted gears after the 13th over, launching Shafali Verma over long-on for the game's first six before taking consecutive boundaries off Arundhati Reddy. Her attacking stroke-play briefly lifted Zimbabwe.

Nandni Sharma had kept things tight for most of her spell before returning for the final over. She struck twice in consecutive deliveries, dismissing Nyasha Gwanzura and Michelle Mavunga. Her three earlier overs had cost just eight runs, and she finished with 2/11. Her final over ensured India had only 115 to chase and set up the dramatic fightback that followed.

BRIEF SCORES: Zimbabwe 114/5 in 20 overs (Sharne Mayers 43 not out, Kelis Ndhlovu 42; Nandni Sharma 2/11, Sree Charani 1/14) lost to India 116/6 in 15.4 overs (Deepti Sharma 49, Niki Prasad 39 not out; Nyasha Gwanzura 3/18) by 4 wickets.

• NEXT GEN SHINE

Inheritance of hundreds: Aaryavir Sehwag & Anvay Dravid score centuries again

Bhuvan Gupta
New Delhi, October 16

FRIDAY BROUGHT pride for two senior statesmen of Indian cricket: Virender Sehwag and Rahul Dravid. Their sons Aaryavir and Anvay — batting at grounds nine kilometres apart in Vizianagaram — hit big hundreds in the U-19 Vinoo Mankad Trophy. While Aaryavir's ton for Delhi went in vain, Anvay guided Karnataka to victory against Gujarat.

The 17-year-old Dravid junior, leading his side, smashed 151 off just 100 balls to help chase down a 358-run target (VJD method). Aaryavir, captaining Delhi, struck a 143-ball 173 to take them to 289 but Chandigarh gunned the total down in 41.3 overs.

Though it came in a losing cause, Aaryavir's knock earned him a spot in the India U-19 squad for next month's Asia Cup. He was getting good starts in earlier games but had not converted any into three figures before this. That is when Delhi coach Rajeev Nayyar had a word with him.

"One day before the match, I called him to my room and told him that his competition is not just with his teammates. 'You have to look around and see who is scoring the most runs in the tournament. Your performance should exceed that', I said to him," Nayyar told *The Indian Express*.

Like his father, Aaryavir is an opener and a natural stroke player. Nayyar thus had to reiterate the importance of getting his eye in against the new ball before upping the ante. "If you get a good start, start seeing the ball well, understand the strengths of the bowler and the behaviour of the wicket, then you can play your shots," the coach told him.



Anvay Dravid scored 151 runs off 100 balls in Karnataka's victory. SLC



Aaryavir Sehwag scored 173 off 143 balls. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Nayyar had seen Aaryavir gifting his wicket to the opposition on 40-odd with a lofted shot in a previous match. He did not want the teenager to repeat that. "I told him that beta (son), look, once you get a good start, you shouldn't throw away your wicket. You are an opener. If you face 100 balls, you can score 160-170 runs because you are a stroke player. For this, you will need patience and you have to stay on the wicket. Determination should be there. So he listened to me."

Though it came in a loss, Aaryavir's knock earned him a spot in India's U-19 squad for next month's Asia Cup

There was the added motivation of it being the team's last game of the league, and the India U-19 squad to be announced. "In the last match, if you score, it is always remembered," Nayyar reminded Aaryavir, who will turn 19 in three days.

The coach believes Aaryavir is the full package with his batting, fielding, bowling and leadership qualities. But he does not jump the gun on the likelihood of a senior India call-up in the future. "Look, it is very difficult... Right now he is playing for India Under-19. Yes, his father was a legend and he has some common traits, especially the way he hits spinners for sixes over covers. He has the potential for sure but India (selection) is very far. At some point he'll play Under-23, then Ranji Trophy, then Duleep Trophy, India A and then India," Nayyar said. He added a caveat: "Whatever training he is doing right now, he has to increase it every day, and has to be consistent."

The encouraging sign for him was the disappointment on Aaryavir's face when he got out. Despite scoring 173 runs, he was sad to miss out on a double ton. The disappointment compounded with the match result. Delhi elected to bat first because their strengths lied with batting, more than bowling. They ended up short by 60-70 runs on a flat deck, and then the bowlers failed to deliver, according to Nayyar.

"It was a perfect batting wicket. There was no grass on it and no bounce. But our bowling was not up to the mark. Fast bowler Pradyuman Sanan, who got five wickets in the last game, could not bowl well today," he said.

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DP WORLD C'SHIP

Hidalgo, Luiten, Meronk share lead; Chouhan best Indian

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 16

WITH NEARLY five hours lost to storms on the opening day, the DP World India Championship continued to play catch-up on Friday.

Angel Hidalgo, Joost Luiten and Adrian Meronk shared the clubhouse lead at the top of a congested leaderboard, while Om Prakash Chouhan was the best-placed Indian at tied 17th when play was suspended at the Delhi Golf Club. Chouhan, as well as Anirban Lahiri and Saptak Talwar - tied 46th - remained in contention to make the cut.

The second round will resume on Saturday, with the cut expected to be decided in the afternoon. More than half the field was yet to complete its second round, while 12 players were yet to tee off.

Luiten played the most among the leaders, tackling 34 holes for rounds of 68 and 68 to get to eight under. Meronk and Hidalgo both played 31 holes. Meronk was five under through four holes at the end of the opening day but added just one more birdie in the first round before following up with a 69. Hidalgo joined Luiten at eight under with rounds of 68 and 68.

Belgium's Thomas Detry birdied three of his first six holes in the second round to move alongside the leaders, a shot clear of English pair Todd Clements and Eddie Pepperell.

Meronk held the solo lead on Friday but dropped his only shot of the week so far on the ninth. "It was a lot of solid golf," he said. "I'm happy with my position. Obviously, a little bit disappointed with the bogey on the last, but it's still a good round."

Luiten also reached nine under after a hat-trick of gains from the 13th and further birdies on the 18th and second. He then made a double bogey on the eighth but bounced straight back with a birdie from 14 feet on the ninth.

"It was good for 17 holes, and then my 17th, the eighth hole, I double-bogeyed, which normally you would say it's a birdie hole," Luiten said. "I think the long day and the tiredness just got to me a bit at the end, and luckily I could get a birdie on the ninth."



Adrian Meronk in action at the DGC on Friday. DP WORLD

NAMED IN ODI SQUAD FOR NEW ZEALAND

Kushagra's father took a gamble to coach him, it's finally paid off

Shashikant, with no cricket background, learnt how to coach by reading extensively — inspired by Romila Thapar

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, October 16

SHASHIKANT KUMAR Kushagra doesn't recall his son Kumar Kushagra showing any interest in cricket. But for Shashikant, who is the joint commissioner (GST) in Jamshedpur, the choice was simply straightforward. Not because he had an unfilled cricketing dream. Or he saw a spark in his son. But 15 years ago he had seen what the game had done to a certain MS Dhoni. "If you see the world, everything is in cricket — fame, name, good lifestyle. Everything you could ask for is there in cricket. So, I thought we must create some new things in life," Shashikant tells *The Indian Express*.

So at 6, Shashikant would start handing Kumar cricketing lessons. Despite coming from a well-to-do family, the father did not enroll his son in a cricket academy. Instead, he — without any background in the game — would take up the role of a coach with single objective of making his son earn the India cap. And 15 years on, that dream is closer to reality with Kumar making his maiden India call-up for the upcoming tour of New Zealand, where he has been named in the ODI squad for the last two fixtures.

"It is a puzzle for me all these years," Shashikant says. "Kumar had no interest in cricket. But I made him play. At times while growing up, he wouldn't even listen, but I would force him, saying, 'You have to play by any means'. That's how he used to bat. I never played cricket in my life. I hadn't even touched a bat, nor touched a ball. But my intention was that we have to do such a thing in the world where people would look at us. Even if he wasn't interested, we still wanted to make him a cricketer and I knew how to make him one," Shashikant adds.

Woolmer's books

Before handing Kumar his cricketing lessons, Shashikant had to learn it all. He would study coaching manuals and also read books written by Bob Woolmer and Don Bradman to understand the nuances of batting. Every shot would be written down in the simple way that would allow the father and son to crack it.

"I never sent him to any academy, because it just takes a lot of time away from you. We thought that since we have to make him succeed very quickly, we ourselves read all the books. I read all the big cricketers' books, also those of Bob Woolmer and also whatever other books there were. We extracted points and worked out every shot, how this shot happens, how that shot happens. When it came to pull shot, we would write down the different ways to play it and similarly for the drives," Shashikant says.

Shashikant also picked up a very important lesson from historian Romila Thapar.

"I studied from JNU. I did my MA from there, and Romila Thapar used to teach and put a lot of emphasis on thorough research. I used to enjoy a lot. So we brought that same structure here into cricket too — that we have to do research, how things happen, where the hand should stay, where the finger should stay, the wrist position. Since we did extensive research on what works and what doesn't, he now knows his game."

Apart from reading, the video tutorials would involve batting highlights of Rahul Dravid and Virender Sehwag. At the nets, Shashikant would ensure his son received enough throwdowns – be it fast or facing spin, he would deliver it all. "I learned bowling, and we used to make him play. Even today he learns from me. He doesn't go anywhere; he comes to me and plays with me even at night, day, or anytime, because I know about his game more than anyone else."

Kumar's rise has been steady in Jharkhand. From the time he attended Under-14 trails, he hasn't looked back, making the gradual progression across age-groups, where his attacking game has stood out. At 19, he was made part of Centre of Excellence's target pool, a call-up to India A arrived in 2024 when he had just became an integral member of Jharkhand team. Then Delhi Capitals signed him up for Rs 7.2 crore at the IPL auctions before Gujarat Titans acquired him for Rs 65 lakh last season. All of it is a vindication to Kumar's talent and also his strong basics that allows him to shuffle between formats effortlessly.

Alongside batting, wicketkeeping happened to be a by-product achieved while trying to unlock fear.

"Though I coached him, he still had a bit of fear in him. We made him do wicketkeeping at the age of 12 with Ranji players, so that fear would vanish. I would make him stand-up to the stumps to the fast bowlers. Even if he got hit, I would tell him 'It is not going to be the end of life'. Like batting he didn't like it, but eventually learned. I would say once he started going to NCA only and saw the cricketers and their life, he started getting serious about the game. Now the boy is very motivated," Shashikant says.



Kumar Kushagra was named in the ODI squad for the fourth and fifth games in New Zealand. PTI

Squad for first 3 ODIs: Shubman Gill (c), Rohit Sharma, Virat Kohli, Shreyas Iyer (vc), KL Rahul (wk), Nitish Kumar Reddy, Axar Patel, Naman Dhir, Anshul Kamboj, Gurnoor Brar, Ruturaj Gaikwad, Arshdeep Singh, Ishan Kishan (wk), Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna*, Kuldeep Yadav.

Squad for 4th & 5th ODIs: Shreyas Iyer (c), Rohit Sharma, Virat Kohli, Tilak Varma, Ishan Kishan (wk, vc], Nitish Kumar Reddy, Axar Patel, Naman Dhir, Auqib Nabi, Gurnoor Brar, Ruturaj Gaikwad, Arshdeep Singh, Kumar Kushagra (wk), Mohammed Siraj, Yash Thakur, Kuldeep Yadav.

India's Test squad: Shubman Gill (c), Yashasvi Jaiswal, KL Rahul (vc), Devdutt Padikkal, Rishabh Pant (wk)*, Dhruv Jurel (wk), Ravindra Jadeja, Anshul Kamboj, Jasprit Bumrah, Prasidh Krishna, Akash Deep, Sai Sudharsan, Nitish Kumar Reddy, Washington Sundar, Kuldeep Yadav, Mohammed Siraj.

Jagsher loses in semis but a bright future beckons

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, October 16

TWO INDONESIANS in the finals of the Badminton World Junior Championships is ominous, but expected. But Jagsher Singh Khangurra joining top-seeded coloured Frenchman Mady Sow in the Last 4 pretty much reflects how World badminton is growing in its neo-markets — throbbing with aspiration and drawing interesting talent from far corners of India and France. Jagsher played a fighting mid-set, sandwiched by blowouts to finish with a creditable bronze after a 6-15, 15-13, 3-15 loss to Indonesian Radithya Bayu Wardhana.

Behind that lopsided margin, sandwiching a defiant mindset, were the 15-year-old Jagsher's struggles from one side of the large Cairo International Stadium in Egypt, as he failed to find the right length for his tosses and lifts to the backline. While it is evident that the Indian from Nabha, the perimeter of Patiala in Punjab, has some enviable defense and a wicked sense of gorgeous kill shots, he was downed like his senior academy mates, Lakshya Sen and Ayush Shetty by that very Indonesian proactive attack the inside-out cross-court deep smash that the red & whites from Taufik to Jojo Christie to Alwi Farhan and Ubaidillah seem to play like second nature. The attack set Jagsher back by a set down, 6-15 very quickly.

Late comeback

Once again from the brink, Jagsher launched a late comeback and used his patient defense and cerebral placements to bounce back from that 6-15 blowout. Uncannily just like his quarterfinals of the Badminton World Championships, he navigated the endgame of the midset superbly.

The kickstart came from him winning an ever-extending long rally for 6-5 long after full flourishing of his defensive rigour. He ended that with an acerbic drop shot that would've blended into any senior tournament in time travel. Jagsher can play.



Jagsher lost to Indonesia's Radithya Bayu Wardhana 6-15, 15-13, 3-15.

While he worked Wardhana around and played net pops just like Sen, diving too for good measure, his game looked very refined in its simplicity and efficacy. He needs net variations, like coach Sagar Chopda says, but he is icy cool and totally in control at the net and front court. He is defensive, but has a hit that will make do at his level - only if he wasn't so bashfully reluctant to deploy it much. Still, he pushed a decider, though the effort had consumed him.

Jagsher, put into Bangalore's Centre of Excellence by OGQ scouts, however, is clearly not in a hurry. He literally has two more years to better his medal colour. And well might.

His earliest coach Suresh Kumar recalls Jagsher's father, Manpreet Singh, a Math teacher, driving 35 kms back and forth twice a day to his coaching in Patiala. "They would start at 5 am and return to his school. And then back in the evening same thing. It was particularly hard in foggy winters, but he never missed practice," Suresh recalls.

Suresh saw Jagsher play in a small hall in Nabha, and was impressed by his diligence.

"His father teaches Math, mother Science, and Jagsher is a very obedient trainee. If I told him to do shuttle runs for 20 minutes and forgot about it, he wouldn't stop till I returned. Very well-mannered, hard-working, and humble," the coach recalled.

What always stood out was how Jagsher stayed patient.

After Suresh Kumar, he had stints at academies in Bahadurgarh and Mumbai before shifting to Centre of Excellence where he was trained by Sagar Chopda and Munira coach in Bangalore. At Cairo, he was guided by academy coach Thilak. Chopda, in charge of his coaching program, describes his game as "old-style."

"He doesn't hit a lot of smashes. There are instances when we keep watching his matches hoping he will kill the shuttle, but he keeps playing those cross drops on both sides," the coach says.

On his personality, Chopda says, "He is introverted, but very systematic I'm guessing due to his upbringing."

• VOICE OF BRITISH ATHLETICS

35 years after picking up microphone, Hutchings still seeking moments to savour

Pritish Raj
New Delhi, October 16

TIM HUTCHINGS has been associated with track and field for more than five decades.

And he has donned many roles. Before being dubbed the 'Voice of British Athletics' for his presence as a commentator for more than 35 years, Tim had an athletics career where he won two silver medals at the Cross Country World Championships and finished fourth at the 1984 Olympics in 5000m.

However, the 67-year-old from Middlesex terms his transition to commentary as a lucky move. "It was natural but also very lucky. After my two silver at World Cross Country, I was running and doing commentary also due to injuries," Tim told *The Indian Express* on the sidelines of the upcoming Vedanta Delhi Half Marathon.

"I was an underling in my initial years. There were senior BBC commentators who I would observe on how they take notes, their voice modulation techniques, and their picturisation of the action on the track," said Tim. "By the time injuries started getting frequent, I was 32 and that is where I picked up the commentary with Eurosport asking me to do it for them."

In the first three years of his commentary stint, Tim's constant presence in the commentary box quickly made him a fan favourite. "I think I did a lot of commentary in the first three or four years of my career. It was like a crash course of commentary for me and that helped me in getting recognised as people had known me as an athlete," he said.

While the transition for Tim was natural, the 1986 Commonwealth Games medallist had to keep the balance of explaining track and field action to both audiences: the athletics nerds and the ones without any idea of the sport.

"I have run the track events and I know what it is to be there. But as a commentator, it was important for me to maintain that balance. I just use my common sense. I don't go overboard with technical explanations, nor do I simplify it. I just put performances in context and I think that is what works," said Tim.

Tim's experience as an athlete gives him the edge on analysing performances which can sometimes be baffling for a normal fan or a viewer. "I think my athletic experience gives me the licence to be critical or appreciative of certain moments on the track and field. I believe those are the moments which I put out for my viewers in the best way," Tim said.

Over the years, there have been iconic races, moments, storylines and wins for athletes across the globe. With sprints ending in seconds to marathons witnessing photo finishes, Tim labels emotions as a crucial part of the commentary business.



Hutchings won two silver medals at the Cross Country World Championships and finished fourth at 1984 Olympics in 5000m.

> **"Let's be honest, commentary is not about reading reports. It is about connecting the viewer to what is happening on the field. Emotions are part of the sport and as commentators, our job is to bring those emotions to our viewers"**
>
> **TIM HUTCHINGS**
> FORMER ATHLETE AND COMMENTATOR

"Let's be honest, commentary is not about reading reports. It is about connecting the viewer to what is happening on the field. Emotions are part of the sport and as commentators, our job is to bring those emotions to our viewers," said Tim. "I have had my moments where emotions came out really well and I think that is the key, to bring out the right amount of emotions for your viewer to connect."

Tim describes commentary as a 400m race. "If it's 400 metres, you don't start off the race screaming when the gun goes, you want to go through the gear and save your crescendo for that last straight," he said.

In a long career of 35 years, Tim has witnessed many great moments but his favourite one remains the 2000 Sydney Olympics 10000m final between Ethiopian long-distance legend Haile Gebrselassie and Kenyan great Paul Tergat.

"It was one hell of a race. If you go back and look at it, both guys are killing each other in the last few moments and that is the beauty of long-distance running. You can lead all the while and then someone comes and pips you on the finish line like Haile did that day," said Tim.

Tergat was leading the race throughout but in the last 100m, Gebrselassie found an extra gear to win the title by 0.09 seconds. Tim's description of the moment is hailed as one of the best pieces of athletics commentary. "They were knocking chunks out of each other over the last lap... the most astonishing battle side by side of two guys who refuse to lose," Tim had called 26 years ago in Sydney and still remembered it by heart.

• BRIEFLY



Rafael Jodar said frustrations boiled over after losing a point. REUTERS

Jodar apologises for swearing at ball kid at Shanghai Masters

RAFAEL JODAR apologised for swearing at a ball kid during his last-16 match at the Shanghai Masters, with the Spaniard saying that he could not control his emotions when frustrations boiled over. After losing a point in Wednesday's win over Dutchman Botic van de Zandschulp, Jodar angrily asked the ball kid to hand him his towel, swearing in Spanish. The chair umpire gave Jodar a code violation for unsportsmanlike conduct. Pinoargote then warned Jodar not to speak like that to ball kids when he argued with him over the violation. "I shouldn't have done that to the ball kid. It was my mistake. I respect a lot the ball kids and the umpires in all matches," Jodar told reporters after his quarter-final win over Casper Ruud. REUTERS

Sports ministry increases support

NATIONAL SPORTS Federations will be entitled to financial support of up to Rs 50 crore to organise international events, the Sports Ministry announced as it laid out the operational guidelines for the revised Scheme of Assistance to NSFs (ANFS). The funds earmarked for National Championships have been kept unchanged at Rs 90 lakh for high-priority disciplines (Rs 30 lakh each for senior, junior and sub-junior) and Rs 75 lakh for the priority and general disciplines (Rs 25 lakh each for senior, junior and sub-junior). For the international events, the NSFs were given up to Rs two crore under the existing guidelines. For athletes training abroad, the Ministry announced that $60 per day would be exempted from food bills that need to be submitted later. PTI

Martinez apologises for outburst

MANCHESTER UNITED defender Lisandro Martinez apologised for his criticism of the club's hierarchy, admitting his frustration "got the better" of him as he held talks with manager Michael Carrick and senior officials. "Today I met with the club's leadership and the manager," he said in an Instagram post. "It was a very positive conversation where we were able to exchange views and speak openly about what happened after Tuesday's game. The frustration of the defeat led me to express how I felt at a time and place that perhaps were not the right ones, and for that I want to apologise." He admitted his words had not reflected the unity required. "Our club is at its best when we are all united, and I recognise that my words in that moment did not come up with that," he said. ENS

Suhas makes winning start at Para Asiad

TWO-TIME Paralympics silver-medallist shuttler Suhas Yathiraj started his Asian Para Games campaign with a resounding straight-game win over Bangladesh's Joytu Dhar in the men's singles SL4 Group E match here on Friday. Suhas, an IAS officer who won silver medals in Tokyo and Paris Paralympics besides gold in the last Asian Para Games, defeated Dhar 21-8 21-11. Also winning in the men's singles SL4 category was Abhijeet Sakhuja, who beat Chinese Taipei's En-chuan Yeh 21-17 21-12. SL4 is a standing sport class in para badminton for athletes with lower-limb impairments. Tokyo Olympics gold-medallist Krishna Nagar also made a positive start, defeating Chinese Taipei's Jia-siang Ling 21-5 21-4 in his opening men's singles SH6 Group C match. PTI

Equestrian federation suspended

THE INTERNATIONAL Equestrian Federation (FEI) has decided to suspend the Equestrian Federation of India (EFI) from December 1, a move that bars Indian riders, officials, trainers and horses from participating in international competitions during the period of suspension. In a letter dated October 15 the FEI said, "Further to the FEI Board online meeting of 13 October 2026, please kindly note that the FEI Board decided to suspend the Equestrian Federation of India, with the suspension taking effect on 1 December 2026," the letter, a copy of which is in the possession of PTI, stated. The FEI said the dissolution of EFI's executive committee by the Delhi High Court in February, combined with the absence of fresh elections, had resulted in a prolonged governance crisis. PTI

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